motion sickness

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motion sickness

by FingerCracc

Summary

“Finish the story,” Phainon prompts, and it comes out kind of quiet, kind of weird.

“He fell in love with a warrior in Okhema,” Mydei tells him, sliding a hand under his pillow. “They were equals in just about everything, and that’s… significant to a Kremnoan. He died sacrificing himself to buy that warrior time to save the city.”

“That sounds like something a hero would do to me.”

“Maybe,” Mydei grumbles. “A real hero wouldn’t leave the one he loves to fight alone.”

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On a trip to see his sick sister, Phainon realizes a few things. Foremost of these: through it all, Mydei has never once left his side.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Grief and death are going to be pretty prominent themes (we're digging into phainon's trauma with this one :D) that said, I don't think this fic will be too sad, hugs WILL be received when needed.
>
> if you're ever curious what they're listening to on the journey, I made a playlist for this fic.

The shower in their apartment makes this sound like the pipes are groaning. Sometimes the walls seem to shake with it. Rumbling plumbing, the scream of a loose washer in the faucet, and then the hiss of water running. These are the sounds Mydei wakes up to, too hot and swaddled in sheets that are due for a wash. He kicks them off and rolls onto his back, peeling his eyes open to stare at his hideous popcorn ceiling and listen to Phainon shower.

Four months into this life, he doesn't know why he doesn't regret it.

As he peels himself out of bed, Phainon starts to sing. His voice is thin and muffled through the walls; Mydei doesn't recognize the song.

When he gets to the kitchen, he smells the remains of three charred eggs before he finds them in the trash. There's a crusty pan left to soak in the sink, crumbs all over the counter, and a small puddle on the ground that Mydei steps in whilst trying to fill a glass of water. He curses and drops a towel, mopping it up with his foot, making a mental note to make Phainon come back and clean the kitchen properly.

Later, with a protein shake and two pieces of toast with honey butter, Mydei hears the bathroom door open, Phainon's bedroom door shut. The pipes have stopped screaming. Mydei takes a sip. A little longer, the door clicks open again. Phainon comes out, dressed in black sweats and a polo, hair still wet and limply lying atop his head.

"Mydei," he says, smiling a little. Something in his eyes isn't right. "Good morning."

Why do you seem sad? Mydei wonders. Out loud, he says, "What's wrong with you?"

Phainon only blinks. "Nothing in particular," he says, wetting his lips, shifting from foot to foot, bagel printed socks on scuffed faux hardwood laminate. "Listen, Mydei, I'm going to be gone for a week or so, visiting my sister. I'm almost done packing, so I'm—"

"Visiting your sister," Mydei interrupts. "Since when? Are you flying?"

Now, he avoids eye contact, gaze tracing the pictures lining their walls, friends and family, inoffensive blue paint. “Driving,” he answers, lingering on a photo of himself and Cyrene, him in his graduation gown, her in a knee-length pink and white dress. They’re leaning into each other, and Phainon’s smile is big enough to split his face in half. The slightest twitch in his brows. “It was an impromptu decision, I’d have told you earlier if it was planned, of course. But I’m leaving in an hour and I—”

“She lives across the country,” Mydei reminds him. “It’s like a thirty hour drive. Were you planning on taking your car? Do you have somewhere booked to stop for the night? Are you even—”

“Okay!” Phainon says, holding up his hands. “I’m totally unprepared, I get it. It’ll suck, but I’ll sleep in the car. And you know Chartonus worked on it a little while ago; it’ll survive the trip. I’ll knock it out in two days, and—”

“You are not driving for fifteen hours each day, you idiot, you’ll—”

“Can you stop interrupting me?” His voice raises. His next exhale comes out shaky. Mydei goes quiet, a little shocked by his reaction and trying to hide it by leaning back on their brown, second hand upholstery couch, propping his chin on his hand, raising an eyebrow in expectation. Phainon continues, wet hair and all. “Have a little faith in me to not get myself killed, please. I’ll take breaks, and if I need to I’ll stop early. I’m not… I’m not that much of an idiot, okay?”

Mydei holds his gaze. After a breath, he sighs, makes this decision before he has time to decide if he’ll regret it or not. He will, but he won’t. Most things with Phainon are like that. “Alright,” he says. “Are you already packed? Give me a minute.”

“Give you—” Phainon blinks. “What?” And then he’s tailing Mydei back to his room like a stray dog in his stupid socks with his stupid face, and Mydei just—

“We’re taking my car; yours is going to get us killed,” he says, rolling his closet open and pulling down the duffle bag he has stuffed up there. It’s hot pink and nearly torn at one of the straps, but he’s had it since high school. A week long summer camp in the mountains with a couple dozen other boys. The first time he followed Phainon on some stupid journey.

And there he is, standing in the doorway, a hand on either side of the frame, brows slightly furrowed. He inhales, lips parting, and Mydei looks away in favor of pulling a few shirts off their hangers and tossing them onto his bed.

“Mydei,” Phainon says.

“Go finish your shit,” Mydei replies. A laugh or a puff of air. In his peripheral, Phainon leans his head against the doorframe.

“I can’t decide if I should be upset that you don’t think I can go on my own or flattered that you’d drop everything to come with.”

And yet, it still seems he doesn't have a clue. This isn't the first time Mydei has thrown everything else to the wind to follow him to the ends of the earth. It probably won't be the last. "Not that second one," he says, reaching for pants next. "Maybe I want to see Cyrene too."

The pause between them stretches a little too long. When Mydei looks, Phainon's expression is complicated. Still a little pinched until it softens and he sighs again. "Alright, if you're sure," he says. "It'll be nice not to be the one driving the whole time at least."

"I'm sure," Mydei says, arms full of fabric. He shoos Phainon out.

△

In the next hour, Mydei packs, forces Phainon to clean the kitchen, argues quite a bit, and books a hotel for each night they'll be driving because he has no interest in sleeping in his car after sitting in it for ten hours straight. Phainon sits cross-legged on the couch with a rolling carry-on in front of him and his phone open to a map by his thigh. There's a sleeve of crackers in one of his hands and a can of spray cheese in the other. He's dressed the same as he had been—that is to say terribly—and he's clearly upset. Mydei pays him no heed as he draws a frowny face with angry eyebrows on a cracker.

"Did you pack your toothbrush?" he asks. Phainon makes a face, hair dried and sticking up atop his head.

"Yes, mom," he says.

"Extra socks? A jacket in case it gets cold? Deodorant?"

"I'm not completely helpless, Mydeimos." Phainon looks at him tiredly. Not annoyed, not quite, not really. It's something else, like he's pretending. Mydei exhales.

"Alright," he says. "We can go whenever you're ready."

Phainon pushes the frowning cracker into his mouth and puts the cap back on the cheese. He brushes past as he gets up to put the food away, and then he rustles around in their tiny kitchen before he comes out with a paper grocery bag in arms. He sets it on the couch and disappears, skidding in his bagel socks down the hall. Mydei hooks a finger on the edge of the bag to pull it down. Chips, a box of protein bars, cookies, licorice, fruit leather… It's stuffed with junk food for the ride. He slips into the kitchen himself to pack a cooler. As he zips it up, the floor creaks, and there's Phainon leaning against the stove, a tote bag on his shoulder and gray slip on sneakers on his feet. The bagel socks peek out from under them.

"Let's go," he says coolly. One side of his collar sticks up.

Mydei straightens up, taking the cooler with him, filled to the brim with drinks and all the fresh fruit and veggies from the fridge that might go bad while they're gone. He pauses in front of Phainon to fix his stupid polo, hearing his breath, nearly skimming his fingers over the sun tattoo he got in college, backing away before his face has a chance to heat. "Come on, then," he says. "I bet you can't carry all your shit in one trip."

Phainon scoffs, and that's how they end up stumbling down three flights of stairs with their arms full, all but racing each other, each of them almost tripping as they take their turns too fast. But Phainon has never made Mydei smart. He brings out his best and his worst. Weakness and strength. Fondness and frustration.

"I win," Phainon pants as they stagger to Mydei's butter yellow hatchback. His carry-on clacks as he sets it down, the snack bag on his hip crinkling as Mydei shifts his duffle to the same hand as the cooler to open the trunk.

"Win what?" Mydei asks, hefting the cooler into the car and shoving it into one corner to make room for the rest of their stuff.

"The bet," Phainon answers.

Despite him, Mydei's mouth twitches upward. "Where's your phone?"

Bewildered, Phainon pats his pockets, comes up empty. "You're kidding," he says. "You did this?"

"You left it on the couch," Mydei laughs. "I just didn't say anything." He puts his duffle in next. Phainon sets the snacks down and storms back to their apartment. Mydei just chuckles again as he finishes loading everything in the car, leaving the snacks and a couple of waters between the seats in the back so they won't have to pull over to get to them.

He leans against the car as he waits for Phainon to come back. Listens to the wind sift through the trees and wonders what he's doing, following Phainon at the drop of a hat again and again and again. He has the next two days off, but he sends a quick email to work saying there's been an emergency and he'll be out. An emergency. Laughable.

Phainon comes jogging down the creaking metal steps leading up to their landing, Phone in one hand, middle finger flipped up on the other. Mydei barks a laugh. "Get in, fucker," he says, slipping around to the driver's side. His car is hot from the sun and stinking of the lemon scented air freshener dangling from the rear view mirror. Phainon slides into the passenger seat. "We have to stop for gas," Mydei tells him.

"Figured," Phainon says. He buckles his seatbelt and digs around the center console until he finds the right cord. "I call aux."

"Who won the bet?"

"You never set stakes, Mydei. That's on you."

"Shut the fuck up."

△

Phainon has a strange taste in music. Kpop girl groups, old folk music, and musical soundtracks take the forefront. Most of it is bearable, some of it could even be considered good, and everything else—everything he plays for Mydei, that is—is the most god awful, ear splitting stuff known to man. He does it on purpose, obviously, gleefully tapping his foot

and his fingers on the back of his phone in his lap. Mydei's burnt orange aux cord connects it, spelling his doom. He takes a big inhale, palms sliding down the steering wheel, thumbnails digging into the leather, and merges onto the freeway.

One song passes, two, three. Phainon leans all the way back, head tipping against the seat like he's trying to look through the sunroof. And then he lets out this little huff. A moment later, the song changes to something palatable, something Mydei may have mentioned liking at one point. Something soft, a girl with beautiful vocals and beautiful lyrics to match.

"You let me get away with too much," Phainon tells him.

Mydei spares him a glance. The line of his jaw, choker, collar. Higher, one ice blue eye, white hair that stirs slightly in the breeze from the air conditioning. Mydei turns back to the road. "I find that the more I complain the worse it gets," he says. "You like the reaction."

A half laugh. "Figured me out," Phainon says. His fingers are still tapping. His phone case, blue and orange in halves, a beach scene. "When you just sit there and suffer like that, I feel bad for you."

Silence. Another verse, another chorus. Mydei gets over to pass a semi truck. "Why now?" he decides to ask. Cyrene is probably Phainon's most important person. The only family he has left. They call every other week, text at least three times as often. He visits twice a year, but those trips are always planned months in advance. He's never just up and *gone* like this.

Another glance, brief. Phainon's lips part. Ahead, a car attempts to merge without signaling. He's quiet for too long.

"I… missed her," Phainon says. "I wanna see her while I can."

Mydei chews on the inside of his cheek. He's reminded of the way Phainon is overly wary of candles, a bit more frugal than he needs to be. "You're not just going to up and go broke one day, Phainon."

This too earns a laugh, though it shouldn't. "That's not something you can promise," Phainon says, sardonic. "Not in this economy."

It's true. Neither of them lives paycheck to paycheck, but their bills seem to get a bit bigger every time they have to pay them. If something went south, it wouldn't take long at all for Phainon to burn through his meager savings. Same for Mydei. "You have people you could fall back on," he points out.

"Who, Cyrene?" Phainon asks. It comes out almost bitter. "Maybe an uncle I've only spoken to a couple of times?" The song fades out as it ends. It's a handful of seconds before the next plays. A little softer, a little slower. A voice clear as glass and an acoustic guitar. As it would turn out, a song Mydei showed Phainon. "Can you imagine that? 'Hey, you remember when I was this tall, right?" He waves his hand about level with his stomach. "'But now that I'm *this* tall—'" He passes a hand over the top of his head. Mydei gives him half a glance and scoffs. "'—I'm a bit strapped for cash. You think you could help a nephew out?'"

“You’re an idiot,” Mydei says. He checks his rear-view mirror. A flash of yellow. He checks a second time and reaches over to punch Phainon firm in the arm. “Slug bug.”

“Ow— what?” Phainon clutches his arm to his chest, then checks every which way in search of the car.

“Behind,” Mydei directs him. Phainon twists in his seat to look, and then laughs.

“God,” he says, settling back into his spot, still rubbing his arm like it hurts. Mydei didn’t even hit that hard. Phainon takes much worse from him when they spar and gets right back up after. He once chipped a tooth on the floor in high school because Mydei punched him so hard, only to keep fighting like it was nothing. “I haven’t seen one of those in forever.”

“Double points, then?” Mydei asks, making like he’s going to punch Phainon again. He gets a fist bump for his troubles, and then Phainon shoves his hand away.

“I hate you,” he says, but he’s smiling when Mydei checks. Silence falls between them. Just the sound of the road and the chorus of this song that they both like. Hours to go. Between the heat of the car and the uncomfortable feeling in his chest, Mydei starts to sweat.

A little longer, he tests his tongue against the points of his teeth. “I’d help out,” he says, clearing his throat. “If worse came to worst.”

Phainon’s fingernails against his phone case. He reaches for the drink he’d gotten from the gas station—lemonade, the kind in a glass bottle—and screws off the cap. “I appreciate that,” he says softly, just when Mydei is expecting another joke to punish him for trying to be serious. But this time, Phainon meets him in kind. “I would too, if it were you.”

Face warming, Mydei grunts. The lid clinks at Phainon returns it to the glass bottle. He puts it back in the cup holder and says, “But hopefully it never comes to that for either of us.”

△

Phainon goes quiet after a point. He leaves one of his more inoffensive playlists on shuffle and takes to leaning against the window, cheek propped on his fist, eyes shut, expression smooth.

He has an interesting sort of face. If he were an entirely different person who wore it, he could make himself look like an asshole just by breathing, or paint a convincing picture of the collected, stoic type. As it is, Phainon wears his heart on his sleeve. He feels so many things, so obviously. He reminds Mydei of a goddamned dog. He so rarely looks like this. Something just off from peaceful, a step too strained to be relaxed, somehow expressionless all the same. Mydei turns his gaze back to the road.

They’re three hours in at this point. His car has burned through a third of its gas tank. They’ve crossed the first of five state lines along the way. Phainon’s eyes are still closed.

One year, when Cyrene was spending the holidays with her partner at the time, Mydei took Phainon to his home so he wouldn’t be alone. On arrival, his mother had taken Phainon by

the chin and tipped him this way and that, seeing how he'd grown up, how he'd lost the baby fat and the acne, how his hair was still unruly as ever, how he'd gotten that stupid sun tattooed on his neck. *A strong placement,* she'd said later, because the more a tattoo hurts the more worthy it's wearer is to Mydei's dying culture. *He grew up beautiful,* she'd said just to Mydei, because it wasn't the first time she'd met Phainon, but it was the first time since he was an awkward teen coming over after school to play games.

Mydei still thinks about that. He shouldn't, but he does. Glances at Phainon every now and then and remembers his chin in his mother's hand. The panic in his eyes as he was helpless to do anything but comply with her scrutiny. His embarrassment and bewilderment later, tucked up in Mydei's childhood bedroom, rubbing his own jaw, the tiny pinpricks of stubble there, because he can't grow a beard but these tiny patches under his jaw always try anyway.

He remembers that, Phainon's stupid expressive face, and he remembers his mother calling him beautiful. Over and over he hears it, until sometimes he looks at Phainon and wonders if she's right.

An inhale, like the first upon waking, but he knows Phainon was never asleep. His fingers were still tapping to the beat. He struggles to sleep anywhere but a bed anyway, and even then, sometimes he's lying awake for a long time before he gets anywhere close. Mydei has woken up too many times to the hollow sound of their faux hardwood as Phainon paces to have something to do with himself.

"Do you want to swap?" Phainon asks. "You've been driving for a while." He flips his phone face up, clicks the power button to check the time. "Are you tired yet?"

"I guess my ass is getting numb," Mydei concedes. His shoulder is aching too; old injury or unconscious tensing. He isn't dumb enough to turn this into one of their competitions. He'll fuck around with his safety, but not everyone else's. "We can stop for lunch, and then you can take a turn."

Phainon pulls up his maps and asks, "Where to, Your Highness?"

"Shut up," Mydei tells him. "Somewhere cheap."

△

Between the two of them, Mydei is the better driver. It isn't that Phainon is bad, but he has a habit of taking turns too fast and getting confused by his own directions. He's never been in a crash, and he's never been more than five minutes late from taking the wrong route, but Mydei is better. He's steady, calm, stable. Nothing on the road scares him. He never gets lost. Sometimes he makes Phainon a tired, aching sort of envious.

They stopped in the middle of nowhere for gas station pizza and a piss, and now they're on the road again. Phainon is at the wheel, and he realizes after pressing on the brake and scaring himself with how sensitive it is, that this is the first time he's ever driven Mydei's car.

"Don't crash it," Mydei warns him. It isn't a nice car by any means. Mydei bought it off a cousin in his last year of high school, but he's taken good care of it since. It's nicer than

Phainon's by a long shot. And yet, he didn't even need to adjust the seat. All it means is that he and Mydei are the same height. For some strange reason, it gives him an odd, almost possessive feeling. It's a goddamn car.

"No guarantees," he laughs. "Just try to be nice to me while your life is in my hands."

"Shut up." Mydei takes the aux; his turn now that he's in the passenger seat. He likes old rock and pop ballads, and doesn't particularly care what language they come in. This first song he plays sounds like it might be in Chinese. "Try to kill me and you'll just kill yourself too."

"Maybe I'll only crash on your side," Phainon retorts.

A scoff. "And then the momentum will turn the car and your side will get hit too, dumbass."

He hums, tapping the steering wheel. It's leather, shiny and soft, part of it pocked with dents where Mydei usually rests his thumbs. He must dig his nail in as he drives. Phainon's never noticed. "Not if I get the speed and the angle just right."

"You know dogshit about physics, don't give me that," Mydei tells him, so he laughs again and gives up this line of conversation. There's a hollow feeling in his stomach. Sticky like sap covered hands run through dirt. Earthworms and wheatgrass. The stink of old fire.

"I'd never kill you anyway," Phainon jokes. Tries to joke; it comes out too sincere. He'll make Mydei gag. To save it, he adds, "Who would pay the other half of my rent?"

"You know that conversation we had earlier about how I'd help if things went downhill for you financially?" Mydei asks him, scrolling absently through his phone. "I take it back, since it's pretty obvious I'm being used."

Fields and fields of nothing. A long, empty stretch of road. Phainon is going over a hundred miles an hour without realizing. He eases his foot off the gas. "Wasn't it your car getting crashed in this scenario? Doesn't that make you the broke one?"

"That would make me dead," Mydei says. "And you as well. You're just fucking dumb."

Phainon laughs, then pretends to be offended. "I feel like you used to be nice to me."

"And you're wrong about that too."

"Hah…" Phainon takes a breath. It comes out as a sigh. He's still… he doesn't know. He wants to see his sister.

"Phainon." He must take too long to reply. Must show something in his face. Mydei hardly ever calls him by name. "You've been weird all day."

"I know," Phainon admits. That pit in his stomach. Like sand slipping through fingers. Rocks on the beach. He wishes he were better at pretending, but he's not. He doesn't want to be watched as he crumbles. "You don't need to worry about me."

“Wasn’t planning on it,” Mydei tells him. A lie. He’s probably worrying right now, but Phainon doesn’t have the words to make him stop. Not when he can’t figure out how to stop himself.

“I should’ve figured,” Phainon says. “You’ve never done nice things like that for me anyway.”

△

It’s a joke, and it’s funny because Mydei does loads of nice things for Phainon. Not with his words, rarely with his words, but he’s… very nice, actually. He drives Phainon home when he’s drunk. He cooks meals for him without being asked, he takes over chores when Phainon doesn’t feel well. Sometimes the things he says make it seem like he’s a bad friend, but his actions make it seem like *“how can I make life easier for Phainon?”* is a question that runs through his head daily.

He always asks if Phainon needs anything when he goes to the store and doesn’t ask to be repaid if he picks something up. He picks outfits when Phainon is going somewhere important, like a date or an interview or a party. He shares his own things—clothes, food, skincare, workout routines—and doesn’t act entitled to Phainon’s in return. He never asks for anything in return ever, really. Strange.

The rumble of the road. Mydei put rock on a few songs ago, but he plays it pretty quietly. They’re both starting to get sick of listening to so much music, but they’re barely halfway through their drive for today and it feels wrong to drive in silence. Mydei would probably disagree, but he’s better at focusing on one thing than Phainon will ever be. Phainon always needs background noise, movement, touch, *something.* He’s… A glance at Mydei. Why is he *here?*

He’s never tagged along on Phainon’s visits before. He hasn’t seen Cyrene since they were all in high school. And yet, here he is, donating his car, his paid leave, his time to the cause. He… Maybe he just wanted to get out for a while.

“Do you need to swap?” Mydei asks out of the blue.

Phainon kind of flinches. “What? No, it hasn’t even been two hours. You drove like three and a half.”

“You’re restless,” Mydei points out. Phainon’s free leg is bouncing, and it isn’t even in time with the music. He stills it. “This isn’t a competition, don’t be stupid. If you need to swap, we can swap.”

The road is straight and basically empty. Phainon has enough presence of mind to drive, he’s just… thinking. Overthinking. But he’s not distracted, not dangerous. “I’m fine, Mydeimos,” he says. “Just… have stuff on my mind.” Mydei just grunts, shifts in his seat to pull a leg under him. Phainon’s knee is bouncing again. “Seriously. Talk to me if you’re so worried. My brain is just going a mile a minute.”

A low hum. “What are you thinking about?”

Phainon opens his mouth. Exhales. Gets over to pass as he approaches a car going quite a bit slower than he is. “I don’t know,” he says, because saying *you* would be super weird. “I was kind of… wondering why you’re here.” That never ending pit in his stomach. The words of a phone call playing on repeat. Over and over. The mind is a prison. *Stop thinking about it.*

“That’s what has you chewing up the inside of your cheek?” Mydei asks. Phainon relaxes his jaw, not having noticed he was doing that. His tongue traces the sores he’s made. “I’m due for a vacation anyway. And even if I haven’t seen Cyrene in years, I know she’s cool. She’s your *sister,* idiot, why are you shitting your pants?”

“I—” His throat tightens. Helpless, Phainon swallows, clears it. “I’m not,” he says. “You’re really just coming along to see her?”

Mydei makes an indignant sound and pulls Phainon’s empty lemonade bottle out of the cup holder so he has something to brandish. His gaze could light something on fire. “Are you seriously asking if I have bad intentions with your sister? Your *sister,* Phainon?”

“No!” Phainon exclaims. “No, what the hell? Why is that even where your mind went? Maybe you really do— Ow!” Mydei pinches the meat of his upper arm and huffs, sitting back. The lemonade bottle clinks as he puts it back. Phainon lifts his other hand from the steering wheel to rub the spot. “What was that for?”

“Being an idiot,” Mydei answers. “Eyes on the road.”

Phainon turns back to the road, huffing. Still, a lump in his throat. “You suck and I hate you,” he says, anything but sincerely, and Mydei barks a laugh and crosses his arms over his chest.

“Sure,” he says. “That’s why we’re taking my car and splitting the costs of this trip. Because I suck and you hate me.”

“True,” Phainon says, nodding, trying to smile. He pulls the inside of his cheek between his teeth again, and it’s already sore. That fucking hollow feeling. A thistle in a flower garden. “Listen, Mydei. When we get there…” His words stumble to a halt. He wets his lips and takes too long to finish the thought.

“Cyrene probably doesn’t have room for me, does she? You know I can sleep pretty much anywhere, though. I don’t mind the couch.”

“No, that’s… Why would you be on the couch? You can just share with me. But that’s beside the point. I was trying to say that… well…”

“Yes?”

A lump in his throat. Insurmountable. Phainon swallows and his Adam’s apple rolls against his choker. “You’ll have to cook for us,” he says. “Cyrene’s just as hopeless in the kitchen as I am.”

Mydei laughs through his nose. In the corner of Phainon’s eye, his hair slips free from behind his ear, shines slightly in the sun as he shakes his head. “Why am I not surprised at all?”

△

They check into the hotel just past nine. It isn't fancy or particularly nice, but it's quiet, passably clean, and air conditioned. After all that driving, Phainon is glad to be anywhere but the inside of the car. Mydei was right about getting a hotel.

The room is tiny, with a little cubby in the wall by the entryway that houses a coffee maker and supplies to go with it, a bottle of water, and two glasses. Below that is a mini-fridge that he puts the dregs of a gas station cola in. Just past that, the bathroom, the rolling door to the closet. On the other side of the room is a desk with a single chair, and inside a little further is a dresser with a TV perched on top. Across from that, the bed. One, because it was a few hundred dollars cheaper than two. Phainon struggles out of his shoes as Mydei tosses his bag on the floor and pokes his head into the bathroom. Water runs as Phainon drops his shoes in the entryway, sighing as his feet can finally breathe.

"You can't steal the soaps," Mydei informs Phainon as he comes back out. "They're mounted to the shower wall."

Phainon rolls his bag next to Mydei's and sits heavily on the bed. He rubs his thumb between his eyebrows, eyes slipping shut. "Hah," he says, a bit weakly. "What a shame."

"Do you have a headache?" Mydei asks, taking the other side of the bed like breathing. He's closer to the window, Phainon the bathroom. It's one of the only arguments they've never had to have.

"A bit," Phainon admits. He can still hear the phantom of tires on the road. It feels like there's cotton in his ears. He should've just taken the red-eye and flown. "The sun was in my eyes for a while."

Mydei grunts and kicks off his shoes. When he sits, he pulls one leg up onto the bed, ankle under thigh. "Come on, then," he says, and his jeans are a bit wide legged, riding up to show the black band of his sock, half an inch of his shin. Phainon sighs and leans back, resting his head in the dip there, legs hanging off the bed. His collar flips up in the process. Mydei fixes it for him for the second time that day, and then presses his small knuckles into Phainon's temples, massaging a firm circle there.

As he does, Phainon looks up. The hotel light is a rather nauseating shade of yellow. It casts weird shadows on Mydei's face, tipped down, expression neutral. Phainon has always thought that Mydei has a unique face. No one can assign him a celebrity doppelganger. Something about the set of his eyes, the bridge of his nose, the shape of his jaw. He's a rare combination. Sometimes he wears makeup too, red eyeliner to match the red tattoos that cover most of his body. He's… no one really looks like him.

"How many times do I have to tell you not to stare at me while I do this?" Mydei asks, folding a hand over Phainon's eyes. He smells like hotel hand soap, and the thumb of one hand is rough and calloused from playing the guitar, same with the fingertips on the other. "It's like you're counting my nose hairs or something."

Phainon laughs a little, reaches up to pull Mydei's hand away. Maybe Phainon's fingers are cold, but his wrist is warm, heart thrumming beneath his touch. "All clear," he says, "I haven't noticed any."

Mydei chuckles. "Shut up," he says, and pretends to poke Phainon's eyes out until he laughs weakly and squeezes them closed. Behind them, his head throbs. He's so tired, body heavy. He goes quiet as Mydei rubs a firm line from his temples to his hairline and traces it a few times, pausing to rub circles into pressure points. Even if it's only temporary, the throb eases up as Mydei chases it away.

"You're oily," he comments after a while.

Phainon cracks his eyes open only to squint against the light. It burns red through his eyelids. "Shut up," he parrots. "When am I not?"

"Wash your face, fucker," Mydei tells him, but he still takes the care to do this right. Another nice thing he does for Phainon. He'll sit down after hard workdays or stressful interactions and work the pain out from behind Phainon's eyes. He says his mother did it for him as a kid, that she would pull him into her lap and massage his head while she told him stories and legends of the old Kremnoan warriors. People who built their culture on war. He's shared some of those stories with Phainon too. Men and women who wore tattoos and braids in their hair, who fought side by side with someone as an act of love, who taught their children to fight as they learned to walk. He hadn't taken kindly to Phainon comparing them to ancient Spartans. *They weren't violent,* he'd say. *They were protective. They showed love with their strength.*

Mydei probably does too. He's steady, calm, stable. Strong in a lot of ways. In body and in this. He makes a good rock. He's been anchored as long as Phainon can remember.

"Wash your mouth, Mydeimos," he says back. Mydei flicks him softly in the forehead.

"The light is in your eyes, isn't it?" he asks when Phainon flinches.

"Yeah," Phainon answers, so Mydei sighs and gently lifts his head to slide out from under him. He flicks the light off and turns on his bedside lamp instead. It's a soft, dull glow. Still yellow, but it doesn't hurt Phainon's eyes so much. He pushes himself up so Mydei can settle back into place, fingers carding through hair as he pushes it out of Phainon's face. They meet eyes, just for a moment, and Mydei looks almost as tired as Phainon feels. Still, "thanks," Phainon tells him, that lump crawling back up his throat.

And Mydei shrugs it off like he always does, averting his gaze and clearing his throat. "Whatever," he says, and probably goes red at the tips of his ears. Phainon can't tell in this light. He chuckles, and silence falls between them like a blanket of ash.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei wakes second, as he tends to. Phainon's side of the bed is vacant and rumpled, cold when he slides a hand through the sheets. The bathroom door is shut, but there's no sound of water running or the buzz of an electric toothbrush. Just silence.

Pushing the blankets off, Mydei sits up. A breath in turns into a yawn, and he stretches his arms over head. His eyes stay closed a little after he's done, clinging to the last bits of sleep before he wipes a crust from the corner of his eye and drags himself upright. As he digs through his stuff for his water bottle—a scratched, dented old thing lacquered red and covered in peeling stickers—the faucet runs, shuts off. The door creaks softly as Phainon pulls it open. The ends of his bangs are wet.

"Morning," he says, a little rough from sleep. He's still in his pajamas, so he can't have been awake for long. A blue t-shirt with a hole in the armpit and old basketball shorts. Mydei sits without a shirt, swishing a mouthful of water through his teeth. Groggy, he blinks, swallows.

"Morning," he rasps back. Phainon inhales.

"We're up a bit late," he says. "Breakfast is over in an hour, so we should probably get ready and head down."

Mydei grunts and leans forward to rest his elbows on his knees. He takes another sip, yawns again. Phainon steps out of the doorway and goes for his suitcase, turning it onto its side and unzipping it. He digs around a bit before he picks a set of clothes for the day. Gray cargo pants and a folded shirt in a suspiciously familiar shade of purple. As Phainon slips by, Mydei grabs his wrist.

"Do not wear that shirt," he says. Phainon blinks and looks down at the bundle of fabric in his hands.

"Didn't you buy it for me?" he asks.

Mydei winces. "You were never supposed to wear it. Not in public, at least."

Phainon huffs a laugh and unfolds the shirt to look at it. It's a frankly offensive shade of purple, with a giant fish emblazoned on the front. Behind it is a man with a fishing pole, the string along the top of the graphic and the hook in the fish's mouth. Around are some cartoon splashes, spreading out evenly above the bold, large printed words *Master Baiter.*

It was a gag gift. Or, was supposed to be, because Mydei had been on vacation in Alaska and Phainon unironically enjoys fishing. He thought it would get a couple laughs and be forever banished to pajama duty, but here it is, haunting him, just like the rest of Phainon's fashion sense.

“It’s funny, though,” Phainon protests. “What’s wrong with it?”

“Look at it,” Mydei says tiredly. “Literally just look at it.”

Phainon does. “It’s pretty bad,” he admits. “But it’s not like anyone is going to take it seriously. It’s a joke. People like jokes.”

“Okay,” Mydei says, snagging a plain brown muscle tee from his open duffle bag and pulling it on. “I’m not sitting with you at breakfast.”

“You’re so rude,” Phainon laughs, but he tosses the shirt back in his luggage and picks a new one—a Star Wars tee, the graphic cracked and fading. God knows how long it’s been since Phainon even saw the movies. He sits on his side of the bed, back to Mydei, and pulls off his pajama shirt to change. Mydei stays quiet, still looks at him. The hair curling around the nape of his neck, his shoulder blades, the dimples in his lower back. He has this mole a third of the way down his spine. Muscles he’s grown into since Mydei started dragging him to the gym. He pulls the shirt on.

“I hope you realize you’re only pushing it off,” Phainon continues, standing and hooking his thumbs in his waistband to change his pants. Now, Mydei looks away, finding his jeans in his bag, listening to fabric rustle as Phainon gets dressed. “I only packed so many shirts. I have to wear that one eventually.”

“You can wear it for Cyrene,” Mydei tells him, slipping into his pants and bending for fresh socks too. A yawn builds; he hides it in his hand as the bed creaks when Phainon sits back down. Back to back, they put on their socks.

“Maybe I will,” Phainon muses. “I’ll be sure to let her know it was a gift from you.”

“Goddamnit.” Maybe she’ll find it funny now. The Cyrene Mydei remembers was a bit of a prude, frowning when Mydei swore, scolding him for making inappropriate comments. He always worried he looked like a bad influence in her eyes, but she’d always been kind to him.

“Heh.” The mattress shifts. Phainon comes to his side, tossing his old clothes on top of his luggage. “Listen, Mydei…”

A glance at him. Dark circles under his eyes. Did he sleep? Mydei did. Blurry, dreamless. He remembers staring at Phainon’s shoulder under the blanket until his eyes fell closed on their own. It’s warmer with two bodies instead of one. “I’m listening.”

Phainon is quiet for a little longer. He swallows visibly, throat smooth and uninterrupted because he hasn’t put his choker on yet. Odd, it’s like seeing him naked. He curves a palm over his sun tattoo and averts his eyes. “I know,” he breathes. “I’m just having some trouble saying what I need to say.”

“I can see that in your face.” Phainon’s eyes meet his again. Ice blue, dilated because they never turned on the light. “Spit it out, HKS.” An old Kremnoan word. It’s meant as an insult, but it always comes out too soft when he uses it for Phainon. Too fond. Four months into a life right next to him, a decade into a life in his orbit, this is why Mydei can’t regret it.

A shaky breath. Phainon breaks eye contact. “I’ll tell you later,” he finally says, standing up and stuffing his feet into his shoes. “We’re going to miss breakfast.”

They won’t. Mydei stares after him. The slope of his shoulders, the hang of his head. The way his hand curls into his fist as he supports himself on the wall. “Phainon,” he says.

“I know,” Phainon says back. “I’m sorry. Let’s just go.”

△

Breakfast is probably powdered eggs, slightly soggy sausages, and roasted potatoes. Mydei mixes a plastic cup full of half apple, half cranberry juice from a dispenser, and Phainon makes himself a coffee with two sugars. It sits in front of him as he eats, steam curling off the surface. He hates coffee. That’s how Mydei knows he didn’t sleep well at all, but he doesn’t comment.

Instead, he busies himself with mapping the drive to the next hotel on his phone as he attempts to saw through his sausage one handed with the side of his fork. “Eight hours’ drive today,” he says. The meat slips, and his fork collides with the plate in a hideously loud sound. He sets down his phone to cut it properly.

“Better than yesterday,” Phainon notes, sliding Mydei’s phone over so he can look. He lowers the brightness first. Mydei spares him a glance. The dark circles. He’s a little pale too, isn’t he?

“Tomorrow’s the longest,” Mydei says. “Eleven hours and some change. Is your headache back?”

A snort. “More like it never left,” Phainon says. “I’m fine, though. Took some pain meds.”

Mydei purses his lips. Phainon isn’t even looking at him, too busy pinching and dragging the screen around, inspecting their route, a furrow between his eyebrows. “I’ll drive first,” Mydei says, extending his hand until Phainon passes the phone back. “Try to take a nap in the car or something.”

Phainon smiles wryly, lifting his paper coffee cup. “That defeats the point of the devil’s liquid, dear Mydeimos. I’ll be too awake by then.” He takes a sip to punctuate the statement, making a face and licking his teeth as he puts the cup down.

“So don’t drink it,” Mydei tells him, scraping eggs, potatoes, and a piece of sausage together into one bite. As he chews, Phainon mournfully shakes his head.

“I already got it,” he says, “and I’m not going to drink it cold. My mama didn’t raise me to waste food.” And it’s true, now that Mydei thinks about it. Phainon will sooner lick his plate clean and make himself sick than leave a few bites behind. He sighs and reaches for the cup. Phainon just watches. Mydei isn’t a fan of coffee either, but he downs the cup, swallowing it fast so he won’t have to taste it.

“There,” he says, bitter on the back of his tongue, ignoring the delighted incredulity alighting on Phainon’s face. “Now you can take a goddamned nap.”

“The things you do for me, Mydeimos,” Phainon laughs. “If you keep it up, people might start to think you’re *nice* to me.”

Mydei just crushes the paper cup and flips his middle finger toward Phainon, swallowing a mouthful of potato to wash the bitterness back.

Phainon laughs and goes quiet. “I’ll try, at least,” he says. “Thanks, Mydei.”

△

The beginning of the drive is quiet. They stop for gas again, and while Mydei pumps, Phainon goes inside to buy himself another lemonade—strawberry this time—and a pack of mini chocolate donuts. As they pile into the car, he offers one to Mydei, who wants to scold him but has too much of a sweet tooth to refuse. He chooses to say nothing, even as Phainon pulls up the map to direct him to the freeway entrance. As they climb up the ramp, he shuts his phone off and shoves it beneath his leg.

“Cruise here for another three hundred miles,” he says. “Let me know when you want to swap.”

Mydei just grunts in acknowledgment. The crinkle of plastic. Phainon extends the donuts to him again, and he spares a brief glance to take one. Only two are gone. Phainon took neither. This too, Mydei doesn’t comment on. “Try to sleep,” he reminds Phainon, stuck thinking of the shadows beneath his eyes, the exhaustion in his smile. Without looking, he opens the center console compartment and digs around until he finds his sunglasses. Plain black frames with orange polarized lenses. He holds them out.

A laugh, more air than sound. Phainon takes them. “Thanks,” he says, probably gearing up to add something stupid to punish Mydei for thinking of him, but he just inhales and leaves this weird little pause between them.

“Whatever,” Mydei tries to fill it.

And then, “You’re a good friend, Mydeimos,” Phainon tells him out of the blue. And he is. Mydei is a great friend to Phainon and they both know it, but they’re not supposed to say it out loud.

“And you’re fucking weird these days,” Mydei says back. “But… thanks, I guess.” In his peripheral, Phainon puts the glasses on and settles in, head against the back of the seat, arms crossed. His neck will hurt if he falls asleep like that. Mydei sucks the inside of his cheek between his teeth and wishes he didn’t care so much. But no, he doesn’t. Because he cares, and if he didn’t, who would? Phainon’s the type with a hundred friends but only a few who really know him. And Mydei has always fit best by his side anyway.

It’s silent but for the sounds of the road; they turned off the music about an hour away from the hotel the night before, since Phainon’s headache was brewing and neither one of them had

anything left to play. Mydei loves music, but it's easy to get sick off too much of it. Now, though, he turns the radio on at half the volume he'd listen to on his own and starts the air conditioning at the first setting.

Half a song plays, and Phainon stirs.

"You're supposed to be sleeping," Mydei points out as he plugs his phone into the aux and scrolls for a moment before selecting something.

"I know," Phainon says, tapping a bit more before he settles back again, phone in his lap, leaning against the window this time. His neck is at a better angle. God knows why Mydei notices. "I just needed to set the mood."

"Needed to make me listen to more shit, more like," Mydei retorts, though the opening chords of this song are a lot sweeter than what Phainon often plays for him. Two days in a row, he's chosen not to make Mydei suffer. What is there to say about that?

"Nah," Phainon says, probably shutting his eyes behind the glasses. He shifts a bit more, and when Mydei glances at him, he almost looks comfortable. "I think you'll like this one."

So Mydei stays quiet and listens to it. Acoustic guitar. The intro is tapped, and as the verse starts, it becomes clear that this song doesn't have any vocals. It's soft, until the chorus builds into something stronger, emotional, beautiful. The song is almost six minutes, but about halfway through he has to murmur, "I like it."

Phainon's lips curl up. "You could learn it."

"I'm not that good," Mydei scoffs.

"Not with that attitude," Phainon tells him, and his voice is a little soft, a little sleepy. "You're plenty good. Remember when you first started learning?"

"Sleep, Phainon," Mydei sighs.

"You talked to me first," Phainon says, because he always needs to be right. But he goes quiet, and maybe if Mydei drives for long enough, he'll fall asleep.

△

It's three hours before they swap. Phainon leaves a playlist full of acoustic instrumentals on, and sleeps a bit. When he does, it's fitful, shifting, sighing, but he doesn't fuss or complain. Sometimes he wakes and looks at the view or starts short conversations before he tries to fall asleep again. At the gas station, he stirs on his own, taking the sunglasses off and stepping out of the car to stretch, yawning, working a crick out of his neck. Mydei leans against the car, watches him, and breathes.

It's hot out, and the asphalt of the parking lot is cracked and tarred, cracked and tarred over again, the sun beating down like it wants to burn everything to a crisp, and Mydei just… Exhales. Tears his gaze away from the tuft of hair that sticks up atop Phainon's head.

“I’m going to run in and buy a coffee,” Phainon says once he’s finished his pandiculation. God knows if he really slept, but he looks like he feels better. The sun always does that, so long as it’s high overhead and not in Phainon’s eyes. He’s funny like that. He could probably photosynthesize if he weren’t so light sensitive, but his eyes were born blue. “Do you want anything?”

“I’m good,” Mydei says, and watches his back. He could go in too, at least to get out of the heat, but he doesn’t. He just stands, stretches out each of his stiff muscles in turn, and waits. On the road, cars pass by. Closer, a sedan pulls up to one of the gas pumps. A moment longer, he follows Phainon inside.

“Changed your mind?” Phainon asks, fitting a lid onto his coffee cup. The air conditioning in the store is bitter cold, but maybe Mydei has just grown used to the warmth. He likes road trips. He likes the smell in the air.

“No,” he replies.

Phainon scratches under his shirt. “Alright,” he says, and leads the way to the cashier. His cup makes a soft sound as he sets it down. The woman manning the counter offers a half-hearted smile as she rings him up.

“Are you still tired?” Mydei asks as they walk back to the car.

“A little,” Phainon admits. He gestures with the coffee. “I’m good to drive, though.” An awkward pause. He hesitates. They look at each other over the top of the car, him on the driver’s side. He hasn’t unlocked it yet. The door doesn’t budge when Mydei tests the handle. “Thanks for letting me rest.”

“You were dead on your feet.”

Phainon chuckles, a little weak. His dark circles are still there, but that sort of thing doesn’t go away fast. “Did no one ever teach you to say ‘you’re welcome?’”

“Unlock the car, dumbass.”

A dry smile. “Yeah, yeah.”

△

It’s a bit odd, playing passenger in his own car. Phainon drives a little faster than he does, always in the left lanes, ten or fifteen over instead of Mydei’s five. The leg that isn’t working the pedals is always bouncing, his fingers tapping out rhythms on the steering wheel. He’s a restless person in general, but ask him to focus on driving for hours and it’s glaringly obvious.

Mydei controls the music now, and he puts on some older rock classics. The beat Phainon taps matches to them; he’s infinitely distracted whenever there’s music playing, always listening to it no matter how loud or how quiet it is, no matter what he’s doing or who he’s

talking to. Not dangerously distracted, obviously, but he listens more than anyone else in the room.

“You know,” he says, still tapping, still bouncing his leg. He doesn’t even like this song much, it’s just that music infects him. “You can eat the rest of those donuts.”

Four left in the package, the chocolate coating a little bit muddy from sitting in the sun. Outside, they leave the city behind for a road winding into the mountains, all green, rustling trees and slabs of reddish rock. Sunlight on everything. The polarized glasses make Phainon look like some sort of bug. Mydei watches the leaves of aspens quiver in the wind, their trunks blurring by as they drive past.

“You haven’t had any,” he says. “Now they’re all melted.”

“Eh,” Phainon says in reply. “They were for you anyway. You can put them in the cooler if you want.”

“Then they’ll get wet,” Mydei points out. They’d filled the cooler with ice during one of their stops; it’ll be half-melted and soupy in there by now. All he gets is another noncommittal sound in reply, and then something makes him think it over again. *They were for you.* Weird. Phainon has been so fucking weird lately. “What do you mean they were for me?”

“Uh… Exactly what it sounds like.” The sound of Phainon’s palms sliding on the leather steering wheel. The road twists a bit, each stretch taking them a little further into what seems like the mouth of a canyon.

“I know that much,” he says. “I want to know *why?”*

“Why is that so accusatory?” Phainon asks, glancing over, bug-eyed instead of blue. Mydei’s reflection in orange lenses. “It’s not like I poisoned them or anything.”

“And suddenly I have my doubts.”

Phainon laughs. He has that kind of laugh you hear two rooms over. Like light through a crack in the curtains. Right in Mydei’s fucking eye.

“You haven’t had like, any snacks this whole trip,” Phainon says. “And I know sweets are your weakness, but you have too much self control unless they’re offered to you or about to be wasted. So. It’s not like I’m going to eat those donuts; they’re all melty and gross.”

Looking at him is like looking into a mirror just to find it’s been glass all along, and some loser on the other side is making faces. “What the fuck,” Mydei says. All he gets is another laugh and a hand blindly groping for a mushy pack of mini chocolate donuts and tossing them into his lap. Phainon’s other hand is still tapping. His leg is still bouncing. Mydei still can’t see his eyes.

△

Somewhere down the road, Mydei rolls down the windows. Maybe it’s a bad idea, considering how hot it is out, but the air is sweet and fresh and a handful of degrees cooler

when they crawl into the shade from one of the mountains. It's so green here, so colorful. They drive through slabs of rock cut for the road to go through, marbled with reds, browns, blues. They drive past forests and old, gnarled trees, wildflowers and rivers along their path.

It's beautiful. Phainon was raised with beaches and wheatfields, maybe that's why he's so awestruck by this. Mydei, when they first met so long ago, had been raised with forests and mountains. That's why he was so awestruck by the beach the first time Phainon took him.

The car jostles as he pulls it off the road and onto a wide gravel shoulder. The river roars now that they're stopped to hear it. Wind whisks in through the open windows and ruffles Mydei's bangs. He's tied the rest of his hair back, and it makes his face seem sharper, stronger. The slant of his eyes could cut, given the chance. He doesn't ask why Phainon pulled over, doesn't question it as he undoes his seatbelt and steps out of the car.

Gravel crunches underfoot. Two doors slam. Phainon walks around the car, and there's Mydei, grabbing him by the wrist and pulling him along a scarcely worn trail in the foliage flanking their drive, ignoring the way he stumbles over roots and rocks, tugging him out of the trees until the only sound is the river and the breeze is damp and almost cool enough to give him chills.

"This is what you wanted to see, isn't it?" Mydei asks, voice raised over the rush of the water over rocks. It's so fast, so loud, though the river itself can't be wider than a few yards. It's full of stones coated in algae and swept up sticks, the flow churning it to a froth as it rushes over them, light dancing in the shallow parts, the blissfully calm edges that Phainon can't help but stoop to dip his hand in. It's so much colder than he expected. He laughs, and then it cuts off in his throat. Cyrene would love to see this.

Phainon wraps his cold, wet hand around Mydei's exposed bicep, laughing again at the way he scowls and flinches. "It's freezing," he says, and Mydei flips him off. "No, seriously, feel it!"

So Mydei does, bending to touch the stillest part of the river, crystal clear and softly lapping at the muddy shore, digging out a palmful of tiny rocks the water has pained sunset orange or rich, glimmering gray. He tosses the pebbles back and turns to Phainon, the breeze stirring his hair again, the tips of his ears exposed to the sun dappled by tree leaves.

"Oh, no," Phainon says as he steps closer. His smile is killer. He could push Phainon in and Phainon would probably be okay with it, just to see him laugh a little. It's a curse, being willing to bleed out dry for the tiniest things. But this, perhaps, could be tantamount to a loss, and Phainon is still terribly competitive. He takes a step back, two. Mydei darts forward to smear a wet hand along the side of his neck, and he falls in by his own making, a single, critical misstep.

Or, he would have, but Mydei catches him by the shirt and hauls him upright, still cupping his neck, smile shifted into something like fear and annoyance at once. "Watch where you're walking," he scolds, and he's close because he's still holding on. "That's the type of shit that'll get you killed one day."

Phainon's belly sinks and soars in equal measure. "Your fault," he breathes, eyes wide, water rushing in his ears, soaking his left foot.

A scoff. His breath or a breeze. "Seriously?" Mydei asks, fist tightening in his shirt. He steps back, Phainon forward, and then he lets go completely. *Thump, thump, thump.* A heartbeat. The sound of water like static. Mydei turns his back, makes his way back to the car. Phainon's shoe is caked in mud. His shirt is all wrinkled. *Why are you here?* he thinks. *What is this?*

Mydei drives. Phainon takes off his shoe, wrings out his sock out the window, and apologizes for being an idiot. And somehow there it is, that laugh he'd tear apart worlds for.

"You are," Mydei agrees, "but you're right, though. That was partly my fault."

△

They stop for a meal that's too late to be lunch but too early to be dinner at an Indian restaurant. Phainon eats unreasonably cheap curry that both burns his mouth and makes him feel like moaning obscenely aloud for how good the flavor is. They argue about white rice versus brown rice, and then they're on the road again, Phainon at the wheel for this last stretch, shoe mostly dry, the sun hanging just barely too low to make driving westward even remotely comfortable. But It's in their eyes for only as long as it takes them to get gas and get lost in the town before they're back on the freeway heading East.

"How's your head?" Mydei asks, and his song of choice this time seems to be in Japanese this time. Piano and guitar, a man and a woman, a little bit soft.

"Good, surprisingly," Phainon answers. He's the type to get migraines at the drop of a hat, the slightest bit of heat, ten minutes of squinting, reading in the dark. Mydei always says it's because his eyes are so blue, but that can't be scientific, can it? His dad's eyes were the same, and he didn't suffer with any of this. "The sunglasses helped."

"Wear them tomorrow," Mydei says. Or, grunts it more than says it, because he's always like that.

"Alright," Phainon says. He's speeding again, ninety-five in a sixty-five, bouncing his leg to the beat. He eases his foot off the gas, sets cruise control at eighty just to be safe. The girl singing has a beautiful voice. He has no idea what she's singing about, but it sounds like nostalgia. A bit more sweet than sad. He might need this one for his playlist. "Thank you."

"Whatever," Mydei replies, because god forbid he says something like *you're welcome.* Phainon feels kind of happy, and then kind of guilty for feeling kind of happy. He laughs.

"You're the worst, you know that?" he says. His shoe is still damp, but he can't even fathom driving barefoot, so he'll suffer it with that squirming glow in his chest.

"I'm literally letting you use my sunglasses?" Mydei says incredulously.

“Yeah,” Phainon agrees, “but the way you reply to *thank you,* my God. It’s not going to kill you if you acknowledge that you make people feel cared about.”

He looks over. Mydei’s hair is still pulled back. The tip of his ear is red, or maybe that’s just the weird tint of the glasses. “Shut the fuck up,” is the only reply he can muster.

△

Their hotel tonight is a little run down, but it’s nice enough. The floors squeak, the room is small, and the air conditioner far too loud for how little cool air it produces, but the water pressure is surprisingly okay and the bed is neatly made and soft. The sun goes down. They eat fried chicken for dinner, despite Mydei’s complaints that they need at least *one* nutritional meal per day.

And then it’s dark outside and there’s not much left but the sound of cars out the window, the too loud a/c, his heart in his ears, the pit in his stomach now that the sun’s gone.

“Tell me a story, Mydei,” Phainon says a bit later, freshly showered and dressed in the same pajamas from last night. He packed two sets, one for each direction of the trip. For now it’s a t-shirt he’s had since the beginning of high school and some basketball shorts he’s always found a bit too breezy to wear in public.

His stomach feels full of rocks, so before he can sink under the weight of them, he asks for this.

Mydei looks up and clicks off his phone, bending to plug it in on the nightstand. He won rock, paper, scissors, so he got to shower first, but his hair is still damp, that little braid he wears by tradition undone. He sleeps without a shirt, but for now he has a loose tank top on as some semblance of modesty. “A story,” he repeats, rather dryly.

Phainon tosses his dirty clothes with the rest of his luggage and sits at the foot of the bed, falling back until his shoulders connect with the mattress and the frame creaks. “Yeah,” he says, staring at the ceiling, smooth and untextured and entirely uninteresting, so he looks at Mydei instead. “One of your ancient Kremnoan legends, or some crazy tale from youth, I don’t care.”

Mydei meets his gaze with a flat expression. “You were there all of my youth; what crazy tales would I have to tell that you haven’t already heard?”

“Fair enough,” Phainon concedes. “Option one, then.”

Mydei does this thing where he closes his eyes and sighs. When he opens them again, his gaze finds the spot where Phainon’s shirt has ridden up an inch, then his face. “Did I ever tell you about my namesake?” he asks, and it sounds like he’s admitting defeat. “Crown Prince Mydeimos?”

Phainon’s eyebrows climb his forehead. “You’re named after a prince?”

“A lot of people are named after legends if you trace the roots back,” Mydei tells him. “It’s nothing special.”

“Crown Prince Mydeimos,” Phainon echoes, rolling it on his tongue, propping his arms behind his head and turning to the ceiling again. A dim blue glow seeps out the top of the curtain rod. The window is on Mydei’s side, as it always is. Their view today is the side of another building and half a parking lot. “It has a nice ring to it. Crazy that sometimes I call you Your Highness.”

“Don’t start,” Mydei grumbles, stretching out a socked foot to kick his hip. Mydei, who sleeps in socks but not in shirts. This, unlike the side of the bed thing, is an argument they *have* had. “This is why I haven’t told you this one.”

“Sorry,” Phainon laughs, liking the light feeling it gives him, if only for a moment. And then he thinks of why they’re here, and the rocks settle again. “I’ll restrain myself. Tell me about this crown prince.”

Again, Mydei sighs. “He was destined to kill his father, so the king threw him in the River of Souls,” he starts, stretching his legs over Phainon’s stomach. “But he didn’t die like he was supposed to. He fought his way out and gained an immortal body, but for one weakness.”

“Like Achilles,” Phainon says. Mydei’s face pinches, as it does, when Phainon compares his legends to other things.

“Not like Achilles,” he protests. “Mydeimos wasn’t lovingly *dipped,* he was thrown in to die.” He pauses, then, daring Phainon to interject again. He doesn’t, just turns his face a little so he can watch Mydei speak.

Mydei swallows, Adam’s apple bobbing before he continues. “But he didn’t. He fought his way out, and killed his father as an act of justice.”

Phainon lays a hand on Mydei’s ankle, hooking a finger in his sock, taking a breath like it’ll fill the hole in his chest. *Listen,* he thinks. *Just listen to this. Don’t worry about anything else.* “Was it revenge?”

“Justice,” Mydei repeats. “Eurypon was a terrible king. He led to more bloodshed and suffering than any five Kremnoan kings combined, but that’s another story. Mydeimos had personal reasons to kill him, sure, but it wasn’t just revenge.”

“He was a hero, then?” Phainon asks.

Mydei laughs, a little gruff. “A hero?” he asks. “Not really. He led the Kremnoans to Okhema instead of taking the throne. He brought the fall of Kremnos.”

“Fall makes it sound like everyone died.”

A grunt. Mydei kicks him softly when he pulls his sock halfway down his ankle. “Quit that,” he says, so Phainon fixes his sock and pats him on the shin until he huffs and continues.

“Maybe he didn’t kill the people, but he killed the culture when he forced everyone to assimilate. That’s why I hesitate to call him a hero.”

“Oh,” Phainon says. “Maybe he thought he wouldn’t make a good king.”

Mydei shrugs. “Maybe.”

“So how’d he die?”

“That’s your question?”

Phainon huffs a laugh. “They always die at the end of your legends, Mydei. You can’t blame me.” Another kick. Mydei digs his heel into Phainon’s stomach until he shoves him off and bowls over, laughing and pained at once. “Mercy,” he wheezes. Again, that light, fleeting feeling. Mydei lets up, so Phainon rolls over to lay by his side rather than at his feet. The bed rocks and groans, and Mydei watches him the whole time. When his head hits the pillow, he turns on his side and meets his eyes. “Hi,” he says.

Mydei’s gaze flicks between his pupils, up to his still damp hair, down to the collar of his shirt. “Hi,” he says back, moving onto his side to mirror him, a little gravelly.

“Finish the story,” Phainon prompts, and it comes out kind of quiet, kind of weird. His heart climbs his throat to sit under his tongue.

“He fell in love with a warrior in Okhema,” Mydei tells him, sliding a hand under his pillow. “They were equals in just about everything, and that’s… significant to a Kremnoan. The old words they used for falling in love translate pretty close to ‘to meet one’s reflection’ and they actually used the word *equal* instead of husband or wife, it…”

“I like that,” Phainon murmurs.

Mydei looks away. “Anyway. He died sacrificing himself to buy that warrior time to save the city.”

“That sounds like something a hero would do to me.”

“Maybe,” Mydei grumbles. “A real hero wouldn’t leave the one he loves to fight alone.”

Phainon tries to laugh, but it’s all air. He can taste his own heartbeat. “Cut him some slack, Mydei, he was trying to save the world.” A shrug. “How’d he get killed, if he only had one weak spot?”

“Stabbed through the back,” Mydei replies. “Tenth thoracic vertebra.”

“Tenth thor— Where even is that?”

“Thoracic spine starts at the base of your neck. Just count the vertebrae down from there, it’s not that complicated,” Mydei tells him. He reaches out, shoves at Phainon’s shoulder. “Turn around,” he says.

“What are you doing?”

“Showing you, fucker,” Mydei answers, and presses a finger to the top knob of his spine when he complies. “One,” he says, and then drags his finger down to feel through his shirt. “Two.”

“That tickles,” Phainon says, squirming a little. Mydei blows on the back of his neck.

“Shut up. Three. Four,” Mydei continues. Here, the vertebrae don’t poke out so much, so he wiggles his finger into Phainon’s back to feel for them, ignoring the way he shakes with near laughter. “Five. Six. Seven. Eight. Nine.” He stops at the middle of Phainon’s back, pressing into the dip of his spine, thumb rubbing a circle into the right spot. “Ten.”

A shiver climbs up Phainon’s spine. “Alright,” he says. “There, then.”

“There,” Mydei agrees. A pause. His hand falls away. Phainon rolls onto his back, shoulder skimming Mydei’s chest, closer than he expected. He should have figured, with the breath on his neck, the nearness of his voice. That brush of contact is terribly warm. Neither of them bothers to move away.

“That warrior,” Phainon starts, eyes following the lines of his tattoos, climbing partway up his neck. “The Okheman one. What was his name?”

And Mydei looks back, amber gaze enough to pierce through metal. “I forget,” he says. “Probably something stupid, like *Phainon.”*

Chapter End Notes

small tidbit on my characterization: Mydei comes from a fairly wealthy family but he's very frugal and anticonsumeristic. Phainon's family Was comfortably middle class until their house burned down and his parents died. He and Cyrene share a trust with the death benefit and everything their parents left behind, but he refuses to spend a penny of it. Aside from that, he struggles a lot with saving money, but he tries his best. He just spends way more than he should on snacks

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Sometime, too early, three or four in the morning, the mattress squeaks and shifts, a door closes, a light flicks on and creeps under the gap at the base. It's negligible with his eyes closed, but Mydei cracks his eyes open and notices, and just the fact that he knows that bit of light is there makes it so he's irremediably disturbed. He can sleep through the sun rising and lighting the room enough to see, and he can nap midday with the lights on, but this… this is too much.

He waits a little while. If Phainon is just using the bathroom, it'll be no more than a handful of minutes before he comes back out and the light turns off again. For now, he turns his back to the light, tries to ignore it. He can make out silhouettes and shapes, bends in the curtains, the box of the heater. That tiny bit of illumination somehow spilling over it all. Shifting a little more, he pulls the comforter up so it blocks his eyes at the cost of stale air and too much warmth. This is better; he slips into a half sleep.

And then, for some reason, he wakes again. The light is still there, and Phainon is either taking a very difficult shit, jerking off, or doing some mysterious third thing that likely involves some measure of emotional distress and his weirdness from the last few days.

He gets nightmares. Mydei is well aware of this much.

Tiredly, he pushes the blanket off. Sits up. Rubs his eyes and then sits there with them closed for a solid five breaths, because there's nothing he'd rather do than go right back to sleep, but he doesn't. He pushes himself up to stand in front of the bathroom door and knocks twice with the second knuckle of his index finger. A moment, an inhale, the door cracks open.

"Did I wake you?" Phainon asks, tired eyed and caught between the light and the dark. Mydei winces against the brightness.

"You aren't sleeping," he grumbles.

The dregs of a smile. "When am I ever?"

Mydei grunts. "Turn that light off," he says, and shuffles back to bed, pulling the blankets back on Phainon's side. A moment passes, the light flicks off, but there's nothing else. When Mydei cranes his head to look, Phainon is just standing there, his silhouette a solitary blur in the dark. "Phainon."

Softly, "Alright." The bed creaks as Phainon settles back into place, lying face up, hands folded over his chest. His eyes might be open, Mydei can't tell in the dark. He reaches out and flicks Phainon in the shoulder.

“Why’re you up?” he asks, muffled into his pillow, hand softening but staying where it is, fingers hooking in Phainon’s sleeve.

“I don’t know,” Phainon answers. He’s warm where Mydei skims his arm. Living warm, so much body heat for someone who gets cold so easily. “I don’t want to be.”

He’s the type that will sleep seven hours when he gives himself nine. He takes a long time to fall asleep and is never able to sleep in, but he’ll at least stay in bed and *try.* Rarely does he give up and venture into another room to do… something. Every now and then, Mydei will wake to find him on the kitchen floor with a package of cookies and cat videos on his phone, but never has he seen him so… resigned to his sleeplessness.

Under the blanket, Phainon’s foot bounces, restless and creating this horrible hiss of fabric on skin, skin on fabric. Mydei yawns, half-asleep, body frustrated by disturbance after disturbance. He flicks Phainon again and mumbles, “Want the bed to yourself?”

“No,” Phainon says, catching his hand. “Where would you go?” Their room only has the one bed and they don’t have a sofa, just a desk with a stiff rolling chair and an out of place ottoman stuffed into the corner.

“Dunno,” Mydei murmurs, yawning again, prodding Phainon’s palm, his other arm sliding beneath his pillow. “The floor.”

“No,” Phainon says, spreading his fingers out, bending his fingertips over Mydei’s, though his fingers are only a fourth of an inch longer than Mydei’s at best. Mydei bats his hand away, and he chuckles. “I’ll survive.”

His foot is still bouncing. Mydei rolls onto his stomach, arms folding under his head, one of his legs sliding under the sheets to pin Phainon’s in place. “Stop that,” he says, and the sound cuts off. Phainon goes still, and Mydei shifts into a more comfortable position, bare arm against Phainon’s shoulder, leeching his body heat. He falls asleep through whatever Phainon says next.

△

Breakfast today is make-your-own waffles, soupy oatmeal, and dry hash browns that Phainon douses in ketchup while Mydei looks on in horror. It’s also decidedly the fated *Master Baiter* shirt day, because it was still on the top of Phainon’s luggage and he’d grabbed it first. He’s paired it with khaki shorts, black socks that climb a third of the way up his shins, and slip on sneakers, and he looks like someone’s embarrassing uncle. Mydei has long since learned when to pick this battle and when to let it go. Phainon isn’t going to a job interview or a date, and as it stands, they’ll be in the car most of the day, so Mydei stays quiet. But he has thoughts. Many of them.

“I take it you love the outfit?” Phainon asks when he stares a little too long. Whether he’s making a face over Phainon’s clothing choice or the sheer amount of ketchup on his potatoes is up in the air.

“I hate you,” Mydei says, and could almost be convinced to mean it. He stabs his fork through his waffle, but the plastic prongs bend too much for it to be satisfying.

“Your sunglasses will really top it off,” Phainon tells him.

“Do you do this on purpose?” Mydei asks. And he’d almost forgotten. They’ll probably see Cyrene today, and Phainon has chosen to dress like this.

“Well…”

Mydei flips him off, and he just smiles, laughs a little like he’s happy again, like whatever’s been wrong is okay right now, and Mydei bites his tongue and stirs brown sugar into his oatmeal.

“Are you excited to see your sister?” he asks.

“I…” In an instant, the smile fades. Mydei looks at him, really *looks*. “Yeah. Super excited.”

“Is she okay, Phainon?” he finally decides to ask. He isn’t clueless. The same day Phainon decides he needs to see his sister, he starts acting weird. Always a little bit sad, like he’s guilty of something when he smiles. “Did she get hurt or sick, or… I don’t know, heartbroken?”

Phainon lets loose this shaky exhale. “Am I that bad at hiding my emotions?” he asks.

“You are,” Mydei confirms. Phainon pushes the food around his plate. To their left, a family converses in Spanish. Everywhere else, people eating, talking, laughing. In the background, a song with too many synths plays. Phainon probably likes it. His knee bounces under the table.

“Sick,” he finally answers. “Acute Myeloid Leukemia, God knows how. It doesn’t run in our family. She’s always been perfectly healthy, she doesn’t have any risk factors, but—”

“Phainon.”

He stops. Exhales until his chest caves in. Helpless, his expression. He wets his lips. “Yeah.”

“It’s okay,” Mydei tells him. “I’m sorry.”

“I should’ve told you before,” Phainon offers, gaze falling to his plate, his fist around his fork. “But every time I open my mouth to say it, something stops me, like if I don’t say it out loud it doesn’t have to be real, and I know it doesn’t work that way but I— Fuck. Sorry. Are you upset with me?”

He’s all sad and teary eyed already. Much more of this and he’ll cry in public. Mydei’s chest squeezes tight, ties itself into knots. “Why would I be upset with you?”

“Because I didn’t tell you?” Phainon tries, blinking, sniffling, looking away. “She’s kind of your friend too, isn’t she?”

Mydei hasn't spoken to her in years. Every now and then, he'll pop in on Phainon's calls to contribute when she's bullying him, but that's about it. "She could've told me herself if that were true," he says. "It's okay, Phainon. It's not like you were trying to keep it a secret from me. I'm not the one that needs to be comforted right now."

Phainon opens his mouth, closes it, swallows. Swiftly, he draws a knuckle beneath his eye and says, "Alright. Well. Can we just finish breakfast?"

△

Back in the room, Mydei lets Phainon pack his things in silence. A handful of minutes pass like that. Phainon putting his still wet toothbrush in a bag, collecting his shaving kit and deodorant from the bathroom counter. He unplugs his phone charger and plucks his keys from the nightstand. And when he's finished shoving everything into his suitcase, zipping it up and setting it upright, wiping his hands on his shorts, Mydei pulls him into a hug.

"Really?" he says, voice wavering. Like muscle memory, his hands tangle in Mydei's shirt, face hiding against his shoulder. Mydei can smell the hotel shampoo in his hair. "Right when I've pulled myself together?"

"You would have started sobbing if I hugged you downstairs," Mydei tells him, rubbing his back, setting a hand on his head. Over the years, they've grown good at fitting together. Now, Phainon's the tiniest bit taller but he folds into Mydei like he's twice as small. Maybe the water here is softer, because his hair is too.

A fist hits his chest. Phainon shakes his head against him, hand smoothing out, winding around Mydei's neck. "I'm gonna start sobbing *now,"* he protests, and probably means it from the way his voice wavers.

Mydei exhales, running his knuckles down Phainon's spine, arm belting firm around his waist. White hair tickles his cheek. "Do you want me to cry with you?" he asks.

"Shut up," Phainon says, close enough to crawl into his chest, warm enough to be the sun Mydei orbits. His body shakes with his breath, but he still holds the tears back. Mydei doesn't tell him to let them out, just lets him stay like this as long as he wants. "Don't pity me."
"I don't," Mydei tells him. "But I'm not some asshole that's going to act like this doesn't fucking suck. Cancer has no business with her." She's too young. Mydei has never known anyone to get cancer that wasn't already retired with a slew of other health problems. Cyrene barely drinks, doesn't smoke, swims in races every other month and looks unreasonably photogenic in the photos Phainon shows him from her social media accounts. She'd been a healthy, energetic kid like the rest of them, so why her? Why anyone?

"Don't pity her either," Phainon mumbles into his shoulder. He squeezes tighter for a moment, so tight it hurts, and then relaxes in stages.

"Pity isn't right," Mydei says. "She's not some kicked dog. But this fucking sucks, and I'm going to say so."

Now, Phainon lets him go. One more breath in. He pinches the fabric of Mydei's shirt and uses it to dab the tears from his eyes, sniffling once more. "God, I need a tissue," he says, shoving Mydei back and turning away to find one in the bathroom. It's liquid and disgusting when he blows his nose, loud even from a room over. Mydei waits a little longer. The faucet turns on, water runs, and then it's silent. Phainon comes out with red rimmed eyes and the ends of his hair damp. He sets a hand on his suitcase, pressing the button on the handle to make it extend.

"Are you ready?" he asks, and his voice is mostly steady now. He looks high or allergic or miserable or all three, his hair a mess, dark circles still sitting like fingerprint stamps beneath his eyes. He makes more sense.

Mydei does a scan of the room to make sure he didn't forget anything and zips up his hot pink duffle bag. "Yeah," he says, and there's a pit in his stomach now too, whatever sensation Phainon must've been learning to live with. What are they going to see, when they get there? What kind of fear is Phainon going to have to face? He hinges to get the bag off the floor. "Let's go."

△

"I can drive first today," Phainon says after they check out of the hotel. The outside air is muggy and warm, the sky half cloudy and gray. It could rain. The air feels like it sticks in Mydei's lungs.

He fishes his keys out of his pocket and tosses them over. Phainon catches them, drops them, and catches them again before they can hit the ground. "That was impressive," Mydei tells him as he unlocks the car. They climb in. Their doors shut one after the other. It's unreasonably hot for how little sun the car has been getting. When Mydei looks, Phainon has been waiting with his middle finger up.

"Shut up," he says, starting the engine. When Mydei grins, he offers the other middle finger too. "Direct me."

"Left out of the exit," Mydei says, glancing at the directions on his phone. "Then right at the light." He reaches to turn the air on, and while he's thinking about it, takes the aux too. The volume is turned all the way down again. They keep listening until their ears are just about to bleed, and then give up with an hour to go. He picks a song without much thought. On cue, Phainon's fingers start to tap.

"What's the estimate for today?"

Mydei checks. "Eleven hours and thirteen minutes," he says. "We'll probably get there around midnight if we stop for lunch and dinner." Phainon licks his teeth and makes a face. He slows to turn at the light, and Mydei checks the directions again. "The freeway entrance is on the left," he says, so Phainon gets over.

"Do I have permission to speed?" he asks as he stops to wait for a turn light. The car in front of them has a custom license plate reading *404 GAS.* Mydei is ninety percent sure it's an electric model. He prays Phainon doesn't notice it.

“Since when do you ask for permission? I caught you going over a hundred at least twice yesterday.”

Bug-eyed in those orange sunglasses, Phainon looks over. Earnestly, he says, “I’ll set cruise control to seventy-five if you say no.”

Mydei just barks a laugh. “Whatever,” he says, “just try to keep it under ninety. I don’t want to get pulled over.”

“Highway patrol is a myth,” Phainon says, and eases off the break. They merge onto the freeway, and Phainon is already going eighty. He slides his hands over the steering wheel, producing the sound of leather on skin, switching to tapping his free foot instead of his fingers.

“You know I watched you get a speeding ticket a few months ago, right?”

“Yes, well…” Phainon pauses, wetting his lips. “Maybe I’m a myth too.”

“That’s not a comeback,” Mydei tells him. “What is that even supposed to *mean?”*

Phainon doesn’t reply. “What’s he singing about?” he asks instead, because of course half his mind is on the music. The chorus of this song has a drumbeat like drowning, overpowering everything else. Mydei’s never really thought about the lyrics before. He hesitates.

“Nothing happy,” he decides on. Phainon just hums, listening to the bridge of the song. As it transitions into the last chorus, he says, “I feel like your music taste has changed a bit.”

“What do you mean?”

“Well,” Phainon says, lips curling up. “At least half the stuff you’ve played on this trip sounds like it was released after the year 1990.”

This time, it’s Mydei’s turn to flip him off. “Shut the fuck up,” he says. “If you have a problem, you can wear some fucking ear plugs.” But Phainon just laughs, and it sounds almost as real as his smile, and he seems like his normal self again for a moment until he guilts himself out of being happy and sighs.

“Thanks, Mydei,” he says after a moment.

Mydei looks at him. The line of his throat as he swallows. His eyes are on the road, as they should be. “...What for?”

“Coming with me,” Phainon answers. “I think I would have been pretty miserable on my own.”

“You would’ve been sleeping in your car; that’s a given.”

“Shut up, I’m serious,” Phainon says. “I’m glad you’re here.”

“I…” What is this? Three days of it, sentimental flashes. “...I guess I’m glad too.”

Half a smile. “You guess?”

“You’re so fucking weird lately.”

Phainon just laughs a little, rubs his neck with one hand, a finger slipping beneath his choker to pull it taut. They drive in silence. One song segues into the next. Mydei phases them away from rock and into gentler genres with a carefully picked queue. Phainon even hums a bit to this last song, something softer with a full band and lyrics that don’t make a lot of sense. And then he takes an audible breath.

“You know what I just realized?” he asks. Mydei only hums. “There was an electric car all the way back at the light with a license plate that said *404 GAS*. Cause it doesn’t use gas, get it? Error 404 gas not found. That’s so fucking funny, how did I not get it until now?” He laughs, like saying he finds it funny isn’t enough, and Mydei sighs through his nose.

“I hate you,” he says, scrolling through his playlist for what to play next. “I really do.”

△

The sky steadily darkens. It starts raining about a couple of hours later. Phainon is still driving, but even he’s not dumb enough to speed like crazy in the rain. They’ve already shaved three minutes off their ETA, so he slows down a bit now. A little longer, the rain comes down harder, pattering on the windshield, drowning out the music, making the wipers work overtime. He gets out of the left lane, slows to crawl along the road with the rest of the cars. His knuckles are white on the steering wheel.

“Was it supposed to rain today?” he asks, and maybe it’s just because he’s used to his own car with brakes half as sensitive as these and a half inch less tread on the tires, but driving in the rain has always made him anxious. His molars dig sores into his cheek. Mydei turns the music off, so it’s just the low squeak of the windshield wipers, the sound of water on the roof of the car. Phainon quite likes rain, given the right circumstances. He’ll derail an entire schedule to go sit on the patio and listen to it. When he was a kid, he’d play in puddles just to come home soaked and dripping all over the floors. He never got sick, though. Cyrene didn’t either.

“You saw the sky,” Mydei says. “It’s hardly surprising.”

Sweat on the steering wheel. Phainon’s free leg bounces until he’s not sure if he’s doing it on purpose or if he’s just clenched it up so tight. Water gathers on the road. The rain comes down harder, deafening for a moment, little hailstones plunking against the windows. His hands slip. The car trudges along.

Mydei is looking at him. He can feel that much. Red light shines through the mist as the car in front of them brakes. Phainon taps theirs too hard; the car lurches. “You think I’d be used to your car by now,” he tries, chuckling. He’s torn up the inside of his cheek. He wipes one hand on his shorts, then the other.

“You can take the exit,” Mydei says.

The hail stops, but the rain continues just as violently as before. Phainon can smell it in the air the a/c pulls in. He resists the urge to tear up the inside of his mouth some more. “It’s fine.”

“HKS,” Mydei says. That old Kremnoan word again. He said it means *hyena* or something like that. The meaning is like *scoundrel.* His voice is always fond when he says it. “I’d be scared of driving in this too.”

Phainon’s driven in the rain plenty of times. Rain like this, even. He’s driven in worse in the winter. Snow and slush and black ice. But he’s never just… taken the next exit to wait it out. Does anyone do that? He doesn’t think so. He’s always just suffered through the stress. “Would you take the exit if you were the one driving?” he tries, more seriously than he intends.

“Yes,” Mydei tells him, and it’s awfully simple when he says it like that. He’s always been more cautious than Phainon, more careful. Safer. Steady, calm, stable.

“Alright,” Phainon says. Half a mile to go. He makes a conscious effort to relax. “We’ll wait it out, then.”

He takes the exit. Drives a little until he finds a supermarket to park at. It’s too early for lunch, or he’d suggest that to kill time, so for now he just pulls into a space and shuts the car off. Exhales. Wipes his hands on his shorts again, coming away covered in lint for how damp they are. The rain keeps coming, a gust of wind sending it spattering over the windows, shaking the tiny parking lot trees in their planters. New droplets make ripple upon ripple in the puddles. Phainon can still taste the humidity.

“Well,” he says. “This is fun.”

Mydei doesn’t reply, just reaches to pull the cover back from the sunroof. He leans his seat back and angles his head up so he can look through it. The rain falling from above, spilling down the sides of the car. The sky is all gray. Mydei’s eyes are lined in red.

“Look,” Mydei says, gesturing upward with his chin.

Phainon takes a breath in and undoes his seatbelt. “Right,” he says, fumbling with the seat. “Uh. How do you…?”

Mydei snorts. “There’s a lever under the seat on your left.”

Phainon finds it, moving the seat back, settling in with an arm behind his head. There’s not much to see through the sunroof. Just rain, more rain. A flash. Distantly, thunder crackles. He sighs. “We’re going to be so late.”

Mydei is quiet for a little while. “Were we going to see Cyrene today at all?”

Phainon opens his mouth. There’s no lump in his throat this time. “No,” he answers. “We’ll be staying at her place, but she’s in the hospital right now. She starts chemo today, actually. The first week is supposed to be really intense, so it might be days before she can go home.”

“Oh,” Mydei says.

“I…” Phainon sighs. “I should call her.”

“Do you want to?”

Another crack of thunder. He didn’t even see the flash this time. “Yes,” he says. “No. She sounds tired when I call, Mydei. It just makes it hard.” He can feel Mydei study him, turns to meet his gaze. Amber to ice. His expression doesn’t give away much.

“She still wants to hear from you,” Mydei says.

So Phainon lets out a shaky sigh and slips his phone out of his pocket. He puts it on speaker as he dials her. It rings, rings, rings. They wait in silence until the dial tone and Phainon hangs up. Three dull notes. He opens up their texts instead, types out *good luck.* “She might be in treatment already.”

“That’s alright,” Mydei says, still just looking at him. “We’ll try again later.” His gaze has always been so intense. Like he sees every goddamned thing. They’ve already established that Phainon is as clear as glass.

A thick feeling in his throat. He clears it. “It looks like the rain has let up a little,” he says, starting to sit up. Mydei’s gaze like a tangible thing. Why can’t he shake it off? “Should we go?”

It’s still pouring. Mydei stays leaned back, an arm under his head. “Wait a little longer,” he says. “Look at the sky.”

Tentatively, Phainon does. Storm clouds and water droplets. An edge of the sun peeking out. Half a rainbow, dim and mostly invisible, but there. Phainon traces its arc to the place it disappears, and then the whole thing fades as the sun hides away again. Another crack of thunder. He squeezes his phone tight, pressing imprints into his palm. “A little longer, then,” he says.

△

Lunch is an odd combination of spaghetti, chili, and cheese that turns out to be one of the best meals Phainon has ever tried. Mydei takes one look at the presentation and bursts out laughing in the middle of the restaurant because according to him it looks *“so goddamned awful who cares how it fucking tastes.”* He still tries it though, and admits that it tastes pretty good, even if he has to pause to chuckle a little between bites. With his reaction to the food and Phainon’s admittedly bad outfit, it’s unclear which of them is more embarrassing to be associated with.

After… that, they’re back on the road with mostly clear skies and Mydei at the wheel. Phainon plays the cutsiest, most high-pitched girl group songs he can find just to piss him off and make him complain about *“vocal strain”* and how *“no way in hell can they sing this shit live.”*

Phainon exists with half a smile for a bit, cheek in hand, propped on the base of the window. They're cutting through civilization so there's traffic, people on their lunch commute or heading who knows where. So many lives going by. Nothing stops for anything.

Seven and a half more hours of this. They've been on the road so long Phainon has forgotten what it's like to do anything else. His ass has long since gone numb. He'll hear the rumble of the road even after he gets out.

Mydei's finished fuming. He just sits now, drives and digs his thumbnails into the steering wheel as Phainon continues to play music that does not align with his tastes. He's remembered what he said earlier, about how Phainon likes the reaction. He wouldn't put half as much effort into tormenting him if the result wasn't rewarding. So Mydei just takes it in silence, and Phainon starts to feel a bit guilty. He picks a song where the singers don't sound cute to the point of being slightly disturbing to play next.

"What." Mydei says after a moment.

Phainon blinks, parrots it back, "What?"

They make eye contact briefly. Mydei's red eyeliner. Phainon's borrowed sunglasses reflecting him back. "It feels like you've been looking at me."

And really, when is Phainon not? He'd grown up well. More than filled out his body, grew out his hair and cut it shaggy, covered himself all over in tattoos. It's funny, looking at him and knowing him. He could be two different people.

Phainon's still looking. God. His fingers itch. "I'm always looking at you."

He watches the way Mydei's lips part and close again, the way his eyes stay firmly on the road. He swallows, throat bobbing. "That's a weird fucking thing to say."

Phainon hums in agreement. "So is suggesting that your namesake's lover might have had the same name as your best friend, even as a joke. But here we are."

Silence. Mydei turns the volume on the music down. He's still just watching the road. Not even a glance to Phainon's side. He's terribly good at being stubborn when he wants to be.

"Phainon," he says. "Is this really a conversation you want to have now?"

It's not the first time. Phainon raps his knuckles on the window, turns his attention outside to the billboards they pass. A memorial: *Loved Beyond Words, Missed Beyond Measure.* An ad for liposuction, a law firm, a community theatre. Something inside him twists into knots. "Probably not," he says, and that's that.

△

He's not stupid, is the thing. Neither of them is. Phainon has carried this torch for a couple of years now. Mydei… At least four months, five. He doesn't actually know, because they don't talk about it. They're a little closer than friends often are, and every now and then they say

weird fucking things, but they don't talk about it. Phainon just doesn't know what they'd be like as more than friends. He can't really see himself holding Mydei's hand.

The conversation dies for a bit after that. Mydei turns the volume back up. Phainon plays music both of them can tolerate. The miles blur by. Cyrene texts back.

The soup they gave me tastes like nothing. Attached is a picture of a bowl of sad, milky broth. Her left hand in the corner of the screen making a peace sign. It makes Phainon laugh, kind of wetly, kind of startled. Mydei looks over. He presses call. She picks up in two rings.

"It really does," she says, rather than greeting him. And oh, she sounds exhausted, but there's the hint of a smile in her voice. Phainon puts her on speaker, and Mydei reaches to mute the volume again. "They said I shouldn't have too much salt, so they basically gave me water."

"How'd it go?" Phainon asks, terribly breathy, chest flipping over and over and over.

"I'm fine, Phainon," she says, hearing that in him. She laughs a little. "They gave me a port, which still hurts a bit, but allegedly it'll make treatment way easier in the future."

"But… How do you *feel?"* he asks her.

"Tired," she says. "Kind of high. In pain. Not too fond of the food."

"Cyrene." She laughs, almost sounds like herself. "Mydei is here. We're seven hours out."

"Hi," Mydei says, a bit awkward.

"Hi, Mydei," Cyrene greets him. "Phainon didn't tell me you were coming. It'll be nice to see you." She pauses. Ceramic clinks on her end as she drinks her flavorless soup. "Seven hours… It'll be like one in the morning!"

"We got delayed by a storm," Phainon tells her. "It's alright though; we'll still come see you tomorrow. We just probably won't wake up all that early."

"Just drive safe, both of you," she says.

"We will," Phainon assures her. He opens the picture she sent again. "What's in your soup?"

"Beans," she answers. The sound of her spoon clinking. "Water. That's about it. I feel a little sick, though. I don't know if I'd be able to get much else down."

"Mydei can cook for you."

"I…" He glances over again. Phainon, his raised eyebrows, the phone. He sighs through his nose, shakes his head. "I can, if you want. Soup that actually has flavor, or something. Is there anything you're supposed to avoid during treatment?"

"You're sweet," she says, and Phainon can hear her smiling again. "They gave me a whole pamphlet, but I don't think it said anything about not being able to eat certain things. Just

like… no raw meat and avoid acidic and spicy things in case I get mouth sores. I would be happy with anything you want to make."

"She got the soap gene," Phainon says. "Don't give her cilantro."

It makes her chuckle, kind of weak but still sincere. She yawns after, clinks her spoon in her soup some more. "I'm glad you called," she says after a moment, a little softer now. "It's been lonely."

Sometimes Phainon forgets that she's just as alone as he is. That she lost her family in the fire too. That her only sibling lives across the country from her. She has friends, just like he does, but there's a separate, empty box in the equation for family. He can't imagine what it would be like to go through this alone. A glance at Mydei. Phainon watches the corners of his mouth tick down, watches a line of three silver cars in a row that they pass. "We'll be there soon," he says.

"I know," she tells him. He can see her smile. Her hair, dyed pink over the white they got from their mother. He hadn't— She'll lose it with the treatment. "I'm just grateful. To you too, Mydei. Thanks for tagging along with him. He worried me a lot when he said he'd come out by himself. I'm glad you're with him."

Mydei chuckles. "You think I'd let this idiot drive thirty hours by himself? He was planning on sleeping in the car for the night. He wouldn't have made it."

"Don't doubt me, Mydeimos, I would have—"

Cyrene laughs, high and tinkling. "You're too good to my idiot of a brother, Mydei," she says. "Thank you for keeping him alive all these years."

△

The hours crawl by. The sun goes down. They reach another point that's just the middle of nowhere, passing another car once every ten minutes or so. Mydei turns on his brights, lighting further along their path, reflecting off signs and the paint on the road, tinted slightly blue. There aren't any streetlights. Just them and the dark.

Phainon pulls the cover on the sunroof open and looks up, trying to see the stars. It's dirty, covered in water spots from the rain, but the sky is there. No moon, but so many stars, brighter here in the dark, blinking softly. He wishes he knew more constellations, but the only ones he'd ever been able to find are the Dippers, and he even gets those confused when he can't see them both at once.

"When you get sick of driving," he says to a car filled with silence. They've turned off the music again, sick and out of things to play hours early this time. "Pull over so we can look at the stars for a bit."

"We're already going to be late," Mydei reminds him. He's a map of shadows in the dark, details blurred out, tattoos turned black. Phainon's leg bounces. He traces patterns into the back of his phone, swirls and stars and zig zags.

“I know. What’s a little later?” he asks. They still haven’t stopped for dinner, but at this point it’s ten at night and they probably won’t. There are snacks in the back. Phainon has had three pieces of fruit leather and half a bag of chips. Maybe they’ll steal something out of Cyrene’s pantry when they get there. “I don’t mean for a long time, anyway. Just for a bit since there’s hardly any light pollution.”

Mydei hums, reaches for his water bottle to take a sip. Barely a minute passes before he pulls the car onto the shoulder and slows to a stop. The sound of gravel under tires. The roar of the road still lingers in Phainon’s ears. “As it turns out,” Mydei says, unbuckling his seatbelt. “I’m sick of driving.”

And all Phainon can do is laugh as he opens the car door and steps out, fumbling to follow suit, and as he comes out he’s struck by cool air on his sweat-soaked back and a sweet, fresh smell from the trees. Mydei climbs onto the hood of the car, and when Phainon joins him, the metal seems to shift in protest. “I feel like we’re going to dent this,” he says, a bit hesitant.

Mydei looks over. “Maybe,” he says. “It’s never had to support two people at once.”

“And is that… okay?” A shrug. Helpless, Phainon laughs. “Mydei, it’s your car. I can get off.”

“It’s pretty sturdy,” is all Mydei says.

“Are you going to get mad if there’s an imprint of my ass on here later?”

Again, Mydei looks at him. What scant light there is reflects off his eyes. “Sit further on the side so it’s not in the middle,” he says. Phainon scoots a bit. The metal seems to protest a little less, so he turns to look at the sky, clear and unobstructed without the dirty window in the way. The blue-black of it, the soft gray of a handful of small clouds, the twinkle of a myriad of stars.

“It’s pretty,” he says. A grunt from Mydei’s side. Phainon chuckles. “Are you agreeing with me or do you think this is totally lame?”

“Just tired,” Mydei says. “I like it.”

Again, Phainon looks at his blur in the dark. He’s leaning back now, the upper half of his body against the windshield, though Phainon is a bit too afraid of breaking it to join him. Instead, he sits and looks at him instead of the stars, and thinks this would be a painfully good time to be honest. His chest aches. A lump forms in his throat, so he turns back to the sky. Distantly, there’s the rumble of another car. It’s a handful of seconds before they pass and disappear in the distance.

“Are you worried?” Mydei asks. He doesn’t specify about what.

“Yes,” Phainon answers anyway. He’s tangling his fingers in his lap, pulling on each until the knuckle pops. “You heard her. She’s so good at pretending to be fine.”

“She just doesn’t want to worry you.”

“Of course I’m going to worry,” Phainon protests. “She’s my sister. She’s… she could be dying from this.”

“You can’t make that judgement until we see how the treatment goes,” is all Mydei says. He’s quiet for a little while, maybe waiting for Phainon to say something, but he has nothing. “She’s young and healthy, Phainon. Her odds are good.”

Phainon sniffs. He’s frustrated with himself. “I know,” he says. Again, “I know. I just can’t lose her too.”

A pause that seems to stretch for eternity. Mydei isn’t particularly adept at comfort. “Should I hug you again?” he offers, a bit stilted, and oh, Phainon could laugh.

“Fuck off,” he says, wiping his nose on the back of his hand. “Why would you make me ask for it?”

Here, a soft, rumbling laugh. Mydei slips off the hood of the car and comes around, shoes crunching in the gravel, just a body shaped blur in the night. He stands there with his arms open, and Phainon curses him again, just once, just softly, before he joins him on the ground, punching him in the chest first, then walking into him until they figure out how to fit. His face against Mydei’s neck. Mydei’s arms tight around his shoulders. He doesn’t realize he’s cold until right this moment.

“You’re terrible at this,” he says. The vibration of Mydei’s laugh. His fingers playing with the ends of Phainon’s hair.

“I know,” he says. “But you feel a little better, don’t you?”

“...Shut up.”

△

They get to Cyrene’s place late. So late, abysmally late. Two thirty-six in the morning, they lug their stuff up three flights of stairs and down the hall for Phainon to punch in the code to open the door. The lock buzzes and clicks. He pushes the door open, fumbles for a light switch. The air he’s met with smells like lavender.

Cyrene’s apartment is small and neat. The kitchen immediately to their left, nothing but a toaster, a microwave, and a knife rack left on the counter. Spices along the top of the stove. A sink, empty but for a single spoon, a humming refrigerator. Straight ahead is the living room, sparsely furnished, just a loveseat, coffee table, and TV stand. Phainon leads the way to the bedroom, where there’s a desk, a made bed, a bookshelf lined with a hundred novels arranged by color. They leave their stuff in one corner, Phainon digging for his toiletries so he can brush his teeth and be done with the day.

Mydei follows him into the bathroom, wordless as he wets his toothbrush and squeezes toothpaste onto the bristles. Their shoulders brush. They’re side by side in the mirror, brushing their teeth, tired-eyed and worn out from the drive. Mydei’s eyeliner smudged somewhere down the road. The sound of Phainon’s electric toothbrush buzzing fills the room.

A couple of minutes pass; the timer goes off. He brushes his tongue, makes himself gag, and spits in the sink. When he's done rinsing and steps back, Mydei takes over.

Phainon should shower. He's sweaty and gross from sitting in the car all day and the sheets are fresh, but he's so tired it's all he can do to change into his pajamas. The same ones he's been wearing this whole trip, blue shirt and shorts, worn soft.

He found the source of the lavender smell: plug in air fresheners, one in the living room, another in the bedroom. The walls are painted soft green. He doesn't think he'll have a hard time falling asleep tonight.

Cyrene's bed is a full, not a queen, so it's a bit of a squeeze, but he slips into the side closest to the bathroom, not the window, and feels the way his body weighs heavily into it. The light burns red behind his eyelids. A little longer, Mydei comes out of the bathroom with his hair tied back and his face washed clean. His eyes are softer unlined. Phainon doesn't have the presence of mind to look at him without saying something stupid, so he shuts his eyes again. Listens to the shuffle of fabric as he strips off his shirt and changes into pajama pants, feels the dip in the mattress as he sits.

"Tight squeeze," he murmurs, and Phainon hums in response. The mattress shifts again as Mydei gets up to turn off the light. Phainon finally relaxes in the dark.

Weight behind him as Mydei slips under the covers. He bumps Phainon a couple of times with the way they're packed in tight, murmurs an apology. "Goodnight," he says after a bit. Phainon can barely even say it back.

Chapter End Notes

more characterization tidbits just for fun: Mydei is actually a very light sleeper but struggles profusely with sleep inertia. He is doomed to be perpetually eepy and disturbed when he wakes up. Phainon tends to sleep okay, but it takes him a long time to get there. He's a frequent dreamer and serial dream-forgetter, but he occasionally gets nightmares that wake him up and screw over any chance of a good night's sleep. He also has ADHD!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Just a note: I've been doing my best with the research but I am neither a doctor nor an AML patient. pls suspend your disbelief if anything is inaccurate!
>
> Also... why did no one tell me there was a typo in the summary... 3 weeks it sat there while I was oblivious... top 5 most embarrassing things of my ao3 career...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the morning, Mydei wakes to too much warmth. A blanket tangled around his legs. Sweat under his arms. Someone else's body against his back. He's too tired to move much. The most he can do is kick the comforter off. There's a puff of breath against his neck, something like a laugh.

"You're awake?" Phainon asks, and the sound is so close that it gives Mydei a chill. But his body is still so heavy, and there's no strength in him yet to speak, so he doesn't, just turns his face into the pillow. Phainon's arm slips off his waist. His heat at Mydei's back disappears when he rolls over and they aren't touching anymore. Without him, it's almost cold. Mydei shoves his feet back under the covers.

"Seems like a no," Phainon muses, too awake for the hour, whatever the hour is. His voice is soft, but there's no rasp from the morning in it, none of the last dregs of sleep. Mydei can't even open his eyes. He's half convinced this must be a dream, but there's the shake of the mattress as Phainon moves, the hand that brushes his mess of hair neatly behind his ear. And it's cold, suddenly it's cold, goosebumps prickling over his arms and neck.

Mydei rolls onto his back and forces one eye open. Phainon looks down at him, blue-eyed and bed-headed. His expression is gentle. "Maybe a yes?" he says, but Mydei has forgotten what he was asking.

Sleep slips further and further away. Mydei is still so tired. He grunts, tries shutting his eyes again, but he's cold now, and the blankets are tangled at the foot of the bed. He makes an unhappy sound, and the mattress shifts again.

"I'm going to figure out breakfast," Phainon tells him. "Go back to bed. Or join me if you want."

And then he's gone, and Mydei breathes with his eyes shut for a while. Maybe he dozes. It's still cold. After a while, a handful of minutes at best, he cracks his eyes open. Nothing but ceiling. The sprawl of daylight. He rolls onto his side and his eyes slip shut again. His mind is starting to wake, but his body refuses. He curls in on himself because he can't find the strength to get the blankets back.

Time passes. There's an infernal racket from the other room, and the sound of it is almost enough to shock him into wakefulness. As it stands, there's no screaming, so he rubs a crust from his eye and lays a little longer. Just… to the count of ten. Just…

He thinks he dreamt last night. Something about a dinner party. Yes, he'd been cooking, and Phainon had stolen his sauce. He was dipping carrots in it, and one of the guests was crying, and the sun was shining straight into his face. Red behind his eyelids, the scrape of metal eyelets on the curtain rod. The room shaking. Pressure on his shoulder, something poking his cheek. He peels his eyes open to too much sunlight and Phainon's index finger prodding his face, his thigh against Mydei's shoulder as he sits cross-legged at the top of the bed.

"It's almost noon, Mydeimos," he says. "You've really got to get up now."

"Mmph." Mydei grabs his hand to stop the poking and forgets to let go. "Fuck off. Fuck… that light."

A laugh. Phainon tries to pull his hand free, but Mydei tightens his grip. "I don't think I've ever seen you this tired," Phainon says. Mydei cracks an eye open to look at him. Blue-eyed and… he combed his hair. Mydei's eyes slip shut again.

"None of that." Phainon prods his cheek again. "Wake up."

Mydei grabs his other hand too, managing to glare. Phainon only raises his eyebrows and stretches out one leg to lightly kick his hip. Mydei doesn't have a third hand to catch his leg too, so he grumbles and pushes himself upright, closing his eyes and breathing here for a moment. Now, Phainon pokes the place where his back tattoos converge in the dip of his spine.

"Quit," Mydei mumbles. "I'm getting up."

"Doesn't really seem like it," Phainon points out.

A couple more breaths. "...Fuck off."

And again, Phainon just laughs and slips off the bed. "I made pancakes," he says. "I even saved the better ones for you. They're probably cold by now, though."

That explains the racket. Phainon isn't exactly hopeless in the kitchen—despite how they like to joke—but he only has about a half dozen things he knows how to make and none of them are particularly exciting. Pancakes, grilled cheese, eggs, pasta… The most basic foods known to man. Ask Phainon to cut a vegetable and he might fuck the whole kitchen up. Ask him not to and, well, he's still rather clumsy. The pancakes should be edible, though.

Mydei yawns and stretches, first overhead, then forward, hands sliding over the sheets, head down. He has to resist the urge to stay here, reluctantly dropping his feet over the edge of the bed and standing up. God, he's so tired. Sleep clings to him like an upset child, latching onto his legs and refusing to let go. He usually struggles to wake, but this is a new level. The drive last night must've done him in. He finds his shirt from last night on the ground and pulls it back on.

Phainon's pancakes are passable. Shaped a little odd and a little browner than Mydei likes, but good enough with some syrup and a banana almost old enough for banana bread cut into slices. As he eats, seated at a chair pulled up to the counter, Phainon disappears to do who knows what. Mydei is still far too tired to care, chewing slow, trying to wake himself up with a glass of cold water. He could almost be persuaded to suffer through a cup of coffee.

When he's done, he goes for a shower, keeping the temperature far colder than he'd like to shock himself awake. This helps a bit, but still, as he digs through his bag for a fresh change of clothes, he's stuck yawning again.

Phainon comes in when he's done dressing, wearing one of the few outfit combinations he's had confirmed to be acceptable by Aglaea, which is how Mydei knows he's taking today seriously. Black jeans and a button up with the top two buttons undone, no *Master Baiter* shirt in sight. He isn't wearing shoes yet, but his socks are plain black and it's unlikely he can mess this up with any of the footwear options he's packed.

"I want to buy flowers before we go," he says, and Mydei is so tired that he must glare by accident, because Phainon's demeanor turns unsure and awkward. "Um. If that's not…?"

"That's fine," Mydei says, fixing the band of his sock and standing up off the bed. He slips into the bathroom, and Phainon continues to hover as he gets his comb and starts unpicking the knots in his hair from the bottom up.

"You just…" Phainon comes to stand in the doorway, still frowning a little. "...Had this face."

"I always have a face," Mydei says drily.

"You do!" Phainon agrees. "And usually it's a very nice one. But, well, the things you were *doing* with it just now..."

Mydei meets his eyes in the mirror. He still looks a little uncertain. Phainon's so easy to rile up, to tease, but the moment he thinks it's even the slightest bit serious he gets all pouty and insecure like this. Mydei sighs. "...Sorry," he says. "I didn't mean anything by it. I'm just tired."

"Oh," Phainon says, and his face brightens like he has a lightswitch and Mydei just flicked it. "Well then. I found a florist that's kind of on the way to the hospital. Like… an extra seven minutes of driving or something like that. But if you don't want to, we could also just stop by a grocery store and pick some up there, even if they won't be as nice…"

Mydei sighs, snags the comb on a tangle. "Phainon," he says. Phainon closes his mouth, makes a small sound in answer. "The florist is fine. Quit acting like a kicked dog; I already told you I didn't mean to glare."

"Well, I—" Phainon chooses not to continue, pressing his lips together. "Okay. We'll get flowers, then."

"And Cyrene will like them," Mydei agrees, because he knows Phainon is already stressed and nervous and as uncomfortable as it is, it can't hurt to reassure him a little more. Not when

he so clearly needs it. Even if it brings an unwelcome squirming sensation to Mydei's stomach. He grumbles the next bit, "It's a good idea."

"Oh," Phainon says. *Oh, oh, oh.* That fucking lightswitch again. His smile is blinding, and it's terrible because Mydei wants him smiling all the time, but hates to be the cause of it. He'd look away, but his gaze is stuck like his comb on a knot. "I was thinking of sunflowers or something. I looked it up and those are the best get-well-soon flowers, and I know she likes them."

This much, even Mydei remembers. High school, they'd been driving somewhere, sometime. It was summer, he remembers that much. She'd said it always made her happy, seeing them grow on the side of the road. *They're like hope,* she'd said, or something like it. *Toss the seeds anywhere and they'll find a way to grow.* She was always kind of poetic like that. A romantic at heart. Phainon too, but he's less obvious about it.

"Sunflowers, then," he agrees.

"Alright," Phainon says. He leans against the doorframe, keeps smiling. "Whenever you're ready, we'll head out."

△

They head out pretty soon after that. Mydei drives by default because it's his car, but Phainon doesn't choose to put on any obnoxious music. He leaves the stereo muted like it was last night, and steals Mydei's sunglasses again because the midday sun is blindingly bright. Mydei's left arm burns to a crisp from the light coming in the window, but Phainon just sits like a happily photosynthesizing plant.

"I'm optimistic," he says when Mydei doesn't ask. "Or. Trying to be."

Mydei spares him a glance. "Seems like you're doing a good job of it." He's still exhausted himself. Maybe he'd just been stirred awake at a bad time in his sleep cycle. Maybe Phainon's stupid pancakes were poisoned.

"Thank you," Phainon says, though it wasn't exactly a compliment. "I just don't want her to see me sad, you know? I think it would just make her feel worse. She's already going through way too much."

Another glance. The glasses hide his eyes, but it's a front, so obviously a front that he's putting up because he doesn't want to make everyone around him miserable. Mydei should take notes from him and stop being an asshole right now. "She'll be happy to see you," he offers.

"Sure," Phainon says. Again, more subdued, "Sure."

Mydei sighs as the car in front of him slows for a turn without signalling. His thumbnails dig dents into the steering wheel. Phainon is back to being weird. "Do you want to get her a gift?" Mydei offers. He thinks of her color coded shelf in the bedroom "A book or something. She still likes reading, doesn't she?"

“Yes,” Phainon says, nodding, thinking about it. “Yes, but… maybe tomorrow. We can take a picture of her bookshelf to make sure we don’t get her something she already has. Besides, she’ll get mad if I bring her a ton of stuff all at once.”

“Alright,” Mydei says, stopping at a red light. Without the sound of the road, he can hear the way Phainon’s leg bounces, the fabric of his pants hissing against the seat. “So think about that instead of making yourself sad.”

“Ah.” A laugh. “Optimistic, right.” A forced smile. Phainon adds, “I must be a pretty shitty friend to be stuck with for days on end right now.”

“Your sister has cancer,” Mydei reminds him. “I’m really not being the one put out right now. Quit worrying about it.”

The light goes green. Phainon’s leg bounces a little more aggressively. “That’s the second time you’ve had to tell me that today,” he says. “Sorry. I’m just. I don’t know, my mind is going a mile a minute and nothing it lands on is good today. I’ll try to stop.”

Mydei hums, checks the directions he’d set up on his phone. Left in half a mile; he gets over into the next lane. “And I still won’t be upset even if you don’t. Just in case that wasn’t clear.”

“Fuck,” Phainon whispers. He goes still for all of ten seconds before he’s bouncing his leg again, rapping his knuckles on his thigh.

“Something wrong?”

“I’m in love with you,” Phainon tells him. “God fucking damnit.”

He’s got a hand over his mouth. A furrow between his brows. He looks sick of himself. Mydei laughs lightly. “Sure,” he says, only because Phainon doesn’t say it like he’s serious, even though he probably is. “You’re so fucking in love with me.”

Phainon laughs too, helplessly. “Asshole move not to say it back,” he tells Mydei.

And Mydei just hums. “Maybe next time,” he says, and Phainon just leans against the window and offers him a thumbs up.

△

The get-well-soon flowers Phainon settles on—after much unneeded stress and discussion of flower language with the florist—are arranged in a neat bouquet, wrapped in yellow paper and white ribbon. Big golden sunflowers interspersed with orange tulips and white daisies. There’s even a card stuck in the middle that has *get well soon* written on it in the florist’s neat hand. They’re beautiful flowers, and Phainon forks over a pretty penny for them and won’t let Mydei contribute.

On the drive to the hospital, he holds them carefully in his lap, not even moving much for fear of jostling them. It could almost be funny if it weren’t obvious how hard he’s trying. Mydei doesn’t end up commenting, just sets up his directions and drives.

The hospital parking lot is a whole challenge, with a dozen different signs for a dozen different care units pointing in a dozen different directions, but they eventually find the right place and park. Inside, they're told Cyrene is in treatment and asked to wait, and there's Phainon in a blue plastic chair, wiping the sweat from his hands on his pants and tensing up his leg so he won't shake the flowers.

"You could put those on another chair," Mydei points out.

Phainon takes this deep breath. "You're right," he says, and does so with terribly gentle hands. Only then does he exhale, hands balling to fists on his thighs. "Holy fuck, what am I so nervous for?"

"She's not going to look like she's aged a hundred years," Mydei says. "You're not seeing her on her deathbed. She's just in treatment."

"I know," Phainon says, exhales again. "I know that. She's just… My sister. I have this image of her in my head, swinging in the backyard, running around and smiling, you know? Even when she got sick, she stuck it out, she was never…"

"And what makes you think this won't be the same?" Mydei asks. He bumps his knee into Phainon's, feels his lips twitch when Phainon bumps him back.

"You're right," Phainon says. "I know you are, but something in me just won't listen. I… I'm sure I'll get over it when I see her, but right now…"

"That's normal," Mydei tells him. He bumps Phainon's leg again. "Do you want to hear another legend?"

"Yeah," Phainon decides. "Yes, that… I think that would be good. You never told me why King Eurypon was so shitty anyway. Well, aside from throwing his kid in the sea, but, you know."

The chair isn't exactly comfortable no matter how Mydei sits on it. He shifts, leaning back a little further and folding his arms. "Eurypon," he considers, trying to remember the details of this particular story the way his mother told it. "He was a good king at first. He fell in love with his queen, Gorgo, after they fought a duel and tied. After Mydeimos was born, there was a prophecy that said he would kill Eurypon and lead to the end of the Kremnoan Dynasty, and that's when Eurypon went crazy."

"So he was scared," Phainon says.

Mydei turns to look at him, nods. "It's a given, though. Every Kremnoan king is crowned in the blood of his own father. Eurypon too, and his father before him for a dozen generations. Of course Mydeimos was going to kill him."

"Well…" Phainon purses his lips, smiles awkwardly. "Yeah, that's not really an excuse to throw your kid in the sea."

“It gets worse,” Mydei tells him. “Gorgo was the only one brave enough to oppose him, and since they were equals in everything, he poisoned her so she would lose their duel. He killed her and threw Mydeimos into the sea.”

Phainon frowns at this, brows pinching together. “But he loved them, didn’t he? Or, at least Gorgo, how could he just…?”

“He went crazy over that prophecy,” Mydei offers, shrugging. He doesn’t know why Phainon gets so into these stories, but he’s always been like that. No one else would give two shits if Mydei tells these stories or not. No one else would bother analyzing the characters’ motivations. “For the record, it doesn’t make a lot of sense to me either. I don’t know how he could just wake up one day and plot to kill his wife and child. Not to mention the cowardice of poisoning someone he thought of as his equal. He’s… my least favorite Kremnoan king for that reason.”

“You mentioned that equals were important to Kremnoans,” Phainon notes. He always remembers the most random things that Mydei says, completely forgets the most random things too.

“Yeah,” Mydei agrees. “It was bigger than love, to them. What Eurypon did was disgusting, and everyone agreed, but no one did shit.”

“You said he brought more bloodshed than any other king?”

“He’s where the bloodthirsty Kremnoan stereotype came from, at least after he went crazy,” Mydei explains, shifting again in this stupid uncomfortable chair. “He loved killing for sport, watching other people kill for sport. He started three separate wars and made death the penalty for most crimes.”

“That’s… fucked up.”

“Yeah,” Mydei agrees. “It is.” A bit of silence. Just as he’s about to ask if Phainon wants to hear another story, the receptionist calls them back up.

“She’s just finished her infusion,” they say. “She’ll be a bit tired, but she’s ready to see you. Room 216, to your left and up the stairs. There are elevators at the end of the hall.”

“Awesome,” Phainon says, all breathy. He smiles, the paper wrapping on the flowers crinkling as he passes it to his other hand so he can wipe the first on his pants again. “Thank you.”

The receptionist nods politely. “Of course,” they say. “Head on up.”

△

“Cyrene?” The door rolls open after she answers his knock, but he just hovers in the entryway. The smell inside is odd and sterile. The room itself is bathed in light from the window, with cold linoleum floors and pale blue walls. Cyrene sits up in her hospital bed, a blanket spread over her, a tray table over her lap with her lunch.

She does look tired. She does look sick, her skin paler than usual, her eyes heavier, but she still smiles when she sees him. She still looks like herself. “Hi,” she says, and there’s relief in her expression too. “Come in! Quit hovering.”

So Phainon comes in, sees her dressed in her own clothes, a soft purple shirt that’s loose in the collar. He can see the deep red scabbing of an incision below her collarbone, her chemo port hooked up to an IV. She fixes her shirt before he can get a good look, and he holds out the flowers rather stiffly. “We got these for you,” he says.

“Sunflowers.” She smiles a little, a rasp to her quiet voice, and winces as she reaches to take them. Her head cranes to smell them, pink hair falling into her face, and Phainon can’t imagine what she’ll look like without it.

“He wasted a ton of money on these, didn’t he?” Cyrene addresses Mydei now, standing with his arms crossed a few paces behind Phainon, looking approachable as ever.

“For sure,” Mydei confirms. “You wouldn’t even let me contribute, and here he is saying *we* got you those.”

“It’s not like I *wasted* anything,” Phainon protests, frowning. “It’s not like you hate them, right, Cyrene? It was money well spent.”

And now she laughs, a small thing since she doesn’t have the strength for more, but she laughs. It’s a contagious sound. Phainon can’t remember a time when she’s laughed and he hasn’t. “Sure, you big baby,” she says. “They’re beautiful, thank you.”

Paper crinkles as she shifts, slow and lethargic, to set the flowers on her bedside table. There are a couple of cards propped up there already. Some of her favorite candy, a potted plant. Phainon wants to help, but he doesn’t want her to feel helpless, so he lets her do it herself. “How are you feeling?” he asks.

“Exhausted,” she answers, settling back into her spot. She lifts her spoon and stirs her food around. It seems she has mashed potatoes and veggies today. A cup of fruit juice, chocolate pudding for dessert. “The fatigue is the worst of it. I’m sick of staring at the wall, but I’m too weak and it’s not like I can do anything hooked up to all this anyway.” She gestures to the IV with her spoon, takes a bite.

Phainon sits in one of the chairs by her bedside, gestures for Mydei to stop looking so imposing and sit down too. He comes and sits in the other chair, and these are a bit more comfortable than the ones in the waiting room, brown and cushioned instead of pure plastic. “Is the treatment not done for the day?” he asks.

She purses her lips, gives him a tight smile. “It’s a twenty-four hour infusion,” she says. “Seven days of it. That’s why I have to be *in* the hospital instead of just coming in for chemo appointments. They’re also giving me another drug the first three days; that’s what they were doing before you came up, actually.”

“Well that fucking sucks,” Mydei says.

Cyrene lets out a startled laugh. “Yeah,” she agrees. “It does, doesn’t it? I have to drag this thing around if I want to get up. And the food totally sucks.” She punctuates it with a stab to her mashed potatoes.

“I’ll make you something tomorrow,” Mydei tells her, propping his elbows on his knees.

Her eyes crinkle at the corners. “I was joking about that, you know,” she says. “You don’t actually have to go out of your way to do that. I’ll survive on this.”

“I have to cook to keep this one alive anyway.” He juts his thumb at Phainon, who makes a face at him. “I’ll just make a bit extra; I wouldn’t be going out of my way at all. Any requests?”

“Whatever you can find ingredients for. I’m not picky, but there's barely anything in my fridge,” she replies. She takes another bite, swallows. She’s always been a slow eater, but it’s clear she’s having difficulty eating now. Perhaps she’s nauseous, or lost her appetite from the medication. But she’s always been like this. She complains in small doses when really she has enough to gripe about for hours.

“We’ll get some groceries too,” Mydei says. “I can just go for soup, to make sure you can keep it down.”

“Thank you, Mydei,” Cyrene says. “I appreciate it a lot, even if it’s not a bother. And it’s nice to see you again after who knows how long.”

“Of course,” Mydei says, and his expression softens too. He’s always been kind, on his best behavior around her. Like he wants her to like him, to approve of him. Phainon’s always felt… some kind of way about that. “It’s good to see you too, though I wish the circumstances were better.”

“Agreed.” She stirs her food some more, sets her spoon down to take a sip of the juice instead. “But I’ve just got to survive this week, and then the worst of it is over. Allegedly.”

“If you want us to bring you anything to make your stay slightly less miserable, just say the word,” Phainon tells her. “One of your books, or something else at home. Let us know.”

She smiles a bit. “That would be nice, actually,” she says. “Thank you, Phainon.”

△

They pass the time catching up. They call often, but not often enough that they don’t have random stories and things leftover to share. Cyrene tells them about swimming, about her friends and their shenanigans, about her work. Phainon tells her about living with Mydei, about the movies he’s watched, about the things they’d seen on the drive. Mydei contributes bits about himself when prompted, but mostly hangs back and offers commentary when Phainon voices an opinion he finds particularly offensive.

Cyrene sinks into her bed as time goes on. She finishes most of her food and pushes the tray table away, though Phainon is sure it goes cold for how long it takes her to get it down. She

laughs a lot, tag-teams with Mydei to tease Phainon on more than one occasion, and seems… happy. It's still her. She hasn't been replaced by some sad, sickly creature. It's still her, even if this version of her is a bit low energy and less mobile.

Eventually, she's basically flat. Her eyes have slipped shut and Mydei and Phainon are the ones talking now—arguing, more like—though she still interjects every now and then. Her mouth stays curled up at the corners until she brings hand to cover it as she yawns after a while.

Phainon quiets instead of responding to whatever Mydei had been spouting at him to look at her. One of her eyes cracks open, clear blue like their dad's had been, like his are. Phainon holds a finger up in front of Mydei's face, ignoring the way he scoffs and bats it away because it still makes him shut up.

"Did we tire you out?" Phainon asks Cyrene.

"Oh, yeah," she says, yawning again, a little sarcastic. "It was totally you, not all of the highly toxic drugs in my system, no sir…" A little hum. She rolls onto her side to face them better, the IV tube stretching over her shoulder.

"Should we let you rest?" Mydei asks her, and his voice goes so much softer for her. "It's about time we got something to eat anyway."

"I wish I had a bit more energy," Cyrene admits. "I'm just…" Again, she yawns. "Sorry. So out of it."

"Don't worry about it," Phainon tells her. With her eyes closed, still smiling a bit, she's peaceful, she's okay. She's eased a bit of that sick, twisting feeling in the pit of his stomach. Tonight, at least, he doesn't think he'll have to worry about her too much. Not if she's just resting like this, not when he's heard her voice and seen her up close. "We'll be back, alright? Get some good rest."

"Yeah, yeah," she says, shifting a little. Her cheek squishes against the pillow, and her tired eyes crack open again. "I'm already asleep, get out of here."

"Yeah, yeah," Phainon echoes right back, a laugh on his lips, something a little bittersweet in his chest. He stands up, pats his pockets to make sure he hasn't left anything behind. "We're going, we're going."

"See you, Cyrene," Mydei tells her, hiking his pants up as he stands, lightly kicking the backs of Phainon's knees as he makes his way to the door.

"See you," she says back with a laugh, and as Phainon turns to follow, scowling as he recovers his balance, she calls, "And Phainon?"

"Yeah?" he says, stopping to look at her again.

"Thanks," she tells him. "I'm glad you guys came out. I feel a little better now than I have in a week, just for that."

“Yeah,” he says, but it comes out all weird. “Of course.”

“The books on the bottom shelf are the ones I haven’t read yet,” she adds. “I trust you to pick a good one.”

△

“So?” Mydei asks as they head out the double doors to the hospital and into the heat of the parking lot. It isn’t boiling today, at least, just a bit humid. Phainon almost trips over nothing, but swiftly rights himself.

“So?” he repeats, raising an eyebrow at Mydei, who raises one back and pointedly glances at his feet.”Shut up,” Phainon tells him before Mydei can comment on his miraculous ability to trip on air. “What do you mean?”

“You saw her,” Mydei says.

“Yes,” Phainon agrees. The sun slips out from behind a cloud, so he shields his eyes.

They’re both quiet for a moment. Asphalt beneath their shoes, the jingle as Mydei digs his keys out of his pocket. He unlocks the car, and Phainon slips in the passenger side. Twin thunks; the doors close. “We don’t have to talk about it,” Mydei says.

“Don’t say it like that,” Phainon tries, but Mydei doesn’t even look at him as he pulls out of their parking space, and that’s… He’s driving, God, of course he isn’t looking, he shouldn’t be looking. Phainon was feeling okay, he was optimistic, and Cyrene seems okay, so what is *this?*

“Like what?” Mydei asks. “And get your directions up; I don’t know where I’m going.”

“Like…” Phainon digs out his phone, typing in the first bit of Cyrene’s address before the GPS fills it in for him. He taps on it, and watches the map load as it routes them. “Like I have trauma, or some shit. I’m fine. I’m not the one we need to be worrying about right now.”

“At the stop sign, turn right,” the robotic voice of Phainon’s maps app intones. Mydei slows, stops. Checks left and right. Checks Phainon too.

“I don’t know why I have to keep saying it, but your sister having cancer isn’t just another average day,” he says, turning the car when it’s clear. The bumper scrapes as they pull off the curb. “You know that’s the kind of thing you give condolences to the family for too.”

“You saw her,” Phainon says, thinking of her smile, her voice. The way she seemed so pale, so tired. “She’s doing fine.”

The rumble of the road. The GPS, *“Go past this light, and then turn left.”* The sound of Mydei’s blinker as he gets over.

“She has cancer,” Mydei reminds him. “And she’s doing a great job of sticking it out, considering, but she’s still sick, and she’s still your sister.”

“You think I don’t know that?”

“I know you know that,” Mydei retorts. “Which is exactly why I don’t get why you’re being so goddamn stubborn.”

“I’m not being stubborn,” Phainon protests. His hands ball to fists. His leg bounces hard enough that his phone falls off his leg and the directions are lost under the seat. *“Turn left,”* they say, and Phainon jams his knuckles into his thigh as he bends to find his phone. “What even is there to be stubborn about?”

“I don’t know,” Mydei says, pulling into the left turn lane. “All of this? The fact that instead of just admitting that you’re sad, you just… do whatever this is half the time. You act super fucking weird and don’t tell me shit. It’s so obvious that you’re miserable, and there’s a damn good reason to be right there, but you’re still trying to insist that you’re fine. I don’t get it.” The blinker ticks, unusually fast or unusually grating. Phainon is shaking the car with his leg, now that they’re stopped.

“Fine!” Phainon admits, and his fists squeeze so tight his fingernails dig into his palms a little. “I’m sad, I’m upset! Is that really what you wanted to hear? Did you want to spend all day listening to me mope?”

Mydei inhales, sighs it back out. The light goes green, and he inches forward, waits for a couple of cars going straight before he turns. “I’m here for *you,* you know,” he says. “I’m here because I saw your fake-ass smile that morning and cared enough to come with you when I didn’t even know what was wrong.”

“I didn’t *ask—”*

“—No, you didn’t,” Mydei interrupts. “But I’m here anyway! You know what that’s called?”

Phainon opens his fists when his nails start to hurt. White crescents in his palm. They’re all sweaty, so he wipes them and wipes them and wipes them on his pants until his hands are tingling with weird sensation. And he could cry again, pushed over the edge by *this,* whatever this is, this hostility, this frustration, this annoyance directed at *him.* And he knows he’s a goddamned nuisance. He knows he’s been dragging Mydei around by the hair for the better part of their lives, wasting his time, his attention, putting him out again and again, but he’s the only person who’s ever stuck around for all of Phainon’s shit.

“You’re a liar, you know that?” And there, those are the tears that Phainon just isn’t good enough at holding in. He tries, and then a handful of words are enough to crush him to pieces. Mydei isn’t even being mean. How can he shoulder the weight of his own emotions, Cyrene’s cancer, *anything,* when he can’t even shoulder this?

“When did I fucking lie?” Mydei asks, and he sounds affronted now, upset about this enough to look Phainon in the eye, and his gaze is furious. Furious at him, at whatever this is, at whatever Phainon is doing.

He wipes a tear with the side of his hand before Mydei can see it, because he’s still driving and still has to look at the road more than he can look at Phainon, but a moment is enough to

pull himself together and say, “you said you wouldn’t get upset!”

“And I’m fucking not!” Mydei says, but his voice is raised and his knuckles are white on the wheel.

“In five hundred feet, turn right,” the directions say, and Phainon squeezes his phone so tight he holds the power button and shuts it off.

“Then what is that?” Phainon laughs, but nothing is funny, and the way he’s digging the hard edge of his phone into his leg doesn’t hurt enough. “Why are you yelling, if you’re not upset? You think I don’t *know* I’m stupid and miserable and wasting your time? You think I don’t —!”

“I’m *trying,”* Mydei says over him, wrenching the car into a right turn that sends Phainon bumping into the car door. And then he slows and finds a place to pull over, because he’s the type to wait out a rainstorm rather than drive through it, because he’s the type that won’t risk driving angry. He’s so fucking *safe* like that. The look on his face is nothing but danger. “To have a conversation. I’m not upset.”

All Phainon can do is laugh, nervous enough that it bubbles right out of him with another tear down his cheek. “You totally are,” he says. “And— And I get it, I would be too, I—”

“Phainon,” Mydei says, tiredly now. He knocks his fist into the side of Phainon’s seat, leaning toward him. “I’m *sorry,* okay?”

“You’re…” He stops short, throat dry. “Sorry?”

Now, Mydei speaks slowly, carefully, studying Phainon to make sure that whatever he has to say lands correctly. “I am aware that sometimes the things that I say come out… more aggressive than I mean for them to.” His expression pinches at this, and it’s clear he’s discomfited having to say all this. He inhales through his nose. “I get… frustrated easily, but I am not upset with you.”

Phainon breathes out a laugh, a lump in his throat. “The way you’re glaring, I’m worried you’ll punch me in the face if I so much as look at you wrong.”

Mydei grits his teeth, blinks hard. His hand falls off the seat and he backs off, and suddenly Phainon can breathe again. “Not in the car,” he says, pinched.

“‘Not in the car?’” Phainon repeats, incredulous. “So if we were outside of it, you’d—”

A fist to the cheek. Not a punch, really, because Mydei is much too gentle for that, but there is a fist against Phainon’s cheek, shutting him up. “Don’t think I won’t,” Mydei says. “It’s not like I haven’t done it before.” And he has, during the bigger of their fights throughout the time they’ve known each other and during spars. He once chipped one of Phainon’s teeth.

As his hand falls away, Phainon laughs, helpless. His throat goes tight. His sinuses start to hurt as his eyes water, and god fucking damnit, he doesn’t want to cry now.

Mydei sighs through his nose and starts the car again. “Do you have your directions?” he asks as he pulls back onto the road. Phainon fumbles for his phone.

“Sorry,” he says, all watery, pressing the power button. “I turned my phone off by accident. Just— Just a second.”

A laugh. “For the record,” Mydei says, just driving. His expression pinches, a bit. “I care about you. That’s why I want to talk, not because *I’m* the one that’s upset, but because you are. And then I get frustrated because you’re so insistent upon suffering alone, even now that I know what’s wrong, even when I…” He grunts. “Nevermind. Sorry I blew up on you.”

Phainon clears his throat as quietly as he can, opening his directions as his phone boots up so slowly. “I’m sorry too,” he offers. “I just… don’t want to talk about this right now.” His throat is still choked. His sinuses are still stinging.

“That’s fine,” Mydei says. “Sorry I pushed.”

“In five hundred feet, make a U-turn.”

Mydei laughs. “Guess I went too far, didn’t I?”

△

They go grocery shopping, both for themselves, and for ingredients to make something for Cyrene. Phainon kind of just tails Mydei around the store like a lost dog, keeping quiet though his head is so loud. Various iterations of *he’s tired of your shit* play alongside various iterations of *your sister is going to die.* Neither is true. Neither is true, right? Mydei isn’t upset with him, he said so himself. And he’s always like this, a little bit gruff and grumpy, long-suffering over Phainon’s antics but ultimately fond of him, caring for him, happy when he’s around. Otherwise he wouldn’t stay, right? Otherwise he’d have left a long time ago like everyone else in Phainon’s life.

And Cyrene… She’s young and otherwise healthy. He’d spent a night drowning himself in statistics, and depending on the source, anywhere from seventy-one to fifty-two percent of her age group survives AML for at least another five years. More than half. She’s always been lucky, and she eats well and exercises, so that has to tip the odds in her favor, doesn’t it? And yet Phainon looks at those numbers, looks at her and her tired eyes, and he thinks *what about the twenty-nine percent that’s left? What if,* he thinks. *What if, what if, what if.*

What if he loses her too, just like he loses everyone else?

His parents in the fire that took his home away from him as a youth. One childhood friend to suicide, another to a car crash, all the rest to future plans that don’t involve him. He isn’t ready to grieve again, because he never really finished. He’s *still* grieving, he’s still stuck, and now his sister is sick and his most important friend in the world is a little bit upset with him, and his brain won’t *shut up.*

What if Cyrene dies, and Mydei finally gets tired of him? What then? Where does that leave him? What does that leave him with? Nothing, really, because Phainon is the type with a

hundred friends but only one who really knows him, and deep down, more than anything, he's terrified of being the only one left.

So here he is, following his best friend like a dog in the grocery store, keeping quiet because he's afraid to say the wrong thing and start another fight, the fight that ends it all. Keeping quiet because somehow he's grieving someone who's still alive, grieving the twenty-nine percent, because what if she falls in with the rest of them? What if she becomes one of those numbers? What if, what if, *what if*?

"You like these, don't you?" Mydei asks. He's holding up a box of those fluorescent orange cheese sandwich crackers. He likes to call them radioactive, likes to sneak them out of the shopping cart, likes to scold Phainon for poisoning himself when he eats them, but here he is, holding them up with his eyes averted.

He feels guilty, doesn't he? He's worried Phainon is upset the same way Phainon is worried he's upset.

Because… it's mutual, whatever this is. Otherwise they wouldn't have stuck together for so long.

"Yeah," Phainon says, though it comes out a bit weird. "I love them."

So Mydei just grumbles something about how he can't believe he's enabling Phainon's terrible eating habits and tosses the package in the cart.

Chapter End Notes

More characterization tidbits: I am a boyfailure Phainon enjoyer just as much as the next guy, but he's actually quite competent in this universe! He's a mediocre chef! The toilet sparkles when he cleans it! He can fold hella fitted sheets! He's just a bit clumsy (and plays it up because he knows it's charming) and tends to be rather impulsive. He does things without thinking and faces the consequences after, but he's a good enough problem solver that he never Really needs to be saved. Mydei just saves him anyway. He's an acts of service guy like that.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The hospital staff are kind and sympathetic in a way that doesn't make her skin crawl. They're used to this. They've seen hundreds of patients with cancer, with worse, enough that each case isn't some brand new, aching tragedy. Cyrene appreciates that, appreciates that they give her the facts and deliver her medication compassionately but without pity. She's spent more than enough time crying and pitying herself. She doesn't need it from the doctors too.

One the third day of treatment, Cyrene's red blood cell count gets low enough that she needs a blood transfusion. Everything makes her lightheaded and exhausted. Her muscles and joints ache, she's always a little bit nauseous, and she's plagued with diarrhea. Her mouth feels sore. She bumps her hip on the way out of the bathroom and later finds it bruised like a peach.

She's given a handful of medications to help the side effects: painkillers and pills for nausea, a mouth rinse for the sores. She takes them, but she hates how many drugs she's on, hates the way she feels, hates the way she can barely barely get out of bed.

All this, but on that third day before her last anthracycline infusion, the doctors test her blood and find that the percentage of abnormal blood cells is going down as planned. All this, and they tell her the treatment is working.

It's still early enough that things could change and go south, but as soon as she's alone, Cyrene cries with something like relief. The suffering isn't for nothing. The chances are that she isn't going to die. It's more likely than not that she'll recover and go back to living a normal life someday, however many months from now. She'll be able to go on walks and start swimming again, go back to work, go out and do things with her friends and her brother. She just needs to survive this first.

For now, she struggles through a meal of tasteless hospital food and tries her best not to throw it back up. It always feels like she will, even if she hasn't yet. She just has to eat slow, excruciatingly slow, because the faster she eats the more her stomach struggles to settle. It doesn't help that she has no appetite. The only thing motivating her to eat is the fact that she knows she *has* to.

Phainon and Mydei are coming again today, a bit later because she'd asked them to wait after the blood transfusion. Allegedly, they're going to bring soup. Part of her is afraid she won't be able to eat it, and all that effort will have gone to waste.

She hates that they'll have to see her like this. Tired, bed-ridden, broken to only her most essential parts. She's seen the way she looks in the mirror. Too pale, hair limp, so obviously exhausted.

The flowers Phainon gave her sit in a jar on her bedside table. The nurse helped her cut the stems and arrange them nicely, but they hadn't gotten to them in time to keep them from wilting a bit. They're still pretty, though. Big golden sunflowers, sweet white daisies, soft orange tulips. Sunflowers have always been her favorite. She's never met a flower so persistent. She's never seen a nicer shade of yellow. Spread the seeds and they'll grow anywhere. They remind her of her brother, a bit.

Oh, how she's missed his stupid smile. It's been a while since they both left their tiny hometown, but she still thinks of him, still misses him. They'd always been close, but the fire made them closer. And now, there's this.

When she's feeling a little better and one of the nurses comes to check on her, she pushes herself upright, legs folding, hiding a wince as the IV tube tugs at her port, still sore as the incision heals. "I'd like to ask something," she says.

"Of course." The nurse smiles. "How can I help?"

Knots in her stomach, nausea. She'd spent a long time looking at herself in the mirror before this. Working up the courage. "I was wondering if it would be possible to get someone to come and cut my hair?"

She doesn't want to lose it slowly, doesn't want to prolong the grief like that. There's understanding in the nurse's smile. "Of course," they say. "Haircuts are a free amenity for all cancer patients."

△

Phainon and Mydei come in time for dinner. She hears them arguing in the hallway before they even reach her door, and the sound of it makes her smile, makes her ache with this sweet, long-suffering nostalgia. She calls for them to enter when they knock.

Mydei comes in first this time, rolling the door open with one hand, the other holding a thermos by the base. He's calling Phainon stupid for some reason or another, and there's a smile tugging at Cyrene's lips before she realizes it.

Phainon comes in after, a book under his arm that she's fairly certain did not come from her shelf, shooting something back about how at least he's considerately stupid, and then he and Mydei take the seats at Cyrene's bedside and promptly stop arguing. Mydei looks calm and unruffled, expression smooth, eyes lined in red more symmetrically than Cyrene could ever hope to do on herself. Phainon is looking at her like he's expecting her to tell him he's won the lottery, dressed in a few too many of his favorite colors, hair doing anything but lying flat on his head.

"Hi," he says, hands on his closed knees, shoulders hiked up. Mydei lounges next to him, leaning back, legs spread wide, clad in all black, and something about it has Cyrene laughing hard enough that it hurts the incision in her chest and makes her nauseous all over again.

"Ha ha…?" Phainon laughs with her, clearly confused. "As much as I love to see you laughing, Cyrene, would you mind sharing what you find so funny?"

“Just…” She presses a hand to her chest, feels like her eyes are watering. “The two of you.”

“Soup?” Mydei offers, lifting the thermos, and it just makes her laugh again, softer this time because it still hurts and she’s still tired, but she reaches a hand out.

“Please,” she says, so he stands and rolls the tray table over her bed, unscrewing the lid of the thermos and offering her a spoon. After he does that, he waits for a bit so see if there’s anything she needs help with before he sits back down. He isn’t fretful in the way he helps, just quietly attentive, the same he is to Phainon whenever he isn’t looking. She likes it the way she likes how used to illness the nurses are.

“Improvised chicken noodle,” Mydei tells her, kicking Phainon’s ankle as they sit, hiking one arm over the back of his seat.

“Improvised?” Cyrene repeats.

“I forgot to buy eggs to make the noodles, so I just used the macaroni in your pantry,” Mydei explains. “I also added the mushrooms you had in the fridge; they were about to go bad.”

“It’s really good anyway,” Phainon adds.

Cyrene dips the spoon in the thermos, stirring the contents around. Sure enough, macaroni noodles surface. Carrots, celery, mushrooms, pieces of chicken all cut neatly. The smell of it is warm and hearty, the broth gold and shimmering, speckled with herbs. No one in her family has much of a history with cooking. Her mom liked baking, and her dad could make simple dishes every now and then, but that’s about it. She keeps herself alive by meal prepping twice a week and microwaving frozen or canned foods, but she never really makes anything like this for herself. Nothing that smells this good, certainly, though the macaroni is quite silly.

“It looks delicious,” she says, a bit hungry and still nauseous at once. Medicine has eased the worst of it, but she’s still nervous, almost. Hopeful. “Thank you.”

“It’s nothing,” Mydei says, and he’s been like that since she saw him last when they were kids. He’ll do a nice thing and do everything in his power to make it seem like nothing at all. Maybe that’s why he and Phainon get on so well. Phainon struggles to accept being cared for, and Mydei likes to pretend he isn’t caring for him. And now Cyrene by extension. “I had to cook dinner for myself anyway.”

“Sure,” she says, smiling slightly, stirring the soup for a moment longer before she lifts the spoon out to taste it. A breath, she takes a bite, chewing slowly, tasting it. Warm, savory, though light on the salt. The vegetables are cooked to perfection, and while the noodles are a bit of an odd texture, it still works. It’s good. Maybe the best soup she’s ever had, since she’s not in the habit of eating soup often, but it makes her realize she might be losing her sense of taste. Something is just a little bit off, but she knows that it’s her and not the soup. It was on her list of possible symptoms. *Loss of taste,* right alongside *nausea and vomiting* and *diarrhea.*

“What do you think?” Phainon asks as she swallows. He wasn’t even the one who made it. Mydei just sits there coolly.

“It’s delicious,” Cyrene tells them, stirring the soup some more so she has something to do with herself while her stomach settles from the upset of a single bite. Another bite, and the feeling isn’t quite so bad. It warms her from the inside. Her stomach calms faster and faster as she gets used to it, though most of that is the medication. Even if she can’t taste it all the way, it still feels like comfort. “You’re a wonderful chef, Mydei.”

Mydei just grunts in acknowledgment until Phainon kicks him in the foot and he replies, “Thanks,” after kicking him back. She has to laugh again, just softly. She’s always found them to be an odd pair. Good for each other, but odd. They’re so different and yet the same. They’re so mean to each other but so kind. At first glance, they’re terrible friends, at third, they might be halfway in love with each other.

“I brought this for you too,” Phainon says, holding out the book he’s been carrying. She doesn’t even recognize the cover, but the name of the author printed on it is one of her favorites. She reaches to accept it with her left arm, the side with the port, and winces at the soreness.

“I don’t own this,” she says.

“You do now,” Phainon tells her, this bright, awkward smile on his face. He’s never been much of a gift giver, but here he is. “You like this author, don’t you? I checked your Goodreads, and you rated three of their other books five stars, so I thought…”

“You stalked my *Goodreads?”* Cyrene laughs, turning the book over so she can read the summary on the back, keeping it clear of the soup.

“In my defense,” Phainon starts. He pauses, Cyrene glances up from the book to see him open his mouth and close it again. “It was Mydei’s idea to get you a book.”

“Shut the fuck up,” Mydei says, and then they’re kicking each other again. “You paid for it, and I didn’t tell you to stalk her.”

Cyrene just shakes her head and ignores them, finishing the summary. A girl inheriting the power of the God of Time and her journey to save the world with her childhood friend. It sounds interesting enough. Another bite of soup, she flips the back cover open to see the page count. Four hundred thirty-six. If the fatigue doesn’t make it hard to keep her eyes open, it should keep her occupied for a few days.

“Thank you,” she says, interrupting their squabbling. Both shut up, turning to her immediately, and that’s funny too. The way they’re so ridiculous for each other but on their best behavior for her. It feels like high school again.

“Does it look like something you’ll like?” Phainon asks.

“Yeah,” she says. “I do love this author. I’ll let you know if it’s any good once I read it.”

“Cool,” Phainon says. “Good. Nice. Yeah.”

She laughs through her nose and tells him, “Now stop buying me stuff. I have like a dozen unread books at home, and the flowers will be dead in two days.”

Phainon just makes a face at her. “So ungrateful,” he says. “Next time I’ll buy you *two* books.”

Mydei scowls at him. “That doesn’t even make sense; why would you buy her *more* stuff if she’s ungrateful?”

△

Later, Cyrene is working her way through the last dregs of the soup—cold now—and Phainon steps out to use the restroom. It’s just her and Mydei, who’s terribly polite to her, but also awfully quiet. She guesses she’d never really considered him one of *her* friends, even growing up, but they’d been friendly. They could joke and laugh together so long as Phainon was around. Now, they’re a little awkward.

He’s grown up now. As much as Phainon talks about him and shows her pictures, she’s still been imagining him as the teenager he’d once been. Still growing into his limbs, still learning to scowl, still swearing far too much. Well, that last one stands true even now, but he’s all tall and muscular and tattooed now. He has the scowl perfected—though it seems to be exclusively for Phainon so far—and if she didn’t know about how much he loves small animals and cute things from Phainon, and hadn’t tasted his improvised chicken noodle soup, she might even find him a little bit scary.

What a pair they make, Mydei and Phainon. It’s reassuring knowing that they have each other.

“I’m glad you two are still friends,” she says after a brief moment of silence, because Mydei may be terrible at small talk but she isn’t. The last bit of broth doesn't collect in her spoon, so she tips the contents of the thermos into her mouth. Just broth, a noodle and a single piece of celery. She sets the thermos back down with a soft clack, spoon jingling against the sides.

“Yeah,” Mydei agrees. His gaze drifts to the door, like Phainon is going to appear through it saying, *sike! You actually believed I needed to pee?* He doesn’t, and Mydei adds. “He’s like a fungus. I couldn’t get rid of him if I wanted to.”

She laughs at this, finds it funny because it looks like that, doesn’t it? Every friend Cyrene has ever had has casted Phainon as a golden retriever when asked what kind of animal he’d be. He’s very eager to please, very smiley, not quite clingy but open in his affection. Dog like, certainly. She wouldn’t be surprised if it were Phainon following Mydei around, but how many times has she listened to him on the phone talking about some adventure or another, saying *I wanted to do this and Mydei decided to tag along, I was going to do that but Mydei made me wait until his day off so he could join, I’m driving across the country to see you in the hospital and by the way Mydei’s coming too.*

So really, which one of them is the fungus? But she knows well enough not to say something like that out loud.

“Sure,” she says instead, stretching her legs out under her blankets, muscles aching a bit, “but he’s sweet about it. How’s he doing, by the way? I don’t think he’d tell me if he was having a hard time, not when I’m like this.”

Mydei hums, closing his legs when he seems to realize how he’s sitting. “He’s trying very hard to pretend he isn’t sad,” he answers. “But I think he’s more okay than not. He’s doing a pretty good job of staying optimistic.”

“Ah,” she says. She’d been worried. Phainon is very good at putting on a smile when he feels like he needs to. Sometimes it crumbles around the people he’s close to, but he’s good at it. She kind of wondered if he might be more afraid of this than she is. He’s lost too many people; he’s probably come to expect it left and right. She hates the thought. “The meds seem to be working, you know. I’m sure I look as terrible as I’ve felt the past few days, but they’re working. I’ve been trying to keep up a smile for him.”

“And he’s been trying to keep one up for you.”

She laughs softly, sighs, slides down in her bed so she can lay down. Sitting up so long makes her tired, and her stomach seems to have calmed after eating. A weak push to the tray table; it rolls away a few inches until Mydei stands and helps tuck it away, taking the thermos to bring home later. Oh, how she misses home. She just hates the way the hospital smells. The way there’s nothing for her to do but lay here and be uncomfortable and tired all the time.

“We would both do that,” she says. “We got lucky being so close in age; it meant *we* were close too. But now it just means we both see ourselves as responsible for the other. So we do things like this.”

“I don’t think he sees himself as *responsible* for you,” Mydei says, settling back into his spot. “He just wants to see you happy, and he’s scared of making things worse.”

Cyrene hums softly, watching the ceiling, the door that rolls open now. “I guess so,” she replies, but Mydei’s attention is back on Phainon, and they both know this conversation is over.

“I hope you didn’t miss me too much,” Phainon says, coming back in. “I may or may not have gotten lost on the way back.”

△

“I’m going to shave my hair,” Cyrene tells Stelle and Dan Heng when they visit the next day. They’re the two best friends she’s had here since moving away. Stelle is a friend from her old internship at a publishing house. They bonded over mischief and things they weren’t supposed to have access to. Dan Heng is a friend from college, initially a transfer student from China before he decided to settle for a more permanent stay. They bonded over a shared love of books. She’s still not a hundred percent sure how these two know each other.

“I think,” Stelle starts, “you’re going to look really badass with a shaved head.”

Dan Heng gives her a withering look. “That’s a hard decision,” is his reply, slightly more sympathetic.

They’d given her candy this visit, as they had the last, but Cyrene doesn’t have the heart to tell them it doesn’t taste right to her anymore. She nibbles on it just for their sake, tries to offer a smile. They both want her happy, they just have different ways of going about it.

“Yeah,” she says. “I just don’t want to sit around and watch it fall out, so…”

“Badass,” Stelle says again, and Dan Heng gives her that exact same look.

“Maybe,” Cyrene chuckles. Plenty of women look good with shaved heads, she knows that. It’s just… a choice, for them. It’s bold, empowering. For Cyrene the thought just makes her feel terribly small. “And it’ll grow back after treatment, anyway, so…”

“It’s still a hard choice,” Dan Heng repeats. “You’re very strong, Cyrene.”

This makes her laugh. Just a little, because she doesn’t want to be mean. This is the weakest she’s ever felt in her life. She can barely move, can barely eat, can barely do anything but sit here or sleep. Her emotions are all being trampled in the dirt, and here Dan Heng is, calling her strong. Here Stelle is, calling her badass. She feels like the opposite.

They’re just trying to cheer her up, she knows. They need to offer *some* kind of response or they look like total jerks, but these aren’t the words she needs to hear. She doesn’t know what those words are; maybe they don’t exist, but she doesn’t want to be told that she’s strong or badass. Not when she feels like this. It just sounds like something on a motivational poster. Like words for someone else, but not for her.

Having the right ones is so hard, she knows. What do you say to someone losing their hair if *not* those kinds of things? She doesn’t know. She’s too tired to think about it.

“Thanks,” she says instead. Tries for a joke, “I think I’ll look like an egg, the next time you see me.”

But it doesn’t earn the laughs that she means for it to. Stelle and Dan Heng just exchange a glance, and then Stelle asks, “Do you have a hat? Or a scarf or something if you want one?”

And oh, her throat tightens. Maybe those are the words. Maybe this is what it feels like to be cared about. “I have one,” she says. “Thank you, though.”

△

Phainon visits by himself today, though he brings a rice and veggie dish from Mydei in a plastic grocery bag.

“He said, and I quote ‘you can go by yourself today in case you want to cry or some shit without me there.’ He’s very considerate like that,” Phainon explains, helping to set up the

tray table so Cyrene can try to eat. Her appetite has been particularly bad today. Her mouth is starting to grow sores. “But if you miss him I can call him up.”

She smiles. “I don’t mind much either way,” she tries, taking the lid off the container of food. It’s quite pretty; not too greasy-looking, colorful from all the different vegetables. “He’s here for you more than he’s here for me anyway.”

“He’s here for you too,” Phainon protests. He’s always so weird when it comes to Mydei. Unable to shut up about him but defensive the moment someone comments on it.

“To some extent, sure,” Cyrene concedes, trying a small bite of the rice. The texture is perfect, but her tastebuds are still dull. “But he’s *your* friend, Phainon. If you weren’t here, there’s no way he’d drive thirty hours to see me.”

“It would be pretty weird of him to visit my sister without me,” Phainon admits, chair scraping the floor as he scoots it closer. He nods at the food. “How is it?”

“Good,” Cyrene says. If only she could just taste it, but she doesn’t say that. They put up smiles for each other. She doesn’t want Phainon to have to worry about this too, so she just takes another bite and smiles a bit. Taste is just another thing that she’ll have to wait to get back after treatment. Like her strength. Like her hair after she cuts it. “Thank him for me.”

“I will,” Phainon says, and hesitates for a moment. He reaches for the bag he’d had the food in, and it crinkles as he digs something else out. “I brought your hat, like you asked. This is the one, right?”

Soft, gray knit; he holds the beanie out and she takes it, feeling the fabric between her fingers. “This is the one,” she confirms, setting it in her lap. “Thanks.”

“Of course,” Phainon says, balling up the plastic bag now that it’s empty. His knee bounces as he sits. “Are you… cutting your hair?”

He’s more perceptive than most people give him credit for. This, though, must be obvious. Why else would a cancer patient be asking for a beanie in the middle of summer? “Yeah,” Cyrene answers, waiting for her stomach to settle. Nerves and nausea both, every time she thinks about it. “Figured it would be better than waiting.”

“Pythias would be glad you can’t break dress code anymore,” Phainon says with this sad attempt at a smile. And maybe he gets it. Hiding compassion behind humor. He’s grieving the same Cyrene is.

She laughs, softly. Her mouth hurts, muscles ache. “I miss being a kid,” she says. “Having teachers and rules to break. That was fun.”

“Mom always loved your hair.”

Her exhale comes out shaky. “It’ll grow back.” Now she’s the one saying useless things to fill the silence. “After treatment is over, it’ll…” She trails off, because it doesn’t matter. Sure,

it'll grow back, but it'll be months before it even starts, years after that to get it back to the length it is now.

"Have you thought about getting a wig?" Phainon asks gently. Her sweet, earnest brother. Always trying to fix things.

"Not much," Cyrene admits. "But… you're right. That would probably make me feel a lot better." She rubs the soft fabric of her beanie between her fingers. Knit with thin cables, old enough that it's starting to pill. "The hat will do for now. Everyone here knows I'm sick anyway." A bite. Her stomach turns against it when she forces herself to swallow.

"Maybe," Phainon says. He hesitates, his expression obvious and troubled. "Just think about it, would you? I can help pay if they're expensive, I—"

"No, Phainon," she interrupts him before he can continue down that path. This burden is hers; he carries more than enough of it anyway, just by being her earnest, caring, terrified of being left brother. She knows he's broke anyway. She hasn't questioned him coming here, but she does wonder if he can afford it. So much time off work, the cost of hotels and gas and whatever else they need out here. It helps knowing that Mydei is splitting the costs, but she worries. She doesn't want him to go, and can't bring herself to ask him to, but she hopes he heads home before the costs can amount to too much. "I don't want you paying a cent for any of this."

Now, his expression pinches. Brows furrowing, the corners of his mouth turning down. "Cyrene," he says. "How are you paying your medical bills?"

"Hah." What a thing to ask. He knows she's on medical leave and unpaid for it. Her insurance is good but cancer is a bankrupting affair even then. She has savings, but not *that* much, and he knows it.

"Take it out of the trust, however much it is," Phainon tells her. "Mom and Dad would have wanted it."

"That money is yours too, you know," Cyrene murmurs. In truth, she doesn't have many other options. In there is everything their parents left behind. They each used it to pay for their schooling and haven't touched it since. The plan was to save it to buy a house when the time came.

"I'll sign off on it," Phainon says without a beat.

Cyrene can't help a tired laugh. "That isn't what I meant."

"It's not like you'd need *all* of it, would you?"

"No." She shakes her head. "Not unless I'm stuck in treatment for years, I'd imagine. But… it would still be a pretty hefty chunk of it."

"That's fine," Phainon tells her. "Mail me any paperwork, if you need it."

She might take it for granted that she doesn't have a greedy bastard for a brother. She'd been planning to have this conversation anyway, but had no idea how to bring it up, and every other time they've been face to face Mydei has been there as well. This would've been an awkward conversation to have with him in the room. Maybe she's taken that for granted too, the fact that her brother's best friend is a far more empathetic creature than he tries to pass himself off as.

"Thank you," she says. One weight off her chest, though another, smaller but heavy with guilt and shame, settles in its place.

"That's what the money is for, anyway," Phainon says. "We'd be having this exact same conversation if it were me in your place."

She makes a face at him and nudges the tray table away, opening her arms in his direction. He laughs, stands up, and bends to hug her. It hurts a little, with the soreness of her port, but she presses her face against him as he rubs her shoulder. They don't get to hug all that often, but he's so warm. She'll never say it to his face, but he's probably the best brother she could ever hope for.

He smells familiar, and she laughs weakly, fighting the wave of nausea that hits her. "...You've been stealing my shampoo, haven't you?" she asks.

"No idea what you're talking about," he says as he pulls back, and they both smile as he rolls the tray table back over and falls into his seat. Quiet, just for a moment. "You should try to eat more."

She wrinkles her nose at him. "I'm trying my best, dude," she says, stabbing her fork into the rice and scooping up a bite. It's soft and probably delicious, but it goes down like gravel. "Distract me from the battle within my stomach, O Great Deliverer."

"It's been years since we brought that back," Phainon laughs. His tone shifts as he plays along. "Very well, Holy Priestess. What tale do you wish to be told?"

She laughs too, enough that it hurts a little, enough that her chest gives this warm, aching squeeze. "I don't know," she says, breaking character. She clears her throat. "What have you and Mydei been up to between visits?" she tries, because all they've been talking about is *her*. Her illness, her symptoms, her suffering. She wants to hear about something else for once.

"Some dumb touristy stuff," Phainon answers, toying with his choker as he reaches up to rub at his neck. His gaze shifts around the room like he's embarrassed, leg bouncing furiously. "We, um… We went and made candles, actually."

"Candles," Cyrene repeats, stirring the rice some more but unable to coax herself into taking another bite. Her insides still fight her. All she's doing is trying to keep them alive. "That sounds fun."

"They were way too expensive, but yeah," Phainon agrees. "Mine is almond and cherry scented. Mydei's was something fruity; pomegranate and pear, I think. We also went to the beach and the natural history museum and walked around town a bit. It's been… good."

“I’m glad,” Cyrene says. Glad Phainon is doing things, glad Mydei is keeping him out of his head, glad they’re… good. Not miserable like she is. Good. Together, like they always are. “Would you humor your dying sister for a second?”

Phainon’s mouth twitches downward. “You’re not dying, Cyrene.”

She’s not. She hopes she’s not. “Do you like him?”

Phainon’s gaze flicks about the room. “He’s my best friend. Of course I like him.”

“You know what I mean.”

A sigh. Phainon sucks on his teeth. “If you’re asking it must be pretty obvious how I feel about him.”

It is. So painfully obvious. They’ve probably liked each other for years now. “So why don’t you do anything about it?”

Phainon just laughs. “That’s a loaded question.”

Cyrene rolls her eyes. “It’s not like I’m going anywhere.”

△

They bring a hairdresser in the next day, a kind woman who offers a hand to help Cyrene sit like she only does it as courtesy, not because she thinks Cyrene needs it. She’s older; somewhere between fifty and sixty, and there are smile lines around her eyes. Her head, curiously, is wrapped in a peach colored scarf. The kind Cyrene has seen other cancer patients wear. She’d been considering finding one for herself, but for now she just has that old gray beanie she wears in the winter.

When the hairdresser notices Cyrene looking, she just smiles and says, “Alopecia areata. Most of the time hair grows back from that. Mine didn’t, so I started doing this because I know how it feels.”

“Oh,” Cyrene says, and there’s an odd, tight feeling in her throat. She settles into the chair, sick with nerves and nausea both. “That’s kind of you.”

“A little bit of compassion goes a long way,” she answers, wrapping a cape around Cyrene’s shoulders and buttoning it up in the back. “I’m Eleni, and I’ll be cutting your hair.”

“Cyrene,” she introduces herself in turn. “And I appreciate it. A lot, really. I don’t think I’d be able to stand watching it all fall out, so thank you.”

Gentle fingers in her hair, brushing it behind her. “Don’t worry about thanking me,” Eleni says. “Now tell me, are we cutting it all off today, or do you want to try something like a pixie cut?”

“All of it,” Cyrene answers. She tries to laugh a little, but it doesn’t come out right. “I just want to get it over with. Like ripping off a bandaid.”

“I get that.” Eleni pulls a comb from her apron and starts untangling the knots in Cyrene’s hair. “Do you want to donate it?”

An exhale, oddly shaky. Cyrene wrings her fingers in her lap. “Can I, even?” she asks. “It’s dyed.”

“Well, that depends on the charity, but yes. Plenty are happy to accept colored hair.” Eleni’s fingers skim her temples before she resumes her brushing. “It’s up to you, of course.”

“Yes, then,” Cyrene answers. “I want to donate it if I can.”

“Lovely,” Eleni tells her, and exchanges the comb for a couple of hair ties. She sections Cyrene’s hair into three, tying off each spot. “Anything you want to do before I cut?”

She’ll cry if she tries to wait much longer, and she really doesn’t want to do that. Not right now, in front of this kind stranger. “No,” Cyrene replies, and takes a breath big enough to make her lungs hurt. Her hands are weak where they tangle together and squeeze under the cape. “I’m ready.”

There’s the soft, metallic snip of Eleni’s hair cutting scissors. It’s a strange sensation, the way she can feel each strand break under them. It tickles, a bit. Eleni cuts above each hair tie, and when she’s done with the first spot, the short strands left over fall into Cyrene’s face. She exhales, rolling her eyes back to watch them sway with her breath. The second section gone. The third. Her head feels lighter. Her heart beats, beats, beats.

Next, Eleni prepares her clippers. Cyrene catches sight of her lost hair. Three pink ponytails lined up neatly. She hopes they’ll make someone a nice wig. Maybe someone like her. A kid with cancer. The thought comforts her more than expected.

“Ready for this too?” Eleni asks. Cyrene nods, wills away the tremble in her chest. The clippers buzz none too softly as they turn on. Eleni sets them to her head and starts to work, gently but efficiently. Cyrene closes her eyes. It tickles when the hair falls onto her neck or her cheeks. Soft like feathers. Soft like tears.

It takes no more than a handful of minutes, and then Eleni is cleaning her up and putting away her tools. The strangest part is how cold her head feels, how light. When Eleni passes her a mirror, she doesn’t recognize herself. Her face, her tired eyes. Another day, she might laugh and call herself an egg. Now, all she has the strength for is to ache. To feel the way her throat chokes up and her eyes grow wet.

“Thank you,” she says, all shaky, lowering the mirror because she doesn’t want to look at herself anymore. She loved her hair. Oh, how she loved it. How she misses it now.

A warm hand squeezes her shoulder. Eleni offers the beanie she set aside for this, and she takes it with trembling hands. The cold goes away when she puts it on. She can’t manage to stifle a sob.

Chapter End Notes

More tidbits(!): Cyrene tries to be very strong when it comes to Phainon. After their parents died in a house fire, they had to take care of each other. They were both closer than ever and fighting more than ever. Moving away from each other was good for both of them and their relationship. They both feel a bit responsible for the other, so they both try to put on a tough front so the other won't worry. Cyrene is also a voracious reader and frequent grass-toucher. Her screen time is like less that 3 hours a day for all devices, but now she's stuck with nothing to do but lay in bed and watch shitty TV all day.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Your head doesn't even hurt this time, does it?"

Phainon cracks an eye open. Mydei looks down at him, thumbs sweeping over his temples, fingers just a little bit cold. His crossed shins make a pillow as he leans against the headboard, Phainon laying flat, one leg hanging off the side of the bed. "Are you going to stop if I say no?" he asks.

"Fucking liar," Mydei snorts, but he just skims his nails along Phainon's scalp, raking his hair off his forehead so he can rub his small knuckles just above his eyebrows.

"I never lied," Phainon protests. "You sat down. I took advantage. It's not the same thing."

"Oh, so it's my fault for sitting down, then?" Mydei asks, and his ministrations stop so he can cup a hand beneath Phainon's chin and tip him up so they can look at each other. His fingers are a bit warmer now, from contact and motion. His knees against Phainon's shoulders, hand settling like it's rather comfortable on Phainon's exposed throat. He swallows, and he's sure Mydei can feel it right there in his palm.

"Now you're getting it." The weight of his gaze. He's… he's kind of obsessed with Mydei's eyeliner. His mouth is dry. One of Mydei's fingers slips under his choker. "Don't get mad at me for taking opportunities when I see them."

"Opportunities," Mydei repeats. He lets Phainon go, but the imprints of his fingers stay hot on his neck. "You saw me *sitting down* as an opportunity?" But he pets Phainon's hair again, so he can't actually be annoyed. Not when his touch is this gentle. Not when his expression is this soft.

"Well… Yes," Phainon agrees, shutting his eyes again before too much heat can gather in his face. Not embarrassment. Something else. He can still feel Mydei's fingers on his throat, can still see the smallest hint of his smile, and it's moments like these where this tiny part of him whispers, *he'd probably let you kiss him.* Now, with a foot caked in mud, on his car under the night sky. *He might even like it if you held his hand.* "And I took it. I'm a go-getter like that."

Fucking liar. Mydei's voice in his head. Oh, he could laugh. How many opportunities has he had by now? How long has he made Mydei wait?

Why is it *waiting* now, if he's never had plans to do anything about it?

"Sure, you are," Mydei says, softly sarcastic, carding his fingers through Phainon's hair, pulling it up like he's measuring its length. A little longer, his hands fall away, but he lets Phainon remain where he is. "How much longer are we staying?"

He opens his eyes, first to the ceiling, then to Mydei as he leans a little bit back. There's not much to see in his expression. He's just patient, just asking. Running out of time off. Phainon is too. They can't stay forever, he knows, as much as he'd like to. A sigh. "There's just two more days of this round of treatment," he says, holding his elbows. "Cyrene is coming home after that, so we'll have to be out of here by then anyway, but… I get it, if we need to leave sooner."

Mydei brushes Phainon's hair behind his ears. "I'm not rushing you."

"How much PTO do you have left?" If they leave tomorrow, they won't have to take any of next week off. Phainon will keep three days of PTO for the rest of the year. If they wait until treatment is over, that'll drop down to one. Mydei might have more than that, but it's still early enough in the year that using it all up is less than ideal.

"Enough," is all Mydei says.

Phainon studies him, trying to decide if he means that or if he's just saying it. He pulls the inside of his cheek between his teeth and finds it already sore. A warm hand folds over his eyes.

"Stop that," Mydei says.

Phainon blinks. His eyelashes brush Mydei's fingers. "Stop what?" he asks. He hadn't been doing anything but looking at him, but overthinking.

"I'm not worried about my PTO," Mydei says after a moment. There's something odd about his voice. "I'm worried about my laundry. I'm running out of clean clothes."

Phainon laughs weakly. "I don't think Cyrene will cry if you use her washing machine," he says. "But I don't believe you at all. We can leave tomorrow, alright? I've seen her and the treatment seems to be working… She— She's okay. I'll be fine."

"Phainon."

Phainon pulls his hand off and sits up, crossing his legs and trying to smooth down his hair where it's all messed up from Mydei's touch. "It's smarter for both of us," he says. "I've been trying not to think about it, but you and I both know I can't really afford to stay out here much longer."

Mydei is silent for a while, thinking about it, maybe. Marveling in the fact that Phainon is being reasonable for once in his life. God, what a mess he is. "Are you sure?" Mydei finally asks. "I don't mind staying, and Cyrene will be happy to have the support."

Phainon sighs. Pulls his knees into his chest like some scared child. "I'm broke, Mydei," he sighs. "I can't afford unpaid leave if I get sick later in the year when I'm out of PTO. I really shouldn't stay."

The mattress shifts behind him. A hand settles on his shoulder. "What about Cyrene?"

Phainon exhales, leans back until he falls against Mydei's chest, one leg shifting to make way for him, an arm banding around his waist. They're close enough that he's still sitting upright, but he leans his head against Mydei's shoulder, feeling the rise and fall of his chest against his back, his breath in his hair. "She's fine," he says, and tries to believe it. "She'll be fine. And I'll probably shit my pants from worrying about her, but what can I do? It's not like me being here is going to kill her cancer cells. She already knows I can't stay long."

Mydei is warm, warm, warm. He always runs hot; Phainon always runs cold. His hand settles on Phainon's thigh, squeezes lightly. "If you're sure."

An oil spill in his chest. "I'm sure," Phainon says. "We can visit her in the morning and then head out. I can make due with that. And… she still has all her friends out here, it's not like she'll be alone. We can— Maybe we can leave some meals for her in the fridge for when she gets home; I doubt she'll feel well enough to cook. Stelle—one of her friends—said she'd be around to take care of her when she comes home, but I don't know if I trust her in the kitchen the way I trust you, and Cyrene deserves the best so…" The chest against his back shakes silently. "...Are you laughing?"

Mydei does for real now, shifting to wrap both arms tight around Phainon, pressing his forehead in the space between Phainon's neck and shoulder, laughing. *Laughing* like some sort of maniac, hot like some kind of furnace.

"Mydeimos," Phainon tries. He sets a hand on Mydei's forearm over his belly, turning his head to try and look at him. All he can see is Mydei's hair, strawberry blond and cut in shaggy layers, dyed red at the tips. The shell of his ear, red too. He stops laughing after a bit, but he stays. His hold is so tight, but it's comfortable. Like being held up, held together. "Would you care to tell me what was so funny?"

"Nothing," Mydei answers, easing up a little. He sounds like he's smiling. "I can cook some stuff for her before we go."

Phainon just squints at the side of his head until they're making eye contact when Mydei looks at him too. They're close, a bit too close. A breath away, but Phainon is used to the fluttering feeling in his chest. It would take more than this to make him shy away, after god knows how many years of this. "I'm holding you to that," he says. "Dessert too, since you laughed."

And Mydei just laughs again. "Sure," he says, smiling a little, rolling his red-lined eyes. "Dessert too."

△

Between the two of them, there's enough dirty clothing to start a load of laundry. Mydei wants to separate the darks and lights, which Phainon has never bothered with all his life. In the end, he wins that argument, if only because a light load would consist of only three pairs of underwear, a shirt or two, and their towels, so they put everything in together. Phainon tosses in detergent and starts the cycle, listening to the sound as it fills with water, the way the clothes thump, thump, thump against the metal sides of the washer when the cycle properly starts.

“Is there anything else you wanted to see while we’re here?” he asks Mydei, who stands in the doorway with his arms crossed, supervising like he thinks Phainon is going to toss bleach into their darks. But it’s laundry, and Phainon has been doing his own since he was a teen and the only consequence he’s ever come across is the fact that his white socks are tinged a tiny bit gray.

“You’re the one that knows the place better,” Mydei says. Cyrene had moved away from their hometown too, and Phainon only visits. He and Cyrene never do much when he does; in all honesty, he doesn’t know the place well at all. They’ll go to the beach a half dozen times or more, they’ll watch movies at a local theater, they’ll go on walks to see the sunset. They’ve always been content to do not much at all, so he doesn’t know what else there is to do out here.

“Cyrene and I never do anything,” he says. “If it’s up to me we’ll just go to the beach again. Do you want to look for another museum or something?”

A scoff. “You hate museums.”

“I…” Phainon pauses as he closes the box of laundry detergent. *Organic, Plant Based and Vegan,* it advertises. *Fresh Lavender Scent.* It does smell quite nice. Halfway like Cyrene, just missing the rose scent of her conditioner. “I don’t *hate* them.” He taps on the lid, likes the way the cardboard sounds under his nails. Tap, tap, tap, to go with the thump, thump, thump of the washing machine.

Mydei raises an eyebrow. “You don’t do well with them,” he amends. “You don’t like standing around and reading signs and looking at stuff.”

Phainon frowns but can’t refute it. They’d gone to one yesterday and he’d been vibrating out of his own skin trying to concentrate on sign after sign, thing in glass case after thing in glass case. “Maybe if there was like… an audio tour, or more things to watch I would like it. Maybe that was just a bad museum yesterday.”

Mydei laughs at him for this too. “I like the beach,” he says, and straightens up from where he’d been leaning. He flicks off the laundry room light while Phainon is still inside, turning himself into a silhouette, backlit by the living room. “We can go to the beach.”

“We already went to the beach,” Phainon says, following him out. “Is there really nothing else you want to do?”

Now, Mydei navigates to the kitchen, pulling open the fridge to check its contents, checking the pantry too. “Is there nowhere else *you* want to go?”

“Well, no,” he says. Cyrene is the one that always wants to go to the beach. She likes the sound of the waves, she likes the seashells, she likes the sand beneath her feet. That’s a big part of why Phainon loves it too. He has so many memories there, so many smiles, so much laughter. But he can’t take her, so he wants to tell her about it. How hot the sand is, how cool the water, how fast the wind. “But I want you to have fun.”

“And I am,” Mydei says, shutting the pantry. “Is it really so surprising that I might like the beach too?”

“Alright,” Phainon says, raising his hands in surrender. “We’ll go to the beach, then. Cyrene is having a hairdresser come in so she wants us to come a bit later again, so whenever you want to go…”

Now, Mydei ducks to check Cyrene’s bottom cabinets. He has to look through two before he finds the pan that he’s looking for. “I’ll make lunch,” he says, straightening up and setting the pan on the stove. He stops at the sink to wash his hands. A full twenty seconds, like you’re supposed to. He rubs his fingernails into his palms, works the suds up his wrists and between his fingers. “That way we have time to switch the laundry before we go. She’s cutting her hair?”

Phainon shifts from foot to foot. Leans against the counter and finds that he doesn’t like the way it digs into his hip. “Yes,” he says, watching Mydei pull out ingredients. Bread, eggs, cheese. Fuck if he doesn’t make a damn good egg sandwich. “She’s… getting it out of the way.” They cried over it together yesterday. Cyrene’s beautiful pink hair. It’ll grow back. It isn’t even *Phainon’s* hair, but he feels grief over this too. So much grief over things he has no business grieving. Things that are temporary or still right here.

Mydei’s tank top is cut to show some of the tattoos on his back. The beginnings of bold red lines. He gets ticklish when Phainon tries to trace them to the dip of his spine where they converge. “Brave choice,” he says, “How does she feel about that?”

“Sad, obviously,” Phainon says. He pushes himself up to sit on the counter instead of leaning against it, heels tapping the cupboards when he swings his feet. He’s out of Mydei’s way, or he’s sure he’d get a talk about being a nuisance in the kitchen. For now, he just watches Mydei crack and open an egg in one hand and tries not to find it impressive. “She kept saying she just wants to rip off the bandaid. Let it hurt now so she doesn’t have to prolong it by losing it slowly.”

Mydei hums. It’s an approving sound, because he was raised on bravery and strength of body and mind. Most of his native Kremnoan culture has been lost to time and diaspora, but he still has this love of courage like no other. Sometimes it’s funny, alongside how safe he is. He’ll never pride himself or others on taking needless risk, but he’ll always stick up for doing the hard thing as long as it’s the right one. “And she doesn’t want anyone with her while she rips that bandaid off?” he asks over the bubbling sound of the cooking eggs.

“No.” Phainon shakes his head. “She wants to do it on her own, and I get that. I think if it were me I’d just be ugly crying the whole time, and that’s not really something you want your sibling to see.”

“Fair enough.”

He watches Mydei’s back. Feels that stupid sticky oil spill sensation come back. He swallows around the way it crawls up his throat. Not his business to grieve, not his turn to be sad over this. A breath. He practices smiling over the feeling.

Mydei prepares the bread with mayo and a tiny bit of mustard. They're both quiet as he works, listening to the sizzle of the stove, Phainon's feet bumping the cupboards. Mydei finishes with the bread and moves to flip the eggs. He points with his elbow to the ingredients on the counter. "Put those away if you're going to sit and watch."

Phainon slips off the counter. "Alright," he says softly, reaching for the bread, twisting the bag so he can fit the plastic clip on it and return it to the cupboard it belongs in. Next are the eggs and condiments, all tucked in his arm so he has a hand free to open the fridge. Mydei's eyes are on him as he shuts it, but he doesn't say anything.

"What?" Phainon asks.

"Nothing," Mydei says back, but Phainon gives him a look. Mydei gives one back, frowning a little and raising an eyebrow. It makes Phainon laugh weakly and flip him off, and then his expression smooths out. "You're allowed to be sad about this too, you know," he says. "It's empathy; it's not like you're pitying yourself."

"Fuck off," Phainon says, but he folds his arms around himself and feels so small. "I know that."

Mydei turns the stove off and moves the pan from the burner. His eyebrow lifts again, and he opens his arms with an expectant expression. Phainon steps forward and falls into him, trying to laugh, trying to feel upset, but he's so goddamn warm, and he smells like he's been stealing Cyrene's shampoo the same as Phainon has, and he looks like a total asshole but he's the best hugger Phainon has ever met.

"I'm gonna kick your ass one day," Phainon says, pressing his face into Mydei's shoulder. "You'll have to stop being so smug."

"Smug?" His arms around Phainon's back. He always hugs tight like he knows Phainon won't break.

"That look on your face," Phainon says, squeezing back. "I hate you."

"Sure," Mydei says, warm and sarcastic, the same way he says it when Phainon tells him he loves him. "You hate me so fucking much."

△

After lunch and switching the laundry, they get dressed for the beach. Shorts and t-shirts, because neither of them thought to bring swim trunks. Phainon dresses in blue and green, Mydei in black and gray, both of them coated in coconut-scented SPF 50. The drive is about fifteen minutes, a lot of that by the water, so Phainon plays some nice acoustic guitar music he thinks suits the occasion. Something soft and percussive. Mydei comments again, and Phainon tries to convince him to learn it with no success.

"I'm no good at fingerstyle stuff or percussion like that," Mydei tells him dismissively. "I know chords and that's about it."

“And how will you ever change that if you don’t try?” Phainon shoots back. Mydei looks over just so Phainon can watch him roll his eyes before he turns back to the road.

“Sure,” he says, “so why don’t *you* learn it?”

“Well…” Phainon did have a little stint with guitar back in high school. He thought it was cool that Mydei was learning, spent a week with blisters on his fingertips, and gave up when the calluses they turned into peeled off and playing hurt all over again. Mydei stuck with it, somehow. He isn’t impulsive in the way Phainon is, though. When he picks up something new, it’s with careful deliberation and persistence. So he kept it up and is pretty good at it now, though he’s no professional, and admittedly inexperienced in fingerstyle, but he spends a few hours practicing in his room every week, and Phainon listens to him play through the walls and develops a keen understanding of why women are 18% more likely to accept the advances of a guy with a guitar compared to one without.

“Skills are more easily built upon than learned from scratch,” he answers easily. “You’re already comfortable with guitar; picking up fingerstyle would be way easier for you than it would be for me.”

“Remind me why you’re so invested?” Mydei asks. One of his fingers taps the beat into the steering wheel, and he doesn’t just do that the way Phainon does. No, it means he *likes* this song. Instrumentals might just be their common ground; Phainon isn’t a big fan of Mydei’s old school rock and often finds his ballads a bit boring, and Mydei hates Phainon’s cutesy girl groups and complains about how dramatic showtunes are. He doesn’t comment when Phainon plays folk music most of the time, but his nose tends to wrinkle when the singer has a strong accent. He’s been doing his best to compromise with the softer songs on his playlists, but nothing seems to charm Mydei quite like instrumental guitar.

“Because I like listening to you play,” Phainon answers. “And because you like playing, obviously. Don’t you think you’d have fun learning something like this?”

“You are severely overestimating my capabilities once again,” Mydei says. “But sure. I’d have fun. Find something easier and maybe I’ll let you win this argument.”

They pull into the parking area, driving past a handful of cars before they find a spot. It’s not too busy today; some people in the water, a couple of boats. Kids playing in the sand, adults sunning and chatting in foldable beach chairs.

“Don’t say that if you don’t mean it, Mydeimos,” Phainon says, unbuckling his seatbelt. The music stops when Mydei opens his door, slipping out and turning to look at Phainon through the car. “You’re sending me on a mission, you know. I’m going to find you something.”

“Sure,” Mydei says, sighing for show. He shuts the car door, and Phainon is quick to slip out and follow him to the trunk. He pulls the door open to get to the cooler, digging out a couple of drinks. Lemonade for Phainon, kiwi strawberry Propel for Mydei, the only flavor they both rank in the top three. Grape is Mydei’s favorite, like some kind of cough syrup drinking maniac. “Just know I’ll probably reject a dozen choices before I agree to one. Your ability to gauge difficulty is terrible.”

And Phainon isn't the one who plays, so he can't argue with this. "...Good music is often difficult to produce," he tries, but Mydei just shakes his head and snorts as he shuts the cooler and hoists himself to sit on the lip of the trunk and pull off his shoes before they can get filled with sand. Phainon follows suit, though there isn't space for him to sit, so he stands on one leg for a bit. They leave their shoes and balled up socks in the trunk, and then Mydei is locking the door and they're hobbling to the beach, wincing as they walk over rocks and asphalt and bits of broken shells.

"Why's it gotta be so damn rocky?" Phainon complains as something stabs the arch of his foot.

"Because they don't dump sand all the way up here," Mydei tells him, unruffled or steel-footed, because he doesn't limp at all on the way. They reach the soft, sandy part of the beach and Phainon relaxes.

"Don't kill the illusion," he protests, feeling the heat of the sun-baked beach. It's almost hot enough to hurt. It's warm and blinding and a little bit windy today, stirring up Phainon's hair, making him squint. He takes a breath of the air, sea-scented and fresh, listens to the rush of the waves. "Beaches like this are gifts from mother nature, not man-made at all."

"It's not like they're *fake,"* Mydei says. It's a long walk to the water. Something prods Phainon in the arm. The sunglasses, held out without a word, Mydei avoiding eye contact like it's a criminal thing for him to be nice. "They just add more sand when erosion washes it away."

"Shh," Phainon shushes him, taking the sunglasses. He puts them on, feels his lips quirk at the corners.

Mydei huffs. A bit further, the waves brush their ankles. "...Quit smiling," he grumbles. Phainon just smiles wider.

"I can't help it," he says. "It's cute when you pretend not to be nice to me."

△

Mydei doesn't have the same attachment to the beach that Phainon does. He's been few enough times to count on his hands; Phainon has probably been enough times to need a dozen extra to count. He still likes the beach, though. He likes the sound of the ocean, the cool feel of it on a hot day, the sand, the smell, the way it looks. He's not the picture taking type, but he has a few of the beach in his photo gallery, and if they can find a good spot without many people, he might be tempted to take a couple more.

"What do you think?" Phainon asks, walking close enough for their shoulders to brush, a little clumsy as his feet sink into the sand.

"About?"

Phainon gestures vaguely. "I dunno. The city, the beach, the wind, any of it."

“I like the city,” Mydei answers. Water laps at his shins with the next wave. It’s cold as ice, but the sun is molten. “The beach is beautiful. The wind keeps blowing my hair into my face.”

“Hah.” Phainon smiles a little, looks at him. Mydei is reflected back in the sunglasses. Hair in his face, expression too soft. Is that what he looks like next to Phainon? Embarrassing. “I guess it’s worse for you, with how long your hair is,” Phainon says. “Did you bring a hair tie?”

“I forgot,” Mydei says. He’d thought of Phainon first, like some kind of fool. He grabbed the sunglasses instead.

Something tickles his arm. Phainon turns away and whistles conspicuously like they do in cartoons. His hand is held out. Between his forefinger and thumb, a black band and a bit of lint he’d dug out of his pocket.

“Fuck off,” Mydei says, snatching it with a laugh and shoving Phainon’s shoulder. He stumbles a step further into the water, and maybe they’re both only as bad as each other, because his expression is embarrassing too. Maybe if he said it this time, Mydei would actually believe him.

“See!” Phainon says triumphantly. “I can do it too! ‘Look at me, I’m not nice to people at all. I don't think of others and do sweet things for them ever, no sir! I just *happened* to have this hair tie in my pocket—’ Ah!” Mydei kicks water at him, but all it does is make him laugh and laugh, dancing away, kicking some back. “Don’t hate the player, hate the game,” he says nonsensically, backing up as Mydei pursues him, made unsteady by the waves.

“I could push you in,” Mydei threatens. They’re in up to their knees now, and Mydei wasn’t planning on getting his clothes wet. They didn’t even bring towels. “I could push you in so easily.”

“You wouldn’t,” Phainon says. Mydei starts to pull his hair back, sticking his drink between his legs and gathering it out of his eyes and into a ponytail as Phainon shakes his head. “Oh no. Mydeimos, you don’t want to do this.”

“Oh, but I do,” Mydei tells him, advancing until the water is too high for Phainon to avoid him without getting his shorts wet in the process. He grabs Phainon by the wrist, and then they’re struggling, splashing, laughing.

It ends with them drenched and searching for Phainon’s lost lemonade somewhere in the sea. It’s Mydei who finds it, but he makes Phainon bend to fish it out of the water and soak himself more in the process. He takes a sip of his own drink while he watches, safely held onto during their fight, and the withering look Phainon gives him is almost enough to start him laughing again.

And then they’re standing halfway up their thighs in the ocean, and the sun isn’t enough to keep them warm every time a breeze blows by. The smell of salt and sunscreen. Water drips from the ends of Mydei’s hair, bangs that slipped out of his ponytail, too short to stay in. Phainon starts to rock a little in place.

“What are you doing?” Mydei asks. They’ve sobered a bit now, as they tend to after messing around like that, energy worked off.

“Burying my feet,” Phainon answers. He’s kicked up the sand around him, so Mydei can’t see when he looks into the water. A stronger wave rewets the ends of his shorts and makes Phainon wobble a little. “It’s fun if you can get in deep. Cyrene and I used to try to get stuck.”

Mydei doesn’t reply, just watches him do it a little longer, watches the way he glazes over with this soft, nostalgic expression. That one shows up a lot lately. Mydei starts to work his feet into the sand too. It takes a moment, but by the time the tops of them are covered and all he can see are his ankles in the water, he feels rooted in deep. It’s a bit harder to correct his balance when the waves hit him. The sand is cool and comfortable as he wiggles his feet further down, moving sand and shells and rock out of his way to see how far he can stick himself.

“What happens if you get stuck?”

Phainon gives a soft laugh. The tired one, the nostalgic one. “It’s pretty hard to,” he says, “but once I buried myself to my knees. Cyrene couldn’t pull me out, so she got our mom. She liked to play along with all that bullshit about me growing up to be a hero, so she pretended to be some grand warrior tasked with assisting me on my journey. And then she just… grabbed me by the armpits and pulled me out.” He chuckles a little, kind of smiling. “God. You think your parents are so strong when you’re a kid. And then you grow up and realize they’re way stronger than even that.”

He’s looking out at the water, still trying to dig himself deeper. The water around him has cleared, and he’s stuck past his ankles. “My dad would have made me get myself out if I got stuck,” Mydei says. “Call it a test of strength. Maybe pretend to leave to create urgency.”

“Your dad was an asshole,” Phainon tells him. A pause. “Sorry. May he rest in peace.”

Mydei laughs at this. “No,” he says. “Good fucking riddance. He got way too much good for someone who gave so little. My mom didn’t deserve to rot with that guy. I didn’t either.”

Another beat of silence. He’s killed the conversation. “I’m glad you had parents that would pull you out,” he tries, though it’s weird on his tongue the way these kinds of things always are.

“Me too,” Phainon breathes. He stills now, not quite stuck, waves lapping at his thighs, still too soaked to start drying. He sighs, and Mydei gets this odd kind of relief knowing he’s letting himself feel whatever he needs to feel.

“You’re thinking about them a lot lately, aren’t you?”

“I always am,” Phainon admits. “Hard not to.”

Mydei hums in reply, giving him the space to speak.

“My mom loved the ocean a lot too. I think that’s why Cyrene does. She would take us all the time, so when I think of being a kid, I think of her smile and getting myself stuck in the sand.” Phainon pauses for a bit, taking a sip of his lemonade. Sun glints off the glass bottle, dripping with seawater. His hair is damp and curling up at the ends. He sighs, pulls one foot out of the sand, then the other. “This is me not being stubborn,” he says, facing Mydei now. “Are you sure you want it?”

Mydei holds his gaze, unsticks himself from the sand too. It clings to him and tries to suck him back down as he removes himself, an odd sensation, but… fun, in a way. He can see it, a kid Phainon and a kid Cyrene burying themselves side by side and cracking up as they pull themselves out because of how weird it feels. It’s strange, then, that this is the first time Phainon has done it with him, in all these years. He could say something weird. *I want you however you are,* maybe. *I’d listen to anything you have to say if it means there's even the slightest chance of seeing you smile.* “I can’t help much,” he says instead, “but I have functional ears.”

“Sure,” Phainon says, and it sounds like his walls are down, like he’s unlocked his doors and come out to sit on the porch, bruised heart in his hands. Another sigh. They start walking back to shore. There’s a breeze, and goosebumps rise on Phainon’s arms. “I just… miss them, you know?”

And he does. Mydei still has his mother, but he knows what it’s like to lose someone. What that feels like. An ache that might ease once the shock of it is gone, but never quite goes away. The memories stay, and humans are dreadfully nostalgic creatures. “I know,” Mydei says.

“I keep thinking about the fire,” Phainon continues, turning them to walk along that line separating wet sand from dry, one foot on each side. Cool and wet, hot and sunbaked. The waves don’t even reach their ankles here, just lapping the sides of their feet. “How sudden it was. How one minute I’m just this happy kid that’s never lost anything, and the next, my house is gone and my parents are too.”

Phainon is a tactile creature. He likes physical comfort, easy enough when Mydei is no good at words, but he might cut off whatever Phainon is trying to say if he goes for a hug now. His free hand is closer to Mydei. How easy it would be to reach out and take it, but they don’t do that, they’ve never done that before without some kind of pretense.

“I guess I’ve been stuck on that all my life. Reliving it over and over and always having this fear that things are temporary. And I never got over that after Livia and Piso passed.”

Childhood friends of Phainon’s, though this particular circle didn’t overlap with Mydei. They’d been a few years younger, neighbor kids Phainon used to babysit until they grew up and turned into friends. Mydei remembers, though. Livia died first in a traffic accident. Piso half a year later to suicide. “That’s not the kind of thing anyone gets over,” he says.

“Maybe,” Phainon admits. Those stupid sunglasses hide his eyes, and his eyes are how to read him. He’s sad, obviously, but… “You know what I just realized?”

His free hand, swinging at his side as he walks. Mydei switches his drink to the opposite side. “What?” he asks.

“Everyone I’ve ever lost has died so fast. One minute they’re there, and the next they’re just… gone. This is the first time I’ve ever had any notice that there’s something wrong, and it’s just throwing me straight into panic mode.”

Mydei reaches for his hand. Phainon’s head angles to look, and after a breath he laces their fingers together, lukewarm and covered in grains of sand. “Thanks,” he says, so softly.

“Keep talking,” Mydei prompts, and this comes out soft too. Phainon squeezes his hand. He squeezes back.

“I think I’m past the point of thinking Cyrene’s going to die, what with her treatment going well and her being young and healthy, but… I can’t shake that feeling, that *fear* that I’m going to lose her too.” His exhale is shaky. He clears his throat, and maybe his eyes are watery and wet. “It just spreads the pain out, you know? Knowing that something is wrong. Because now I’m like… pre-grieving someone who isn’t even dead, who isn’t even going to *die* and I just— I don’t have room for that. I’m still not over my parents, still not over Livia and Piso. What will I do if I lose her too?”

The rush of the waves is like a sigh. “You keep grieving,” Mydei answers, squeezing his hand. Phainon squeezes back. “It fucking sucks but that’s all you can do. You grieve, and then you grow enough for the memories to be warm instead of painful.”

Phainon laughs wetly, weakly. “That’s some poetic shit right there,” he says. “I didn’t know you had it in you, Mydeimos.”

“Shut up,” Mydei tells him. Their joined hands get trapped between them as Mydei wraps his other arm around Phainon’s shoulders. “Not everything needs to be a goddamn joke.”

△

They walk around on the beach a little bit longer, freezing in the wind, baking in the sun. Phainon finds a single seashell bigger than a half inch, something tinged blue and steeply ridged. Their clothes are only half dry by the time they’re trying their best to get the sand off their feet so they can put their shoes back on and head back.

Phainon plays more guitar music on the drive. They argue over who gets to shower first and end up playing rock, paper, scissors to decide. Mydei wins best four out of seven and refuses to let Phainon wheedle him into any more rounds. He showers first, Phainon second, and when he gets out he heads to the kitchen to decide on dinner.

He ends up making butternut squash and ginger soup with enough leftovers to leave two servings of it for Cyrene in the fridge and a third to take with them to the hospital. He isn’t sure how much time he’ll have to cook in the morning, but they’ll also leave behind the bread and fruit they’d gotten for themselves. Phainon wants to do more, but too many leftovers will only go bad in the fridge, and they never taste quite as good in the freezer.

So Mydei makes this soup—and it's damn good soup—and they pack up three servings so they can eat with Cyrene this time. Phainon holds the bag in his lap on the drive, taking the job of making sure they don't spill unnecessarily seriously, a new book plucked from Cyrene's shelves on top since she finished the last one.

The receptionist lets them head up right away. They take the stairs and make their way through the sterile-smelling hallway to room 216, and then Phainon pauses at the door. He takes a breath and sets his shoulders, lifting his hand to knock, hesitating some more.

"Phainon," Mydei rasps.

"I know." Phainon raps on the door three times, and Cyrene calls for them to come in. He rolls the door open and steps inside first, Mydei close after him, shutting the door behind them.

And there she is. Cyrene propped up on her bed, looking a little more comfortable than the last time he saw her, a journal in her lap and a pink and gold pen between her fingers. She's still hooked up to an IV to get her treatment, but she looks used to this now, not quite so tired. But the biggest difference is the beanie on her head in place of pink hair. He watches Phainon take it in. The tiniest hint of a sigh on his breath.

"Hey," Phainon says, kind of hovering in the middle of the room. His voice breaks, just a little.

"Hey to yourself," Cyrene says back, closing the journal and reaching to set it on her bedside table. Her hand quivers slightly. Still sick, still struggling. They're fighters, both of these siblings. Now, she stretches her hand toward them. "What did you bring? I've had nothing to read all day."

Phainon snaps out of whatever stupor he'd fallen into upon seeing her and steps further into the room, producing the book he'd taken off her shelf. It's thick, maybe six hundred pages or more, the cover printed in deep blues and yellow, accented with gold. *For the Sun is Set to Die* is the title, and she takes it gratefully. "I've been meaning to read this one forever," she says, setting it aside. "Hopefully it's good."

Phainon still doesn't say anything, even as Mydei takes the bag from him and nudges him in the direction of the guest chairs. He just sits heavily and stares, taking the container Mydei passes to him on autopilot, the soup still warm.

"Cyrene," he finally says as Mydei takes up the task of helping her with the tray table. She looks at him, clear blue eyes meeting clear blue eyes. So alike, these two, yet so different. "Your hair."

She exhales. "Yeah," she says. The glass of the container clacks lightly as Mydei sets it down. He's softer with the spoon, so it doesn't make a sound. "What do you think? Do I look like an egg without it?"

Mydei sinks into the seat next to Phainon, passing him the last of the spoons in the bag, engraved with little curlicues on the handle. "Maybe more like a mushroom with that hat,"

Phainon tries to joke, and then he sobers again. “Are you…?”

“I’m still getting used to it,” she answers his unspoken question. “I’ll admit, I did cry a lot after they cut it, but… It’s alright. It was cathartic. I’ve come to terms with it.”

“You look fine,” Mydei offers, and immediately regrets speaking. Cyrene smiles and turns her gaze to him. She’s different without her hair, but anyone would be. Anyone would look like a new person with half as drastic a haircut.

“Thank you, Mydei,” Cyrene says, chuckling a little. “And thank you for cooking again. I really hope it’s not a bother.”

“Not at all,” Mydei says. He nudges Phainon’s foot with his own, looks at him. “I meant it before; I have to cook anyway or this one will wither and die.”

“I can cook for myself,” Phainon protests, frowning a little. And he can, it’s just terribly mediocre.

“Sure,” Mydei says, and turns back to Cyrene. Something about the exchange has her smiling. He gestures to the soup. “It’s butternut squash and ginger. The broth might be a bit thick, but I made it a bit blander so it should be easy to keep down.”

“Thank you,” Cyrene says again. And he already knows she can’t taste much. He’s seen that in her expression, in the way it takes her so long to finish a bowl of anything. She won’t say so, but she’s easy to read the same way Phainon is, even if Mydei isn’t half as practiced with her.

“There’s some more in the fridge too, for when you go home. Hopefully you like it.”

Phainon sucks in a breath. “Right,” he says, pulling the lid off his own container. “We’re leaving tomorrow. I wanted to stay until this round of treatment is over, but we need to get back to work.”

“That’s alright,” Cyrene says. “I’m happy you were able to make it at all. It’s been nice seeing you. Both of you. It’s a lot less lonely with you coming around.”

Phainon stirs his soup. He has yet to try it, caught up in conversation as he is. Mydei chews on a spoonful. “Are you going to be okay?” Phainon asks. “I know you said Stelle was going to come over and help out, but if there’s anything I can help with, or anything I can do—”

“Phainon,” Cyrene interrupts, somewhere between amused and exasperated. It’s a feeling Phainon is an expert at bringing out in people. “I’m okay. I’m not a kid, yeah? I’ve taken care of myself while sick a dozen times; I can take care of myself through this too.”

“Yeah,” Phainon breathes. He wipes one hand on his pants, then the other. He flushes slightly, embarrassed. “Yeah, sorry, I’m just… worried.”

“It’s nice being cared about,” Cyrene tells him. “But I don’t need to be babied.”

“I know,” Phainon says, ducking to finally try the soup, spoon clinking against glass.

“Just let us know if there’s anything we can do to help,” Mydei says. “And keep us updated. I’ll try to make sure he doesn’t shit his pants.”

Phainon kicks him. “Shut the hell up; I’m fine.”

“Sure you are.” Mydei kicks back, and Cyrene laughs softly at their exchange.

“I’ll keep you updated,” she agrees. “And I’d like it if you did too. I’m so sick of everything being about me and my cancer. Share whatever you guys get up to.”

Phainon gives up on squabbling with Mydei to turn an earnest expression on her. “We will,” he promises. “And we’ll be back in the morning before we leave tomorrow, so don’t worry about us, alright? Just focus on getting better.”

“I’m doing my best,” she says. “Try not to worry about me either.”

“No promises,” Phainon laughs. “It’s chronic.”

△

It’s late by the time they leave, dirty dishes packed back into the bag swinging from Phainon’s hand. 8:43, seventeen minutes before the hospital’s visiting hours close, as late as they could push it before Cyrene’s energy started to flag and she melted into her bed with her eyes barely staying open.

Phainon’s mood dims the moment they shut the door, as it often does, but he’s usually like that. He gets sad once a party is over, lonely after a guest leaves for the night. It doesn’t matter how much time they spend together. It’s… part of why Mydei moved in with him. A Phainon left in solitude is rarely a happy creature.

As they approach the car, Phainon switches the bag from one hand to the next, twisting the handles in his fingers. Mydei unlocks the doors, and he hesitates.

“Do you mind if we walk?” he asks. At Mydei’s glance, he adds, “just for a little while. To… see the sunset, or something.”

“Or something,” Mydei repeats. He studies Phainon’s expression. Not drowning in worry or grief, just… he doesn’t have the words for the way Phainon seems to feel. A little bit tired. Lonely but not, sad but content. Mostly, he’s just kind of quiet, kind of contemplative. “Leave the bag,” Mydei says, so Phainon stows it in the car and they walk.

The sun is behind the hospital, so they make a slow loop. It’s quiet out, but for the hum of the hospital’s power and the occasional passing of cars. Mydei looks to the sky and finds that this might be the most average sunset he’s seen in his life. Just a splash of muted orange, cloudless and textureless, but Phainon wants to walk, so they walk.

“I like this,” he says after a while.

Mydei looks at him, gold cast and ruffled by the wind. “The sunset or the walking?”

“It’s not a very good sunset,” Phainon points out. Their shoulders bump. He always walks so close. “I guess the walking. Or the way my brain is kind of quiet for once.”

“You seem sad,” Mydei tells him.

“I don’t think I am.”

He doesn’t think. What does that even mean? “Alright,” Mydei says. He’s out of things to say. They’ve been glued to each other for the better part of a week now. Most people would probably be grating on his nerves by now. Phainon, well… he’s always grating on Mydei’s nerves, but he’s alright company. Mydei wouldn’t follow him everywhere if he wasn’t.

They finish their loop, the sun at their backs, the car in view a handful of seconds away, butter yellow and coated in water spots and a glob of bird shit. Phainon takes a deep breath of air that smells a bit polluted and steers them back toward the parking lot. “We can head back now,” he says. “I’m so ready to go to bed.”

“So early?” Mydei asks, but all he does is follow. He’s good at that, when it comes to Phainon. He’d probably follow him over the edge of a cliff if it came to it. There are words for that, but he’d rather not say them.

“Yeah,” Phainon answers. “I think the sun gave me a bit of a headache.”

Chapter End Notes

obligatory tidbits (5th edition): I said it in another chapter but Mydei's love language is 100% acts of service, which translates into other love languages when he thinks someone he cares about would appreciate it. He's touchy with Phainon because Phainon likes it, he begrudgingly says sweet things when he knows Phainon needs it, he spends so much time with Phainon because he knows Phainon doesn't like to be alone. He gets absolutely mortified when attention is drawn to it, but he lives to make the people he cares about happy, particularly his mom and Phainon. He's a big mama's boy. Phainon, on the other hand, has every love language in the book, and he's very free with his affection. He's puppy like that.

Chapter 7

The dessert Mydei makes at Phainon's insistence is a fruit cobbler with strawberries, peaches, plums, and nearly expired corn muffin mix from the back of Cyrene's pantry. It sounds a bit odd, but Phainon trusts the process, and when it comes out sweet-smelling and hot, he douses it with whipped cream and stifles an indecent noise at the taste when he bites into it.

"This is good," he says, pointing at it as Mydei watches with an amused expression. It's past breakfast time at the hospital already, so Cyrene will have eaten already, but they'll leave the rest for her in the fridge with the leftover soup as promised. "I like this a lot."

They're running late because of how long it had taken to make. Phainon doesn't even care. Seven pieces out of nine from the square pan are probably too many to leave behind for Cyrene anyway. They'll have to take some of the leftovers too. The flavor is light and honeyed, and the texture is surprising but it *works*. Phainon isn't even the one with the sweet tooth; what did Mydei put in this?

"Cool," Mydei says. "I wasn't sure about the corn muffins."

"It's good," Phainon says, stabbing another bite with his fork. "Goddamn is it good."

Mydei huffs a laugh. "Hurry and eat so we can get out of here," he says, brushing off the compliments as he tends to. But the smile is there, so Phainon knows it's appreciated. "Did you pack up your shit?"

Phainon covers his mouth as he talks with it half full. "My toothbrush is still drying, but I think I got everything else."

"Double check," Mydei tells him. "Don't forget your charger and whatever else."

"Yes, mother," Phainon says, swallowing. God, he loves peaches. "I take it you're packed too?" Mydei's hot pink duffle bag sits on the floor beside the couch, zipped up and ready. He packed up while the cobbler was baking, quick and efficient as always. He points at it with his thumb but doesn't bother with a verbal response.

Phainon leans toward him and squints. "But did *you* double check?"

Lazily, Mydei lifts his fork between two fingers, pointing it at Phainon, then at himself. "Which one of us forgets things?" he asks. "You or me?"

Phainon laughs, flips him off. "You suck," he says.

"And who made that goddamn good cobbler you've been drooling over all morning?"

Now, Phainon puts his hands together and pretends to bow. "You did, Your Highness," he says. "God of the kitchen. This mortal one can only bow before your talents and grovel for your blessings."

“Submit or starve,” Mydei tells him, chair screeching as he pushes it back to stand and grab a cup of water. As he sits back down, glass clinking, he asks, “Did you tell Cyrene we’re running late?”

“Yeah, she knows,” Phainon answers, finding his piece almost gone. He’s tempted to go for another. A glance at Mydei, then his plate. He scoops the last bite into his mouth and stands to get another. “She called us stupid.”

“Shut up with your mouth full,” Mydei scolds. “And she’s right. We’re going to get to the hotel in the middle of the night again.”

“But cobbler,” Phainon says, mouth still full. He tops this second piece with a smiley of whipped cream, then fills in the gaps because it isn’t quite enough. He sits back down, and Mydei’s mouth wavers before he purses it to hide a smile. He’ll never admit it, but every now and then he loves flattery. He only ever pretends to be humble.

“Yeah, yeah,” he says. Another bite. He chases it with water. “Hurry up.”

△

Cyrene is glad to see them. She’s tired again today, mentioning aches and bruises and lethargy, though she doesn’t complain much. Only ever in small doses, and never in a way that generates real concern. But Phainon knows her well, and worries anyway like he’ll get withdrawals if he doesn’t.

On the bedside table, Cyrene’s sunflowers are already wilting, dropping petals and sagging under their own weight. They must’ve spent too much time without water. Cyrene herself sits cross-legged in bed with her hat on and both her journal and the book Phainon brought her the day before in the blankets with her. Her bookmark sticks out from between the pages, already a fourth of the way through.

“Call if you need anything,” Phainon tells her.

“I will,” she says, half smiling.

“Mail me the paperwork for the trust.”

“I will.”

“And make sure—”

“Phainon,” she interrupts him. He stops short, chastened, and holds his tongue. “I’ll be fine. You’ll know if things go south and you need to come back out. Unless that happens—and that’s a big *if,* mind you—you don’t need to worry about me so much, okay? I’ll update you.”

Phainon lets the inside of his cheek go from where he’d been chewing on it. Mydei’s foot nudges against his softly. “Alright,” he says. “Sorry if I’m being overbearing.”

“A little,” Cyrene admits, softening. “But I probably would be too in your place. Just… try not to worry about me too much.”

He brings a hand to his brow in a salute. “Aye aye,” he says, and it makes her smile. “I’ll call you sometime on the way home too, okay? If you can handle me being annoying for a little longer. We’ve got thirty hours of driving and not much else to do either way.”

“And I’ve got a couple more days of this and not much to do either, so I think I’ll be glad to have the distraction.” Again, Mydei’s foot taps his. He leaves it there, close. Cyrene sighs a little, taps her fingers on the hard cover of her journal. “Stelle and Dan Heng are visiting again, so probably don’t call later today.”

“Noted,” Phainon says. He glances at Mydei, who just sits and listens, sits and listens. He’s done his eyeliner differently today, just on the lower lid of one eye. It would probably look weird on anyone else, but he makes it work as good as he made that goddamn cobbler. “There’s soup and fruit cobbler in the fridge for you. You go home the day after tomorrow, right?”

“Yes, finally,” she confirms.

“We changed the sheets and stuff for you too; everything should be ready so you can just relax when you get there.”

“I have done way too much relaxing,” she says, smiling, “but thank you. I appreciate it a lot. You guys coming to see me, cooking for me, all of it. It’s been… really nice.”

“Hug?” Phainon asks.

Her eyes smile more than her mouth. “Hug,” she confirms, gingerly sliding herself off the bed to be in a better position for it. Phainon wraps her up, fighting the urge to squeeze her tight in case it might hurt, mindful of the IV tube stretching behind her. She smells like hospital linens and he misses the tickle of her hair, but she’s warm and she laughs a little against him. “I’ll miss you,” she says, and tiptoes to peer over his shoulder. “You too, Mydei. Thanks for coming out with him.”

“Any time,” Mydei says, kind of soft.

Another breath, and Phainon pulls back. “Alright,” he breathes. “We’ll get out of your ha—ah…” They look at each other for a moment, Cyrene expressionless, just staring enough that guilt squirms in his stomach, and then she’s laughing, she’s laughing so hard it seems to hurt her, sitting back down and shaking her head.

“Get out,” she says, still laughing, and the sound of it has him laughing too. “Get out, you’re banished!”

“Sorry!” Phainon tries, but she kicks him toward the door, grin straining her face. “Really, that was in terrible taste and I didn’t mean it, I’m sorry!”

“Bye, Phainon. You have like, ten hours to drive today; *leave.”* Her eyes sparkle. Phainon grabs his bag and heads toward the door.

“Bye, Cyrene,” he says, rolling it open. “Talk to you soon.”

“Yeah, yeah,” she says. “Bye Phainon, Mydei. Keep in touch or whatever.”

Mydei lifts a hand to her on his way out, and then the door rolls shut between them and the hallway is uncomfortably silent. Phainon sighs and follows Mydei down the familiar path to the stairs. Warmth in his chest, the way it eases into something soft and bittersweet. God knows when he’ll be able to make it out here again. Christmas, if they follow the usual plan. Knowing she’s sick, he’s afraid to wait that long.

A glance at Mydei. He’s got this half smile going when their eyes briefly meet. “You guys are fucking weird,” he says.

Phainon bumps him. “Like you’re so normal,” he says. At the top of the stairs, he pauses, stretches an arm in front of Mydei to make him pause too. He smiles before that bittersweet feeling can take over. “Race you.”

“Not helping your case,” Mydei tells him, but he gears up for it as Phainon counts down. At *go,* he drops his arm and they thunder down the stairs neck and neck before Phainon pulls just a bit ahead since he has the inside of the bend. At the bottom, he laughs, heart beating hard in his chest.

“I believe the victory is mine,” he says, ignoring the looks they get from the noise they must have made, the annoyance on Mydei’s face. He pretends to think for a moment. “As my prize, we’ll be listening to girl group music for the first hour of the drive.”

“I swear to god,” Mydei sighs. “You fucking suck.”

△

Contrary to popular belief, Phainon is not a complete menace. He keeps the obnoxiously cutesy stuff to the first fifteen minutes of the drive, just to see the way it makes Mydei frown. He doesn’t even play some of the super high-pitched stuff he has buried in his playlists. Only the best of the best, only the classics. At the last song he picks, something upbeat and deeply danceable, Mydei either gets tired of scowling or can actually tolerate this song, because his expression smooths out as he drives.

The second chorus comes on, and one of his fingers starts to give a traitorous tap to the beat. Phainon watches, just for a bit, just to make sure it isn’t some kind of fluke. But no, Mydei keeps it up, tapping out the beat to this song belonging to a genre he’s sworn again and again is his mortal enemy.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon says. A grunt. “Have you, by chance, taken a *fancy* to this song?”

And oh, he can *feel* the way Mydei sighs. He stops tapping the beat. “No,” he says, long suffering and sick of Phainon’s bullshit. “I have not.”

“You were tapping the beat,” Phainon teases, lips pulling up. “You don’t do that unless you like the song. Admit it.”

Mydei's mouth presses into a firm line. He doesn't spare Phainon a glance. "It's way too cutesy for a bunch of grown ass women," he says, but it isn't a denial.

"Sure, sure," Phainon waves that off. "But do you *like it?"*

"Crashing the car is an option readily available to me."

It startles a laugh out of him, knee bouncing, fingers tapping on his phonecase. The last chorus of the song starts, and there's tension in Mydei's jaw. "So stubborn," Phainon notes. "Didn't we already have this discussion? We'll both die if the car crashes."

"Yes," Mydei agrees, and his finger lifts on the steering wheel before he deliberately sets it back down off beat. "The afterlife sounds much kinder than this hell."

"You're such a hater," Phainon tuts. "Well, if it's all the same to you, should I play that song where they bark and sing about wanting to be dogs? I can always put that on next."

"So we're off to the afterlife together, is what I'm hearing," Mydei says.

"It'll be a good bonding experience."

A little longer and the song comes to an end. Phainon has mercy and chooses something fairly normal to play next because he's kind and benevolent like that. Mydei props one elbow on the edge of his window and drives one-handed for a while. The air conditioning works overtime as the sun beats down on them. Phainon snags the sunglasses out of the center console and slides them on. In the sun visor mirror, his reflection looks a bit silly. Somehow, Mydei always makes these look cool. Hell, he makes everything look cool. No point in acting surprised.

"This is fun," he says after a while. Not the driving, but the road trip, the time together in a setting so different from their home. Mostly, he likes the fact that he isn't alone. He'll crash later and cry, he's certain of it. He'll think of Cyrene's hair and her exhaustion, and his long dead parents and friends and he'll fall apart, but right now he's about as happy as a person can be with a lifetime of grief stored in their chest.

"Fun," Mydei repeats dryly. Mydei, who isn't upset with him, hasn't been. Mydei, who has stuck around longer than anyone Phainon's ever known, aside from Cyrene, who doesn't quite count because she's his sister.

"Are you insinuating that you *don't* love sitting in a hot car for hours on end with only your best friend and his delightful music taste to keep you company?"

"Delightful is a word for it," Mydei retorts.

"It certainly is," Phainon agrees, "One you used, even."

"You're just saying shit at this point," Mydei says. "Either let the important stuff out or shut up."

He must be clearer than water, than glass, than crystal. Mydei can smell sentimentality like a shark can smell blood in the water. “Everything I say is important,” Phainon tells him.

“Sure.”

“You suck,” Phainon laughs, and he can’t even pretend to be offended. “And here I was about to say nice things about you.” Mydei’s nails digging into the steering wheel. His eyeroll, the dismissive grunt he lets out.

“Don’t hold back on my account,” he says.

He’s such an asshole, but he isn’t at all, really. They’re just like this. Phainon flip flops between feeling scared and feeling secure, but right now that emotion in his chest is warm and settled. This is it. This is them. They have a long way to go to get home, but Phainon doesn’t mind it at all.

“Thirty more minutes,” Mydei says. “Play whatever dumb shit you want now, because I’m only putting up with it for another thirty minutes, and then you’re driving and I’m controlling the music.”

Phainon laughs through his nose. “Got it,” he says, and scrolls through his playlist for the worst songs he can possibly find.

△

Phainon lasts a surprisingly long time before they swap. He makes it three and a half hours, tapping his foot and his fingers, and talking about whatever random things come to mind the whole while. Mydei lets him go on about *Antiques Roadshow,* which he’s had a very strange obsession with for a few months now. He wants to get into antique appraisal and collecting, and always gets pouty when Mydei tells him he’s just going to get scammed.

But he listens, because Phainon needs someone to listen to his shit or he’ll wilt like Cyrene’s flowers did. So much of Mydei is dedicated to keeping him happy. It’s getting embarrassing.

They stop for lunch at a ramen restaurant, and Phainon bets that he can’t handle the spiciest thing on the menu, which means they both end up ordering it and suffering. Mydei’s nose runs and his mouth feels lit on fire, but he manages to finish his bowl before Phainon does. As his prize, Phainon—who just sits there, red as a lobster, tearing up a little from the spice—must comply with his demands for the music for the entirety of his shift driving.

Mydei’s turn passes pretty uneventfully, aside from Phainon’s complaining every time he makes him put on yet another Metallica song. They fill up on gas and end up in the middle of nowhere for a while, driving eighty-five on a road they have pretty much to themselves. Phainon would probably be going over a hundred.

Eventually, they lose service and are left with only the music Phainon has downloaded on his phone, which means Mydei has to forfeit his prize, but he still has skipping rights every time Phainon tries to turn on something atrocious. Another three hours pass like this. The sun puts itself in an unpleasant position as it starts to creep downward, right in their eyes as they drive

west. When they return to civilization, Mydei makes Phainon take over again, stretching a bit before he settles into the passenger seat, loading up a couple of the songs he'd wanted to make Phainon play before the lack of data cut him off.

This first one has a full minute of electric guitar for an intro, and Phainon gets all excited saying he should learn it.

"I play acoustic, Phainon," Mydei reminds him, but he just grumbles a bit and gets excited again as soon as the vocalist comes in.

"You could sing too!" he says. "You've got that growl like he does, you totally could!" He glances at Mydei, bug eyed with the sunglasses and smiling enough for Mydei to see the points of his teeth, and Mydei can't do anything but laugh in his face, incredulous.

"Absolutely fucking not."

It takes about forty-five minutes, but the road they take gradually turns windy and steep as they disappear from the city and into a mountain range that blocks out the sun. It's verdant and lush this time of year, and in the shade it's almost cool, so they roll down their windows to breathe the air. Phainon takes the sunglasses off and looks like a happy dog with the wind in his hair. Mydei watches his profile. The line of his nose, his jaw, the choker around his throat. His gaze is sticky. He turns away before he can get stuck.

The car grumbles as it climbs the slope, Phainon on the gas, not speeding much on a road that curves this much. Give him a straight-away and he'll go thirty over the speed limit without even noticing it, give him bends and turns and hills and he'll end up ten under and white-knuckled on the steering wheel. At the very least, Mydei's never felt *unsafe* with him at the wheel.

"Thank god we're in my car and not yours," he says as they reach the crest of the hill. The road evens out for a quarter mile or so before another incline starts. Around them, trees whisk by and wind buffets them from the open windows.

"Mine would make it," Phainon protests, barely sparing a glance as the road starts to curve a bit. His fingers clench tight on the steering wheel.

A sign: *SCENIC OVERLOOK 2 MILES.* Mydei props an elbow on the window and fights the smile that tries to creep its way onto his lips. "Respectfully, Phainon," he says, "you drive a fucking canoe."

"Shut up, it's not a *canoe,"* Phainon complains, bouncing his free leg and saying the word *canoe* all silly.

He drives a 1999 Toyota Avalon. Peeling off-white paint, three rock chips in the windshield, an interior that smells faintly like gasoline. It's low to the ground, short, and looks, frankly, like a fucking canoe. He bought it off a neighbor and is pretty good about keeping up with the maintenance on it, or it wouldn't have lasted so long, but the mileage it gets is abysmal and it fights for its life every ride because of how fast Phainon drives the little thing.

“It’s too small to be a boat,” Mydei tells him, and Phainon pretends to be upset but he laughs, and the wind blows the hair off his forehead, and he just looks… Charming. That’s probably a good word for him. It’s probably impossible to look at Phainon and dislike him.

“You suck and I hate you,” Phainon laughs, bringing them up the second incline, foot on the gas. As he catches up to a car ahead, he relaxes a little, no longer at the front of the line. “Walk home.”

“This is *my* car,” Mydei points out. “You can walk home.”

Phainon pretends to think about it. “But I’m taking the snacks,” he says.

“Damn,” Mydei retorts, “and I was *so* excited to eat those radioactive cheese crackers.”

A laugh. Phainon has a laugh like gold. “That’s right!” he exclaims. “Bow and grovel, and perhaps this venerable one shall take pity on you.”

“‘O Great Phainon of Myrtle Point, Oregon,” Mydei starts, tacking on Phainon’s hometown just to add words to the bullshit title.

“Yes, Devoted One,” Phainon says, deepening his voice like he’s the main character of a fantasy movie or narrating a car commercial. “Your God listens.”

Mydei flips up both middle fingers and says, “Go fuck yourself.”

They devolve into laughter from there. Phainon gets them up the incline, past the edge of the mountain, and the sun comes out, about to set, casting everything in gold. The road, the steep, forested drop to their right, blocked with a guard rail. Below that, city and nature sprawl out. Warm wind hits Mydei’s face as he turns his body to look out the window, tasting the air, kind of awed by the beauty of it.

“I’m stopping at the overlook,” Phainon informs him, and he doesn’t see any reason to protest. The car pulls into the tiny gravel parking lot marking the place, and they roll up their windows and slip out of the car to look, feet crunching in the rocks, the backs of their shirts soaked in sweat from sitting so long.

There’s a stone half wall blocking the edge, built from red and gray bricks and reaching about waist height. The top is coated with a smattering of bird poop, and there are a couple of placards that Mydei doesn’t bother to read as he steps up to look at the view, Phainon at his shoulder.

They’re lucky, because they’re the only ones here. It’s a small overlook, not half as big and touristy as some that he’s seen, but it isn’t lacking for that, not at all.

The hiss of wind through leaves, pulling hair out of Mydei’s ponytail. The air is sweet and fresh. Still warm, but not baking in the way it would be earlier in the day. He squints as he looks out. Directly below them, a pale stone cliff face, rough and textured from weather, scraggly trees rooted in place. Further out, rich green forest and the city, so huge and so tiny at once. They can see suburbs and tall city buildings. A sky that stretches endlessly, pale blue

and spotted with clouds, a blinding sun over the horizon. Now, he shields his eyes and takes his phone out for a picture. He takes two in landscape mode so he can choose which one came out better later, and then he slips it back into his pocket.

"This view," Phainon says, bracing his hands on a poopless spot of the half wall. "Goddamn." It's beautiful. A bit painful to look at, what with where the sun is. Phainon is squinting a bit, hair flipped off his forehead by the breeze, the light casting him in warm gold. "Too bad we aren't here like twenty minutes later. The sunsets have to be amazing from here."

"I'm sure," Mydei agrees. The sun on Phainon's neck, banded by his choker. His shirt collar flaps against him in the breeze. Mydei's gaze is stuck on the bowl of his throat. "It's beautiful."

A soft hum. Phainon rocks on his heels, but he doesn't turn to Mydei as he replies, "Look at the view when you say that, not at me."

Gold in his hair, on his neck. Mydei sighs, turns back to the view. Their shoulders brush when he bends forward to lean on the wall, forearms folded atop it, back rounded. Hot, coarse stone. The soft fabric of Phainon's t-shirt against his bare arm. "What an ego," he murmurs, "to assume I was talking about you."

Phainon mirrors his position, and nevermind that they have a dozen yards of the wall to themselves, he picks the spot right next to Mydei, close enough that their arms press tight together. Mydei is probably tacky with sweat. Their triceps will stick when they pull apart.

"What, you weren't?" Phainon gives this soft laugh, more air than sound. "You've been looking at me all day, don't think I don't notice that, even when I'm driving."

Mydei's been dancing like a goddamn monkey for him for how long now? He doesn't even know. So long he's lost track of it. But no one counts their breaths, no one measures each and every beat of their heart. Of course he wouldn't be able to pinpoint when it started beating for Phainon. What does it matter, to let it beat like that a little longer.

"What was it that you said the other day, 'I'm always looking at you?'"

Phainon rocks into him a little. "And you know what you said after?"

"'That's a weird fucking thing to say.'"

Again, Phainon does that same laugh. The soft one, like a setting sun. "How the tables have turned," he says. He sounds lighter, less bogged down by his grief, happier since he saw Cyrene. Mydei hopes it stays that way. Loves him happy but hates to *make* him happy, to be the cause of it, because it makes him feel like his stomach could turn inside out and like this could be permanent and real, and not just something Phainon plays around with on a whim. "So you *were* talking about me."

A breath. Something flips inside him, climbs up his throat, whispers that *this could be it. Maybe he wants you too, maybe he's just as sick of pretending as you are.* "Do you really want me to answer that question?"

Are you ready? Mydei wonders. *Can we finally have this conversation now?*

Phainon turns to look at him. He's close, but Mydei already knew that. His eyes are bluer than the sky or the sea. "Maybe…" He wets his lips, flicks his gaze between each of Mydei's eyes. "Maybe I do."

Mydei studies him back. His hair in the breeze. His parted mouth, his open, kind of hopeful expression. Strangely, the panicked, fluttery thing sitting in Mydei's chest calms. Like listening to his own heartbeat, like counting his breaths. He lets the silence stretch a little longer, just to see if Phainon will turn away and laugh it off like some kind of joke. But he just stays, just looks. They're both always looking at each other.

"Yes, then," Mydei says. He's always been disgustingly sappy on the inside. A hopeless romantic, as much as he tries to hide it. Phainon tends to run into things head first, but even he's cautious when it comes to this. "I think you're beautiful."

He can hear Phainon's inhale, his hitch of breath. A second goes by, and then Phainon is turning away and covering his mouth. The shell of his ear goes crimson as Mydei watches, this *feeling* blooming in his chest. Warmth crawls up his neck. He's sure he's blushing too. He turns back to the view to map the lines of streets with his eyes, clearing his throat.

"Phainon," he gets out, helpless.

"Sorry," Phainon replies. His voice sounds all weird. He clears his throat too. "Sorry, I wasn't expecting you to just say it."

"You asked for it," Mydei reminds him.

"Yeah," Phainon breathes. His laugh is kind of overwhelmed. "It's, um. It's mutual, by the way. I think you're beautiful too."

Mydei can feel how red he must be. He ducks to hide his face in his arms. "Shut up if you're going to be weird," he grumbles. Another chuckle. Phainon bumps him again, draws away, their tacky skin sticking.

"Mydei," he tries.

"Whenever you're ready," Mydei says into his arms. He can feel Phainon duck closer to him to hear, can see the fall of his shadow in his periphery.

"What?"

"Whenever you're ready," Mydei says. "I'll say it back. So don't bother if you don't mean it."

"Oh," Phainon says. A pause. He's always been so smart but so fucking stupid. *"Oh.* Mydeimos." Mydei doesn't raise his head. Just stares at the bird shit stains on the wall and tries not to burn into a crisp. It doesn't help that Phainon is like the goddamn sun. Too close. Too bright. His stupid fucking smile is imprinted on the backs of Mydei's eyelids, and it isn't fair at all. "Mydei," Phainon says again.

“Fucking *what?”* Mydei asks, turning just enough to look at him out of one eye through a curtain of hair.

“I’m in love with you,” Phainon says, as easy as breathing. Because what is there to be afraid of? That’s just his heart, bloody and beating in his chest, in his throat, in his open palms between them on the wall, dripping red on the bird shit, forming puddles, staining their clothes, slicking their hands.

“You can’t fucking laugh about it this time.”

“Mydei,” Phainon says, like he likes the taste of it in his mouth. “When was I ever the one who laughed?”

And he’s right. He might not say it like he means it, but he never laughs. Mydei does. And Mydei’s the one who never says it back. He sighs, and he can’t look at Phainon as he says it. “Me too.”

Another bump. Phainon reaches out and lightly guides Mydei’s chin up with the backs of his fingers. It’s a tiny, fleeting touch, and he pulls away as soon as Mydei is looking at him. He seems so hopeful, expression open, holding his breath like he *needs* to hear Mydei say it. “That doesn’t count,” he whispers, baiting him, and Mydei might as well be the fish on his *Master Baiter* t-shirt, because he’s always caught, always pulled along by some string connecting him to Phainon by a hook in the heart.

Another day, Mydei would probably laugh him off and call him needy, but he gets it. He needed to hear it too, and Phainon gave it to him so readily. God. He sucks in a breath.

“Why are you bracing yourself for it?” Phainon laughs. “You look like you’re taking a shit; you’ll hurt my feelings.”

“You’re a fucking idiot,” Mydei says, looking at his stupid smile. His heart flips, flips, flips. His ears are molten, and he’s just… “I’m in love with you.”

Phainon is quiet. His mouth spasms and he turns away again, having the exact same reaction to this as he did to Mydei calling him beautiful. He clears his throat, covers his mouth, hides his face in his arms. “Fuck,” he says, inhaling it, sounding breathless. “I’m gonna throw up.”

“The fuck do you mean you’re gonna throw up?” Mydei shoves him in the shoulder, and he laughs, laughs, laughs, stumbling a step away, still hiding in his arms. “Whose feelings are hurt now, asshole?”

“Sorry!” Phainon says, surfacing. He’s red from the neck up, smiling hard enough to squeeze tears out of his eyes. “I just… my butterflies have butterflies, man, I—”

“Shut up,” Mydei says, grabbing his collar to shake him a little, gritting his teeth, hating how much he loves this stupid fucking smile, this stupid fucking man. But he can’t even be mad, because he’s never met anyone quite so *good* as Phainon. Warm and earnest… and Mydei’s match, his equal, like they’re fucking Ancient Kremnoans. They’d battle for ten goddamn

days and ten goddamn nights and there would never be a clear victor, and it's so stupid and unfair how much Mydei likes that.

"Shut up," Mydei says again, quieter, looking at him, loving him, and just… They've been here long enough for the sunset to start, just barely, just the first bits of orange and red painting the horizon, still shining down on them just a bit too much, and it's so unfair that Mydei has to feel this way. But how could he not? Looking at Phainon now, how could he not?

His hand still balled up in Phainon's shirt. He'll stretch it out and leave wrinkles. Phainon is done laughing, just looking at him, wide-eyed and soft-mouthed and gold in the sun, flourishing and photosynthesizing in it like some kind of plant, and it isn't fair at all. His knuckles against Phainon's chest. His hand smooths out, slides up Phainon's shoulder, around the back of his neck. It would be so easy to just… kiss him, or something. Really, what's stopping him? He's been waiting so goddamn long already.

Funny, Phainon kisses him first. He just sucks in this little breath and comes closer. He probably sees the look in Mydei's eyes telling him to stop being such a fucking coward, because he leans in, hesitates for just a second, and then he fits their mouths together sweet and easy like he's done it a hundred times. It's a little dry and a little wet at once, close-mouthed and just the right amount of pressure.

He smells faintly like sunscreen, like coconut and summer, and he sets one hand on Mydei's shoulder, the other barely brushing fingertips along the underside of his jaw. He's less eager than Mydei anticipated. He always imagined Phainon coming in with too much force, clacking their teeth together, drawing away with a sheepish apology. He'd imagined a bit too much tongue and energy, because that's how Phainon does everything. Whole-hearted and clumsy, with dog-like enthusiasm.

Maybe if it were his first, that would make sense, but Phainon has had a couple of boyfriends and girlfriends in the past, so of course he knows how to do this. It's probably better this way. Mydei doesn't think he'd be a very good teacher, if Phainon needed to learn.

"Is that fine?" Phainon asks, drawing away so he can breathe, still close enough that Mydei has to go cross-eyed to look at him. He sounds hopeful and uncertain in equal measure, like Mydei wouldn't have just shoved him off and sworn at him if that wasn't okay. He's so dumb sometimes. So fucking sweet.

"You always pick the weirdest things to worry about," Mydei informs him, and kisses him again, a little firmer this time, because *gentle* doesn't come quite as easily to Mydei as it seems to for Phainon. His nose digs into Phainon's cheek. There's a sound as he pulls back. "I'd kick your ass if it wasn't fine."

"Should've figured," Phainon says. One more kiss. Halfway through, he starts to smile, and Mydei gets his teeth.

"Quit that," he murmurs, both arms finding their way around Phainon's shoulders. Phainon's lips are weird and firm as he tries to fight his smile, and Mydei gets his teeth again after half a second. "Fucking gross," he says, giving up, just standing their foreheads pressed together.

“Sorry,” Phainon breathes. His hands find Mydei’s waist, finally touching like he’s allowed. “I’m just… happy, I guess. More than I have been in a while.”

A nicer version of Mydei might say something sweet. *You deserve to be,* or, *you make me happy too.* This one doesn’t, though. This one just says, “About fucking time,” and Phainon laughs, laughs, laughs with the sun in his hair and in his squinting eyes. They’ve wasted way too much time at this overlook, wind in their faces, the sound of an occasional car speeding past behind them. They’re going to be so late to the hotel, but Mydei can’t even bring himself to care.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Phainon falls asleep with relative ease that night, more than exhausted from the drive and the sun in his eyes. They reach the hotel a bit after midnight, change into pajamas and brush their teeth, and are in bed before one. Phainon thinks blurry thoughts and listens to Mydei's breath beside him, and falls asleep within twenty minutes.

When he wakes, it's to sweat-soaked sheets and clothing, Mydei's face in his shoulder, and his left leg completely devoid of feeling where Mydei has it clamped between his. There's a hand over his waist, and they're touching in half a dozen spots, but nothing about this is comfortable enough to be considered cuddling. There's a spot of drool on his sleeve.

Slowly and carefully, he attempts to extricate himself, if only to save his leg and get a head start on showering before Mydei can wake and claim it first. His leg seizes in bloodless pain, and Mydei's hand unconsciously tightens. Phainon winces, pauses, and tries again, pulling his leg free and untangling Mydei's fingers from his shirt. He's reluctant to let go, so Phainon gives him a pillow to hold instead and sits up. The sensation of blood flowing back into his leg just about paralyzes him, and as he sits there and waits for the pins and needles to start, he watches Mydei press his face into the pillow and mumble something in his sleep.

He's shirtless, as he always is at night. Maybe this should do something to Phainon, especially after they kissed last night, after they finally addressed whatever it is that hangs between them, but it's just Mydei. He's shirtless at least forty percent of the time, and Phainon is used to it. He's just Mydei, and nothing had been weird after they got back into the car and drove for another four hours, and somehow that's his favorite part.

He doesn't want things to change too much. He doesn't want to lose Mydei as a friend to have him as more than that. He didn't realize until just now that he'd been afraid of losing that ease, that familiarity, but that doesn't even make sense, does it? They're still them, Mydei's still Mydei, and that's… good.

The pins and needles hit. Phainon gingerly rotates his ankle and bends his knee, trying to end it faster, but it's all he can do to sit here and bear it. Mydei sleeps on, drooling and oblivious, and it's stupid how fond Phainon feels. Suffering must be a side effect of love. He bends to get his phone off the nightstand and takes the most unflattering photo of Mydei he can manage.

He opens his texts with Cyrene, attaching the image. *Can you believe I kissed this guy last night?*

It's 7:43, but only a moment passes before she reads it. She's like him, a difficult sleeper and an early riser. The medication is probably making it worse, with how often she's forced to nap. He watches the dots as she types.

I'm just surprised it hasn't happened before last night.

He sends a handful of question marks back, feeling his lips quirk as he watches her type again.

That's your business, she sends first. Another message follows up the first. *It's not like I was going to meddle where I didn't belong, but I could tell, obviously.* A third message. *I'm happy for you.*

He wasn't expecting her to be surprised. He's fairly certain anyone who's known him longer than a day could figure this much out. He and Mydei had both known too, they just… didn't do anything about it. *Most lackluster response,* he sends.

Sorry, did you want more enthusiasm? She sends a mile long string of emojis back, from shocked faces to hearts to confetti, and he laughs through his nose before he shuts his phone off and sets it back on the nightstand.

His pins and needles are mostly gone, so he slips off the bed and digs for fresh clothes in his luggage so he can shower. They smell like Cyrene's detergent, and he's… happy. That's probably the easiest word for it. He's hopeful that things are starting to go well for him. That Cyrene will be okay, that Mydei will be happy with him too. God, it's been a while since he woke up content like this.

His chest fills up with something bigger than him. Warmth, nostalgia, something just softer than guilt. He's good at spoiling these things for himself, but he knows he needs to feel this much too. It's too much to unpack all at once.

For now, he'll let Mydei sleep a little longer, and then they can have breakfast and resume the journey back home.

△

Mydei is still half asleep at breakfast. He answers questions with hums and grunts, leans over his plate with both elbows on the table, and keeps his eyes closed for too long increments before he drags them back open and peels another wedge from the tangerine in ruins on his plate. Phainon lets him be, smiling to himself as he separates the crispy and soggy sides of his bacon.

"Wasteful," Mydei murmurs, watching him abandon the soggy sides to die with a scrunched up napkin. Phainon just holds the strip he'd been working on out to him, waving it in the air so he can see just how limp and flaccid it is.

"Do *you* want it, then?"

Mydei's glare doubles in strength when he's sleepy like this. His eyes look so dead inside. "Get that out of my face," he grumbles, jabbing his fork into some similarly soggy sausage. "Nine hours driving today, and you're going first."

"Fine by me," Phainon chuckles. "Do you need a nap? I know you didn't get a lot of sleep."

“You didn’t either,” Mydei points out, rubbing the edge of one eye with the second knuckle on his thumb. “It’s fine. I’ll wake up eventually.”

And he does, albeit slowly. They pack up after breakfast, and as he combs out his slightly damp hair, he seems more than half alive, though he’s definitely still tired. Phainon wraps up his phone charge and does a scan of the room to make sure he hasn’t forgotten anything. He steals Mydei’s keys, since he’ll be driving anyway, tucking them into his pocket and dipping into the bathroom to watch Mydei finish up. He’s handling his bangs now, twisting them and clipping them to the top of his head before he pulls out his eyeliner pen. His gaze shifts to Phainon in the mirror as he takes off the cap.

“Did you forget something in here?” he asks, leaning over the counter to get closer to the mirror, pulling the skin around his eye taut. Phainon’s gaze flicks from him to the counter, back to his exposed forehead.

“...No,” he says. In one fluid motion, Mydei lines his eye in red, moving his hands away to look. He should look silly with his hair clipped like that. He kind of *does,* but it’s also kind of hot how smoothly he did that. His gaze lands on Phainon, heavy amber and molten.

“What is it, then?” he asks, leaning forward again to do the other side. Phainon’s fingers twitch on the doorframe.

“Well, I was going to ask if you were ready, but then I got distracted.”

A deep hum. “By?” The way Mydei does his other eye is just as smooth and practiced as the first.

“Uh… huh?”

Mydei checks to make sure his eyeliner is even. When he’s satisfied, he unclips his hair and shakes out his bangs, turning to face Phainon, and that’s not what he looks like, asleep and drooling, is it? “You were distracted by?” he reiterates.

“Take a guess,” Phainon says, and part of him wonders if he could just… He doesn’t know. Reach out, maybe. Mydei would probably let him, but he isn’t quite used to what that looks like yet, what that feels like. He knows Mydei about as well as he could hope to know anyone, and he’s felt this way about him forever, but he’s never really thought about it seriously. Should he now? Now that they’ve acted on whatever this is, now that they’ve acknowledged it and let it become real?

Mydei lifts an eyebrow. His eyeliner is just about perfect. Under the fluorescent bathroom light, he’s the realest kind of beautiful Phainon knows. “I think it’s pretty obvious.”

“Then why’d you ask?” Phainon watches as Mydei gathers up the last of his toiletries in a plastic gallon size bag he’s probably been reusing for a few years at this point. He doesn’t replace things unless they’re beyond repair. His pink duffle bag, his favorite ratty bath towel, his water bottle with a dozen dents and scratches in the paint and faded, peeling stickers. Phainon could probably fit on that list too, now that he thinks about it.

Mydei's never left him in all this time. Not in any way that matters.

"To see if you'd try to defend yourself," Mydei answers, closing the bag and taking a step closer to turn off the light. Phainon blinks, and the bathroom goes dark, Mydei's face half lit by the spill of light from the window on the far wall of the hotel room. He's close, Phainon is used to him being close. He's the same, but it's different now. Maybe some things do change.

"Do I need to defend myself?" Phainon asks. He's always found Mydei captivating. This much is nothing new, not even to Mydei.

"Are you going to move out of the doorway?"

"I could," Phainon says, looking at him. He remembers the rush of it last night. Mydei calling him beautiful, Mydei saying he loves him, Mydei kissing him. His own stupid reactions. The way he could do nothing but blush and hide in his arms and say weird things. Embarrassment swells with the heat that climbs his neck. He steps out of the doorway.

Mydei slips past him and unzips his duffle bag to shove his toiletries inside. When he's done, he does the same scan of the hotel room Phainon had, checking for anything he might've left behind. There's nothing at all, because neither of them unpack, really. No more than plugging in their chargers and leaving their toothbrushes by the sink to dry. He turns around to find Phainon still red in the face, covering his mouth.

"What are you blushing for?"

"Nothing," Phainon says. "I'm just vividly reliving every stupid thing I did last night."

Mydei chuckles at this. "You didn't do anything out of character, at least."

"That's worse, you realize," Phainon points out. "That means I'm stupid all the time."

"And you're just now realizing?"

Admittedly, this startles a laugh out of him, and he moves his hand up to rub at his brow, shaking his head. "So merciless, Mydeimos," he says. "Take pity, would you? I'm trying my best."

"I'm sure you are," Mydei says, fairly gently, by Mydei standards. He lifts his duffle bag off the bed and comes closer, dropping it at their sides. He pulls Phainon's hand away from his face and lightly cups his jaw, leaning forward to press a kiss to his cheek, surprisingly soft and a little bit chapped. "Reminder that I didn't kick your ass last night when you kissed me," he says, stepping back and retrieving his bag. "Let's go."

△

Phainon manages to drive for two hours this time. Sometimes he can do more, and Mydei always can, but today his head is running with the winds and his leg is bouncing, fingers tapping, shoulders tensed and cheek gnawed to a mess of sores. He's a live wire, maybe a danger to the road, and they're running on a quarter tank of gas so he takes the next exit to fill up as an excuse.

He uses the restroom at the gas station, though he doesn't need to. Mydei waits for him when he comes back out, leaning against the side of his car, scrolling through something on his phone all easy, and as Phainon's feet kick up rocks on the way back, he gets this odd feeling. A heartbeat he can feel in his chest, a little voice in the back of his mind saying *this is weird.*

He tosses the keys over, watches Mydei tuck his phone in his pocket and climb into the driver's side. The car is hot and stinking of the lemon air freshener hanging from the mirror. He turns something on as they drive, girl groups, pop rock, guitar. He turns the music off.

"Do you want to call your sister?" Mydei asks.

He should probably say yes. He should probably *want* to say yes. "Not right now," he says instead. Mydei's hum isn't questioning, which he feels is a victory. He couldn't answer if asked what's wrong.

They're so far from home, is this thought he keeps having. His mind will go to a dozen places just to end up back at this. So far from home. They'll need another night in another hotel, another day on the road. It's barely a blink. He isn't bored, he isn't lonely. He watches out the window; they've been in the middle of nowhere for a while. Acres and acres of farmland, nothing but fields or cattle grazing on either side. Miles and miles of gold rippling in the wind. He remembers the sound of that, the heat of the sun on his skin, the smell of the earth.

He hasn't seen wheat in harvest season in a decade or longer. There's a tight feeling in his throat. He sucks in a shaky breath.

Still here, he thinks, blinking to the afterimage of clouds and swaying wheat. *It never really goes away, does it?* That feeling. Homesickness for somewhere that doesn't exist. Missing people and things that are long gone. He still thinks about them all the time. He doesn't think he'll ever stop. He wonders if Cyrene feels that too. Realizes that one day, one of them will be stuck missing the other. He thinks about that all the time too.

He clears his throat, unlocks his phone to dredge up a song. "I thought of something you can learn on guitar," he tells Mydei, who's been quiet enough that he probably knows whatever's going on in Phainon's head. He'll never say it, but he picks up on the strangest things. He burns incense instead of candles because he knows Phainon is afraid of the flame. He stays silent as they drive through some boring old wheat fields because he knows Phainon is feeling nostalgic.

The rumble of the road in his ears. The sun cooking his right arm and reflecting off his phone screen as he finds what he's looking for. The silence is replaced by the opening chords of the song. Mydei doesn't seem to recognize it at first, but he barks a laugh as the singer comes in. *"Today is gonna be the day—"*

He skips it with a button on the dash. "Fuck off," he says, and Phainon has to laugh too. "I'm not learning *Wonderwall."*

△

They get Greek food for lunch, and Mydei's gyro is so good he notes down the ingredients and vows to try to recreate it at home. Phainon holds his hand for about ten seconds before he psychs himself out of it, and then they're back on the drive. He falls out of his funk after a while, and then he's back to talking nonstop, though it seems he's run out of conversation topics because he turns to asking strange questions that kind of piss Mydei off, like whether potatoes count as vegetables and if he'd rather fight a bear or fifty Canada geese.

Eventually, they call Cyrene. She describes her last day of treatment, says that her friends Dan Heng and Stelle both visited for the tail end of it. They're going to take the IV out soon, and she can't wait to not be tethered for it, even if it's only for a short time between rounds of medication. They end up talking to her for an hour and twenty-three minutes before one of the doctors comes in to check on her and she has to hang up. Phainon does that thing again, where he's happy and then he's sad after all the talking is over. Mydei tells him another old Kremnoan story, this time of the rivalry of Nikador and Kephale, the Titans of Strife and Worldbearing in their mythology, and he perks right up.

Dinner is unfortunately greasy Chinese food. Phainon seems to enjoy it, but it makes Mydei feel slightly ill. He can't wait to have his own kitchen again, and says so as they cut through the parking lot.

"You've had, what, a day without one?" Phainon asks. "You baked yesterday morning."

"It's been five meals," Mydei notes, for reference. "Not only do *I* feel sick, my wallet feels sick as well."

Phainon opens his mouth to refute this, but can't. Breakfast was free at their hotel, but lunch and dinner are still on them, and it adds up. He takes the keys when Mydei passes them to him, locks the car and slips in. Mydei takes the passenger seat, since he'd driven for the last uneventful three hour stretch. As Phainon sets up his directions, he clears his throat.

"I could pay for you next time," he says, like he's trying to sound casual and failing grossly. "I mean, it's only right if, um…"

"We are equally broke, Phainon," Mydei reminds him. The car rumbles as it starts.

"So you can pay the time after that," Phainon tries.

"And then we both still paid for two meals, and are just as broke."

"You're the worst," Phainon says, and the bumper scrapes the curb as he pulls onto the street, nearly turning right when his directions tell him to turn left. He corrects it without incident and tries to play it off like that wouldn't have ended in disaster if there were perhaps two more cars on the road. Mydei shakes his head and laughs a little, propping his elbow on the window to look outside, the sun hot on his exposed arm. The town they're in is a small one, with old buildings and peeling paint, but it's unmistakably cozy, so he doesn't have a word of complaint.

"I'm just saying…" There's an odd break in Phainon's words as he clears his throat, checking each of his mirrors, visibly swallowing. "Maybe it won't help us be less broke, but… Is this

official? Like, well. Uh. Us? As a unit, or… That sounds weird. A couple? Or a, um, partnership?"

"What are we, corporations working together to exploit the poor?" Mydei asks, and watches Phainon go through the five stages of grief all in one go. His lips purse, part with a wet sound, red climbing up his neck as he lifts one hand off the steering wheel like he means to hide his face before he remembers that he's driving and needs to be able to see.

"Admittedly, that came out wrong," he says, settling on acceptance, tapping his fingers on the steering wheel, all four at once, minus his thumb, before he grips it like normal again, knuckles going white. "I meant something less like exploiting the poor and more like…" He thinks for a moment, Mydei trying his best to keep his expression neutral, despite the way his mouth wavers and tries to edge into a smile.

"Like what?" he prompts. "A peace treaty to defeat a common enemy?"

Phainon laughs through his nose. "You know you suck, right?"

"Perhaps a contract to split the spoils of war?"

"Like…" Phainon opens his mouth, closes it, scratches his head as he thinks about it. "Like…" He squints at the directions, gets over one lane so he can turn left at the next light. His tongue flicks out to wet his lips. "Yeah, fuck, I've got nothing."

"There's gotta be a record for how goddamn awkward you are," Mydei tells him. "Maybe you could make it into the next Guiness book."

Phainon glances at him, sunglasses on, reflecting Mydei back at himself. "You're not even going to *try* to help me? You're just going to sit there and watch me suffer?"

"Yeah," Mydei says, plucking his phone out of his lap to add another song to the queue. A solid four minutes and fifty-five seconds of alternative rock to match the last six songs he's played of the same genre. Phainon flip flops between vibes on a whim, adding soft pop next to loud electronic dance music, next to showtunes. Mydei likes to stay consistent and transition slowly. "I'm having a pretty good time."

"What a kind, gentle, doting lover you are," Phainon tells him. "You really make me feel so warm and fuzzy and cared about inside."

"Glad to see my efforts acknowledged," Mydei says sarcastically. The last song fades out, and the next comes on. "I really try."

"Uh huh," Phainon says, bobbing his head up and down. "And you succeed."

"I know I do."

An exhale, somewhere between a laugh and a sigh. Phainon shifts in his seat, grips the steering wheel a bit tighter, leg bouncing to the beat. "So I guess I have to say it properly, right? Will you be my boyfriend?"

“Is that supposed to be sarcastic too?” Mydei asks, but Phainon doesn’t seem to find this funny. Maybe they’re too used to pretending this is some kind of joke. They’ll have to work on that, learning how to treat this seriously.

“Fuck off,” Phainon says. “No. I mean it, but I can take it back if you’re going to be an asshole.”

“Sorry,” Mydei says. “Habits die hard.”

“Answer the question.”

“Yes.” This comes out surprisingly simply. He doesn’t know why he’d expected it to be hard. Things are rarely straightforward between them, but this comes out easily once Phainon figured out how to ask. “I’d like that.”

“Cool,” Phainon says, nodding, lifting one hand off the steering wheel to wipe it on his pants, then the other. His expression is carefully blank, but his ear—only half hidden by his hair—is bright red, and his mouth twitches before he purses his lips to stop himself from smiling like a buffoon. He clears his throat. “To a successful partnership, then.”

“We split the profits fifty-fifty,” Mydei tells him.

A weak laugh. “What exactly constitutes the profits?” he asks, and honest to god scratches his chin like a cartoon character while he thinks about it. “Actually, don’t answer that.”

Mydei squints at him. “Clearly you’re the one with an answer,” he points out. “What’s that face for? You’re not thinking something weird, are you?”

“No!” Phainon says, too quickly. “I have never had an untoward thought in my life.”

“Who said anything about untoward?”

Phainon goes quiet, whether at a loss for words or unwilling to dig himself a deeper hole. Mydei laughs, just a chuckle at first, and then with his full chest.

“Shut up,” Phainon protests, helpless. “Stop laughing, Mydeimos, I mean it.”

“Yeah, sure.” He laughs a little longer, sighs as he looks at the downturned corners of Phainon’s mouth. After a breath, he manages a straight face. “So what kind of thoughts were you having?”

Phainon doesn’t even look at him, just extends one arm, middle finger flipped up. Another laugh, Mydei bats his hand away. “How romantic.”

“You know it.” Now, Phainon smiles, pulling onto the freeway, shutting his phone off and shoving it in his pocket since he doesn’t really need directions to drive straight for three hundred miles. He pushes the sunglasses up his nose, smiles with teeth before he squashes it down to something more subtle. “You lucked out, you know. You’ve got a damn good boyfriend.”

“You were really just waiting for a chance to call yourself my boyfriend, weren’t you?”

“You know it,” Phainon repeats. Mydei shakes his head, chuckles.

“My mother is going to have a field day with this,” he mutters, thinking of the way she always asks about Phainon when she calls, the way she never outright tries to push Mydei towards him, but can see through him like glass. They’d just been talking, once, and Mydei was telling her about driving to a party an hour away just to rescue Phainon from a couple of drunk friends. She’d laughed over the phone, warm and crackly, and said, *you give your all to that boy, don’t you?* He thinks about that all the time, the same way he thinks about her grabbing Phainon by the face and later saying, *he grew up beautiful,* like Mydei isn’t haunted by that fact every day.

She raised him to love with everything he has. She’ll probably laugh when he tells her, call him a coward for taking so long, but she’ll be proud.

“Your mother?” Phainon asks.

“Yes,” Mydei sighs. “My mother.”

Phainon glances at him, turning the air conditioning up one setting higher. “How so?”

And he dug himself into that hole, didn’t he? Mydei sighs, traces patterns over his phonecase. “My mother loves you, in case you haven’t noticed. Remember that one year you went with me for Christmas and she grabbed your face and inspected you? She pulled me aside later just to tell me you grew up beautiful and that your neck tattoo means you must be strong and worthy.”

“Wha—” Phainon makes a strange, confused sound. “That whole time she was so scary,” he says, and laughs incredulously. “I thought she hated me!”

“Quit laughing,” Mydei says, “it’s not like it’s funny.”

“Oh, but it is,” Phainon protests. Another split second laugh, Mydei is hit with the force of his grin, stretching too wide for the complete lack of hilarity of the situation. “Tell me, did she say anything else?”

“I don’t think I want to tell you if she did,” Mydei tells him. “Not if you’re going to make it weird and embarrassing.”

A contemplative hum. Phainon hooks a finger under his choker as he considers this. “Very well,” he says, “this venerable one is kind and benevolent, and will offer you a piece of his own embarrassing information in exchange.”

“You say that like I don’t have enough dirt on you already,” Mydei says.

“Come on,” Phainon tries. “Please? You’d be totally curious if Cyrene said something about you, wouldn’t you? Help a guy out.”

“Bow and grovel,” Mydei says.

Phainon clears his throat, and something like dread settles in Mydei's stomach. "Please," Phainon says. "Please, Mydei? Please, I need to know, I'll tell you something so embarrassing after, I promise it'll be worth it, please. Please, Mydeimos, plea—"

"Shut up," Mydei says, wanting to kick him if they weren't in the car, a laugh betraying his words. "You're so goddamn annoying."

The edge of Phainon's smile. He's still looking at the road, tapping out the music that fills their silences. "...So?" he prompts.

Mydei sighs. "Last Christmas, I went up and we were looking at our old picture books and shit. She was telling me about my dad before he became a total deadbeat and died, and she looks at me and goes, *love doesn't wait for cowards, Mydeimos, it's always better to feel and hurt now than to regret wasting the chance later.* And then she closes the books and asks how you're doing. She'll never meddle, but I swear to god she's never been so obvious."

Phainon laughs a little, and then he chews on his cheek. "Christmas," he says. "Just how long have you liked me, Mydeimos?"

"Christmas wasn't even that long ago," Mydei grumbles.

"It's probably been years for me," Phainon admits. "I can't even pinpoint a time, it's just kind of been there forever." Why is it so easy to say these things for him? Mydei has to dig the words out like sticking a hand down his throat.

Heat crawls up his face. Mydei turns toward the window and brings a hand to tug at his ear. "Me too," he gets out. In his peripheral, Phainon is doing that red faced, twitchy mouthed smile again. He looks away, watching the billboards and the buildings fly by. "It's your turn to say something embarrassing, by the way."

"Right," Phainon laughs. "Let me think; I feel like you already know the worst of it."

"You didn't even have something in mind?" Mydei huffs. "What a fucking scam."

"Shh," Phainon hushes him. "Let me think." He's quiet for a bit, chewing on his cheek again, humming softly. He inhales. "You have to promise not to laugh, but I've got something."

"Yeah, fuck that. You laughed at everything I said." Phainon scoffs, goes quiet again. "Are you going to say it?"

"It's…" He sighs out of his nose. "Fine. I have… somewhere, buried in the trenches of my notes app—"

"The more you lead up to it, the more embarrassing it gets," Mydei tells him. "Just like a minute ago, when you asked me to be your boyfriend."

"Shut up," Phainon says, and pouts a little. "Fine, I'll just…" He takes a deep breath, like he really is embarrassed about whatever it is that he's going to say and needs to work himself up to it. "In my notes app, I have…" He scratches his nose, clears his throat. "A list of places I'd like to be kissed."

There's a pause, both of them silent. Mydei opens his mouth to speak. "And what's on it?"

Phainon groans, looks like he would very much like to bury his face in his arms if he weren't driving. "I'd really rather not answer that. Besides, I've already fulfilled my end of the deal; you don't need to know any more."

"Wouldn't it be good for you to tell me?" Mydei points out. "Realistically, I'm the only one who can check anything on that list off anytime soon."

"Don't say that," Phainon says, voice cracking, red down to his neck. "Don't fucking say that, oh my god."

"Mainly I'm just curious," Mydei says, smoothing out his expression, because Phainon probably *would* die on the spot if he started laughing. "By 'places' do you mean locations, like… 'at a scenic overlook next to a pile of bird shit,' or body parts like 'the back of my neck,' or, 'my knees,' or some shit."

"My *knees?"* Phainon asks. "That's what you chose as an example?"

"Fuck off, is 'my armpits' better?"

"No!" He's laughing now, which is what Mydei had been hoping for. Phainon feels shame too easily. And something like this… it's embarrassing, sure, but Mydei daydreams weird shit too, even if he doesn't go as far as to write it down. "That's a hundred times worse!"

Mydei lets his laughter die down. The flush doesn't quite fade, but Phainon no longer looks like he's going to crash the car and find somewhere to bury himself. Mydei gives him another breath, then says, "So… Body parts?"

"I hope you're not imagining this freakishly large list with weird shit like knees and armpits," Phainon says. "It's like… six bullet points, and they're all *normal,* and I made it like… three years ago."

"Why are you so embarrassed about it, then?" Phainon glances at him, and oh, Mydei's reflection in the sunglasses looks smug. He crosses his arms and sucks on his teeth.

"You try telling someone you've thought about them kissing your eyelids with a straight face," Phainon says. "It's weird! It's embarrassing! I've been dating you for less than twenty-four hours!"

"So that's one of them, then."

"Shut up." Phainon sniffs, checks his blind spot to pass a slow car. "Yes."

Mydei is so ridiculously fond of him. It isn't fair. There's only so much room in his heart, full to bursting. "You're making it a way bigger deal than it really is," he says. "I'll tease you a little, because it is kind of funny, but you can ask me for things, you know? The worst I can do is say no."

“The worst you can do is make fun of me ruthlessly, and then say no,” Phainon corrects. “And I don’t know, but that seems like a pretty likely outcome.”

“Am I doing that now?”

At this, Phainon pauses, finally listens to what Mydei is saying. “Well,” he says, wetting his lips, “no.”

△

They get to the hotel with the last dying rays of sun. Check in is easy at this hour, and then they’re dragging their luggage into the elevator, up to the third floor, and into their room. It’s dark and cool with working air conditioning, and they leave their stuff in the entryway. The door shuts too loudly as they close it again to head back out.

There’s a warm wind outside. The worst of the heat is past, and the sun is already hanging low in the sky as they walk, so it isn’t too bad. Mydei is glad for a chance to stretch his legs, his whole body kind of stiff and aching from spending the past two days in the car. Phainon just likes walking; he’ll go out on a whim and wander until Mydei has to call him and say, *Where the fuck are you? Dinner’s ready.*

They’re on the outskirts of the city this time, somewhere between suburbs and downtown, with aged, squat houses and not too busy streets. Phainon turns them left at the corner, so the sun is at their backs. Side by side, he walks too close. Their shoulders bump. His hand is shoved deep in his pocket or Mydei might’ve reached out to hold it.

“Sick of me yet?” Phainon asks, bumping him again, doing it on purpose because he’s like glue in a different way than Mydei is. Phainon likes proximity, always touching, always talking. Mydei is content to just be in the same room.

“When am I not?” Mydei says instead of answering with something stupid like *no, never,* or, *I like spending time with you.* There are a handful of orange cones blocking an exposed pipeline on the side of the street. Dug up dirt underfoot, spread to the sidewalk by the wind.

“Most of the time, probably,” Phainon answers, sliding his hands out of his pockets to stretch them overhead with an exaggerated sound. When he drops his arms, they bump again. “Otherwise you wouldn’t put up with me half as much.” Cracks in the sidewalk. Faded white paint for a crosswalk. There’s nobody coming, so they cross, drifting a little further apart, then back together as they wind up on the narrow sidewalk again.

“If you know that much, why bother asking,” Mydei mutters, not really making it a question. Ahead, there’s a bit of movement. He hears Phainon suck in a breath. A handful of steps forward, and he crouches. In the driveway of this next house, just under a dirt-covered, off-white pickup truck, sits a gray tabby cat. A little scruffy, but collared. It stares at them with wide eyes and an upturned, sniffing nose. Phainon looks at it and blinks slowly, trying to get it to trust him as he inches forward. When he’s close enough, maybe two yards away, he sits right there on the ground and holds out a hand.

“Hey buddy,” he murmurs, all soft and high pitched. He uses this voice with any small animal ever, though he speaks normally with kids. Mydei watches him, tired and fond, and yes, maybe a little bit sick of him. He sighs as comes to sit next to him on the sidewalk. The cat doesn’t even flinch, and when he holds a hand out, it comes to Mydei first.

“This isn’t fair at all,” Phainon says as Mydei sits through a thorough examination as the cat smells his outstretched fingers. After a bit, it nudges its head against them, so he pets it once, twice, all the way to its tail, scratching its low back a bit. The cat turns around, and he can see that she’s a girl as she walks a little lap around them, sniffing the back of Phainon’s shirt as he holds carefully still.

“She’s friendly,” Mydei tells him, taking his hand and holding it out for the cat to sniff. After she does, she bumps her head into Phainon’s hand the same she had to Mydei, and Phainon makes a distressed sound as he pets her.

“What a gal,” he says, scratching her head. “What a lady.”

She comes back to Mydei, putting her paws on his lap as he rubs his thumbs over the thinner patches of fur in front of her ears. She tips her face up, eyes squeezing shut as she leans into the touch. Phainon’s head falls onto his shoulder, hair tickling his cheek. “You’ll make me jealous,” he says.

“Of who?” Mydei asks. “Me, or the cat?”

A petulant sound. Phainon reaches up to cup his cheek, turning Mydei so they’re facing each other. His hands falter on the cat’s head. Phainon is kind of glaring at him, close enough to kiss.

“The cat, then,” Mydei says, answering his own question.

“Fuck off,” Phainon grumbles, and lets go of his face. He’s quiet for a bit, sliding his fingers through the cat’s fur when she comes back to him before she gets distracted by the grass and ignores them completely to gnaw on it. He sighs, softly, bends to touch her and gets ignored some more.

Mydei chuckles softly. “Come on,” he says. “We probably look weird, sitting in front of someone’s house like this. Let’s go.”

“But the best girl ever,” Phainon protests.

“She’s not your cat, Phainon, let’s go.”

“Our cat.”

Mydei stands up, scraping the sidewalk, brushing himself off. He holds out a hand. Phainon sighs and takes it, heaving himself up, casting forlorn glances back toward the cat as Mydei pulls him along. He’d taken Mydei’s right hand with his left, and neither of them has let go. Mydei under the guise of dragging him, Phainon under the guise of being dragged. Even now,

they come up with flimsy excuses. Not looking, not drawing attention to it, Mydei adjusts the fit of their hands. Phainon opens his fingers, Mydei slots his between them, and they walk.

Stupid, stupid, stupid, how it probably makes him blush. He can feel the heat in his face. The sweat in his palms. Phainon doesn't comment, and he's glad.

They're quiet for a while. The gold of the dying sun turns to the blue beginnings of dusk. Their hands sway at their sides. Their shoulders keep bumping.

"Do you think a lot of things are going to change between us?" Phainon asks, looking at the weeds growing in the sidewalk cracks instead of Mydei. Their hands are clammy. They should probably let go, but somehow that's just as awkward as initiating it.

Mydei turns to him, his profile, the cut of his jaw and the two pimples stacked on his cheek. "What do you mean?"

"Just… things, I don't know," Phainon tries. "Are we going to turn into something different?"

Still, stubbornly, Phainon doesn't look at him. His eyes are how to read him, clear blue, with lighter patterning in the irises. "I still don't understand what you're asking," Mydei tells him. "It's not like we're going to become completely different people, but… yeah. Some things will change." *They already have,* he doesn't say. They wouldn't be holding hands if nothing changed, Mydei wouldn't have kissed his cheek this morning, wouldn't have kissed him on the mouth last night. Without change, what's the point of honesty?

"You're right," Phainon admits. He pulls his hand free, wipes it on his pants, laughs a little. "Sorry, I'm sweaty."

"I noticed," Mydei says, and wipes his hand too. "Me too, but I didn't know how to let go."

"What?" Phainon laughs, seeming to find this amusing. Mydei can only tolerate him for his smile. He'd do too many things for it.

"I don't know, it felt… mean, I guess."

His laugh is softer this time, though Mydei is well aware that his words have become even more ridiculous. "Nah," Phainon says. "Just let go next time; my feelings won't be hurt." He wipes his hands once more, holds it out again. "And then when our hands are dry, we can hold hands again and it won't be disgusting."

Mydei stares at his hand. Hates the way his heart clamors in his chest. He takes Phainon's hand again, though both of them are still a bit damp. "I guess so," he says, and adds, because Phainon is still being weird, "this is a change, you know."

They make another left, Phainon leading them in a big, square loop. Shadows start to settle. They'll want to get back soon, before it's truly dark. He's beautiful still, but Mydei can't help but think Phainon is better suited to the sun.

"I guess I hadn't thought of it like that," Phainon murmurs, looking at their hands, then back in front of him. The pools of light from the streetlamps, windows lit up from inside.

“Chronic worrier,” Mydei teases him. It comes out gentler than he means it to. Everything does these days, and it’s a goddamn illness. “Not everything ends in disaster.”

“Least of all you,” Phainon breathes. He squeezes Mydei’s hand, and… it’s nice to see him recognize that Mydei is steady, that after all these long years, he’s finally figured out that he doesn’t have plans to do anything but *stay.* Maybe it’s Mydei’s fault for never saying it aloud, but he doesn’t think he’s ever been subtle about Phainon.

“Least of all me,” he agrees, and watches the side of Phainon’s smile.

“You really love me, don’t you?”

“Shut up,” Mydei tells him. “Now you’re taking it too far.”

Chapter End Notes

tidbits (version 6.0): crazy take I know, but Phainon is the one with more relationship experience here... this Mydei turned out a lot more reserved compared to my versions of him in canonverse... and he's been too stuck on Phainon to really care about dating other people. Phainon says yes 9/10 times he's asked out because he likes getting to know people and is willing to try to let feelings grow... but it never works out longer than a month or two because he can never shake off his feelings for Mydei, and he doesn't really want to. so now they're here. awkward as fuck but in love or something

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"It just hit me that I have to go back to work tomorrow," Phainon says, his head pillowed on Mydei's arm, staring at the play of light and shadows on the ceiling with the curtains pulled open. The hotel room is cold, but they're sticky with body heat, already full from breakfast and procrastinating the drive home. Just one more day, but it's another nine hours neither of them is looking forward to. "I don't want to at all."

Mydei laughs through his nose, bicep tensing as he bends his elbow to poke Phainon square in the forehead. "No one wants to go to work tomorrow," he says, snorting at the way Phainon scrunches his face at him. His touch smoothes, gentles, fingers drifting to card through Phainon's hair. "But we all need the money. So do you. That's just life."

He smells like this hotel's soap of choice, they both do. Lemon verbena, weirdly strong. Phainon likes it and hates it in equal measure. "Oh, capitalist society," he bemoans, turning his face into Mydei's shirt, a small logo stitched on the chest. Mydei's arm shifts around his shoulders; they fit with surprising ease. He supposes they have plenty of practice. This is one of those boundaries they've never hesitated to cross. "What if we went back to being hunter-gatherers?"

"Then we would die," Mydei tells him, fingertips finding their way beneath his sleeve. With his other hand, he pokes Phainon in the forehead again. "Do you really think you'd be able to forage? Hunt something and kill it with your own hands?"

He doesn't, but it hardly matters. Phainon lifts his head to look at him, locking their ankles together. "You'd take care of me, wouldn't you?"

Mydei pokes him harder until he goes cross-eyed and frowns. "What makes you think *I'd* be able to do any of that?"

"You mean you *can't?"* Phainon pretends to be shocked. Mydei scowls at him, but it isn't like he means it. He has a scowl reserved just for Phainon, and he'll never say it, but it's fond. He's always fond, Phainon is pretty sure. He can count the times he's made Mydei seriously mad on one hand. They argue and get on each other's nerves on the daily, but it never actually means anything. Not when they can have this too.

"HKS," Mydei murmurs. *Hyena, scoundrel,* whatever that word means. He doesn't say it all that often. His mother and father both spoke fluent Kremnoan, but he didn't learn much growing up. Just words and phrases here and there. It's a harsh language, but Phainon likes the sound of it on his tongue. In a way, he mourns for it too. Another dying culture, lost to the winds. Who would Mydei speak it to, even if he had learned it fluently? "We're equally doomed in this scenario."

Phainon pulls his hand off, pinning it beneath his own on Mydei's chest. "Different scenario, then," he tries, wedging the top half of his foot under Mydei's calf, though it puts his knee hiked up and his hip twisted. "Hear me out. We homestead."

"Phainon," Mydei says.

"We'll have goats," Phainon says. "We'll grow wheat and berries and potatoes. We'll have a couple of cats as mousers. It'll be great."

"Goats," Mydei repeats. Phainon smiles.

"Goats," he agrees. "And chickens, and cows, maybe. Mousers for sure. An orange one and a white one. Meowdeimos and Furnon. They'll compete over who can catch more mice, and they'll always be hissing and fighting with each other, but then we'll find them cuddling in the barn one day."

"Sometimes I wonder if you hear the things that come out of your mouth," Mydei tells him, fingers skimming up and down his arm. Phainon laughs a little, lifting his hand from Mydei's to trace patterns on his ribs instead, shifting his hip, curling his leg around Mydei's closer to him. *"Meowdeimos* and *Furnon?* Really?"

"They'll be the best mousers," Phainon confirms, tapping the foot not pinned beneath Mydei's leg. His sock hisses against the sheets. Mydei kicks him lightly, trapped as he is.

"You move so goddamn much," he says, pressing Phainon's hand flat too, right over his left rib. His breath filters through Phainon's hair, and when Phainon stills, he huffs. "Meowdeimos is the better of the two," he says.

A laugh bubbles up in Phainon's throat. "Oh, but you forget that Furnon has experience on a farm," he says, and something bittersweet and nostalgic bubbles up with it. "He knows all the right places to look already. Meowdeimos is his fresh-faced little junior; of course he can't compete."

"Meowdeimos is a fast learner," Mydei protests. "Give him a bit, and he'll know all those things too."

Phainon laughs softly. A breath, two, and he can't stay still any longer, pulling his leg free to rock it from side to side. His knee keeps bumping Mydei, but he doesn't get scolded for it. And god, what an odd blessing that it doesn't bother him too much, that he plays along with all of Phainon's dumb little daydreams. Cyrene is the same way, and Phainon is kind of lucky, isn't he? To have two people who stay, two people who play along. "They'll be equals, then," he decides. "Some nights Furnon will catch more mice, and some nights Meowdeimos will, and we'll never know who the better mouser is."

Mydei's chest shakes with his laughter. "And then we'll find them cuddling in the barn," he says, and throws his leg over Phainon's to stop him from moving so much. Phainon just taps his fingers on Mydei's ribs instead.

“See,” he says, smiling but keeping his eyes averted so Mydei can’t see how wet and shining they must be. He isn’t even sad. He’s happy, and somehow that’s harder. “You get it. We’ll be living the dream.”

“Sounds like a lot of work, just to get away from work,” Mydei points out.

“Ah, you’re right,” Phainon says, sweating with their combined body heat but unwilling to move. He could probably stay here for hours, if Mydei doesn’t get sick of all his moving first. “I’ll just win the lottery instead.”

Mydei barks a laugh. “Yeah, sure,” he says, and he holds Phainon so easily. Has it always been like that? He thinks it has. God knows how many nights he’s spent with his head in Mydei’s lap. “That’s way more realistic.”

“And then we’ll never have to work again,” Phainon says, laughing a little, rolling so he’s on his back and they’re side-by-side again, his head still pillowed on Mydei’s arm, their bodies still pressed tight. The sun has barely shifted when he looks at the way it paints the ceiling again. It’s still early, but soon it won’t be, and they can’t stay here forever. They have a home to get back to, after all. “I’ll share, you know. ‘Cause I’m nice like that. We can move somewhere nicer, and you won’t have to worry about a thing.”

Quiet. Just their breath, the sound of the air conditioning hissing through the vents. Crisp white sheets and pillows a bit too firm for Phainon’s liking. He’s been using the same flat, nasty yellow one at home for years now. He could probably hear Mydei’s heartbeat if he tried. His own if he held his breath. He wishes they had a balcony. He wants to go on the roof and feel the sun and the wind and smell the ocean, smell the earth. He’s always wanted way too many things.

“Phainon,” Mydei says, and his throat is tight. He could’ve cried seeing those wheat fields yesterday. What’s wrong with him? Why is it that the moment the smallest thing happens, he tips over the edge? Is it work stress or pressure or anxiety? Is it Cyrene’s illness and his premature grief? Is it still just homesickness, after all this time?

“Have I always been this much of a useless sap?” he asks. “I can’t remember, now that I’m thinking about it.”

“You’re too used to faking your smiles,” Mydei tells him.

“Maybe,” he admits. His chest hurts. “I miss home, Mydei. I miss my parents and I miss the ocean and the wheat fields and the neighbor kids. I miss Cyrene, and we just talked to her yesterday. It’s like that’s all there is. Just… so much *missing.”*

A hum. “And you’ll feel that forever,” Mydei says, not too softly. His arms flexes again as he reaches to play with Phainon’s hair. “That’s just life.”

Phainon takes a breath deep enough to make his chest hurt. Exhales it all at once. “I can’t even be mad about it,” he says. “The memories are too important to me, you know?”

The next pause can't span more than a couple of breaths, but it feels like forever before Mydei speaks again. "I miss my dad," he admits. "Have I ever told you that?"

"No," Phainon whispers. "But I've always wondered. It can't— I know he was a bad guy but… you don't just walk away from your dad dying without a care in the world, no matter who he was."

"I couldn't even cry at his goddamn funeral," Mydei says. "But I still wonder if he'd be proud of me when I do shit he'd have called strong. I still look at him in the pictures all over my mom's house and wonder if maybe he wasn't as bad as I remember him being." He makes a frustrated sound. "I just… I feel those things too, even if it hardly compares to you losing everything in that fire. It doesn't make you a useless sap. My… my mom would've said you're stronger for it, to be able to carry all of those memories into the next day and the one after that, and my mom is never wrong about anything."

Phainon laughs a little, throat tight, pursing his lips. He reaches over Mydei's body for his free hand to squeeze, a bit awkward with their position, but… "Thanks," he tries. "I think you found the magic words I needed to hear."

"No I fucking did not," Mydei says. "You still feel all of it, and you're not going to stop, so shut up."

He laughs harder, and then he's probably crying, tears slipping from his eyes as he drags himself to sit upright, wiping his cheeks with the backs of his hands, sniffling. "Ah, fuck," he says as Mydei sits up too. "Quit looking at me."

"Shut up," Mydei tells him, and there are too warm arms wrapping around him, pulling him in until his shoulder collides with a firm chest. Mydei holds tight, holds fast. "All this over some fake fucking cats. Stop talking."

"It's not the cats," Phainon says, laughing wetly, chin wobbling, pressing his face into Mydei's shoulder. "You shut up."

△

A bit later, he watches Mydei line his eyes in red again. It's unexpectedly satisfying, the way he does it in one smooth line. Such a mundane thing, and yet.

They make eye contact in the mirror. "Did you forget something in here?" Mydei asks, and Phainon gets this embarrassed kind of Deja Vu. Mydei's bangs are clipped back again, and with only one eye done he looks exceptionally silly. He *should* look exceptionally silly, but Phainon is stuck looking, looking, looking. He always is. There's a lump in his throat. It still hurts from crying.

"I wanted to watch," he admits, excruciatingly attracted to the way Mydei's gaze narrows, expression otherwise flat. "It's like… those satisfying calligraphy videos."

"...Calligraphy?" Mydei repeats, pausing briefly to give Phainon an odd look before he resumes, leaning toward the mirror and doing his other eye with just as much ease as the first.

“You make it look so easy,” Phainon says, fighting the warmth that crawls up his neck. “I have a sister, you know. I’m very familiar with her complaining when it comes to that sort of stuff.”

“My hands are steady,” Mydei says simply, straightening up when he’s finished, checking that his eyeliner is even. “And I have a lot of practice.”

He’s going to say something embarrassing again, his self-control stretched thin from his tears. He can feel it in the flip and tumble of his stomach, the heat in his face, but he can hardly stop the words from spilling out. “I really like it.”

Now, Mydei unclips his bangs, combs them out with his fingers. He meets Phainon’s eyes again in the mirror, says tonelessly, “Thanks.”

Phainon still looks like he’s been crying. He sniffs, rubbing his neck, tugging on his choker. “You’re welcome,” he tries, but it comes out all weird. Mydei turns to him, and the full force of his red-lined gaze hits. Phainon might throw up.

“One minute you’re all up in my space without a care in the world, the next you’re super fucking awkward,” Mydei says. “Are you embarrassed you cried? You already know I don’t give a shit about that.”

And here is it. Maybe he’s stupid, maybe he’s sentimental. Probably both. He wants a lot of things. Probably too many. He’s greedy and good at taking advantage, but Mydei always lets him. *It’s Mydei,* he thinks. *When has he ever cared how greedy and dumb and embarrassing you are?* Right now, he’s over the crying thing. Right now, he looks at Mydei and remembers what it feels like to want, what it feels like to have permission. “I’m not quite sure what I’m allowed, yet,” he says, hands tight on the doorframe.

Mydei crosses his arms, leaning against the counter like an invitation for Phainon to pin him against it. One of his eyebrows lifts. “So ask,” he says. “What am I going to do?”

“Ruthlessly make fun of me,” Phainon suggests, “and then say no.”

“Sounds like a normal day,” Mydei retorts. “What are you so scared of?”

It’s just Mydei, Phainon thinks again. He needs to stop being so afraid of things changing. They will and they are, and that’s inevitable. But… they’re still them, and not everything needs to end in disaster. He needs to remember that, make it stick. “You’re right,” Phainon says.

Mydei’s smile is all too smug. “I know.”

They’re already running late. They’ve wasted so much time this morning already, but Phainon is packed and ready, and a little longer can’t hurt. “I want to kiss you or something.”

“‘Or something?’” Mydei repeats.

Phainon exhales. It might be a laugh, it might be a sigh. “I want to kiss you,” he says again, surer. “And I know you already said it’s fine, but it feels weird to just go up and do it, so…”

“So you act all weird,” Mydei finishes for him.

Phainon frowns. “At least I asked, right?”

“Sure,” Mydei tells him, straightening up. He takes a step closer, two, raises his eyebrows when all Phainon can do is hold his breath and stare. “So what’re you afraid of?” he asks. “Scared you suck at it?”

“No!” Phainon says, and falters. “Well, wait, do I? No one’s ever complained, but—”

“Chronic fucking worrier,” Mydei breathes, sighing as he cups Phainon’s cheek. His hand is warm. Phainon cuts off. “You’re fine,” Mydei tells him. “You’re not bad at it, when you aren’t too busy smiling to reciprocate.”

“Oh.” He parts his lips, wets them, notices Mydei looking. “Well, then. You wanna?”

“Shut up,” Mydei says again, but he just sounds fond, and the next moment he’s crossing the last of the space between them and kissing Phainon properly. He makes it feel so easy, soft-mouthed, just a stamp of pressure, his fingers curling in Phainon’s hair. He’s there for maybe three seconds, and there’s a little wet sound as he pulls away, eyelashes kind of long as they flutter open in wake of his amber, red-lined gaze, and oh. Phainon’s eyes have been open this whole time. Based on his snort, Mydei can probably tell.

“Oh, no,” Phainon says when he notes how smug Mydei looks. “You don’t get to hold this over me. I’m going to be so fine and normal about kissing you in the future; you won’t even know what hit you.”

“Sure,” Mydei says, stepping back and absolutely laughing at him. “I look forward to it.”

△

Their last day of driving begins without incident. Mydei goes first, handsome and at ease at the wheel, and they make their way through midday traffic before they’re on the freeway drifting farther and farther away from the city. The longer they drive, the lighter the traffic gets, until they’re cruising comfortably with a handful of other cars forty minutes later. The sun is already high and hot overhead, the air conditioning is blasting, and Phainon is putting the fruits of a sleepless night’s research to the test.

“Hear me out,” he says, pausing the music as the end of the song he’d been playing fades out. His finger hovers over the next one he’d been planning on playing. “You’ve said no to everything else I’ve suggested, so I’m trying to speak your language here.”

Briefly, Mydei glances at him, noticing his phone in hand and scoffing. “Is this about me learning fingerstyle guitar again?” he asks.

“Yes,” Phainon confirms. “But this time, I’ve done research, so you can’t complain that I’ve picked something too hard. *And,* I’ve happened to choose something that I know for a fact that you’ll like.”

“When did you do *research?”*

“I couldn’t sleep last night,” Phainon says. “I put an earbud in; you were fast asleep. *Anyway.”*

“Just play it,” Mydei tells him.

“Behold,” Phainon says in his car commercial voice. He hits play, and the absurdly long fingerstyle intro to this absurdly long song begins. Mydei recognizes it in an instant, if the quirk of his mouth is anything to go by. *“Nothing Else Matters* by *Metallica,* certified by the internet to be a good starting place for a beginner fingerstyle player; certified by my own suffering ears to be Mydei approved. What do you think?”

A sound halfway between sigh and laugh. “You’re really never letting this go, are you?”

“You sent me on this mission, Mydeimos,” Phainon reminds him. “Don’t be upset that I’m following through.”

“I’m not going to sing it.”

“That’s fine.” His mouth twitches. So close to a victory. He just wants to see Mydei excited the way he always is when he gives himself to something. That, and he’s hot when he’s playing the guitar, but Phainon won’t tell him that. “Even just learning the intro is enough for me.”

Mydei takes this deep breath, shakes his head. “Alright,” he says, a little long suffering, a little fond. “I’ll learn it.”

“Delightful,” Phainon says, smiling too wide. His phone buzzes in his hand atop his bouncing leg. He flips it over to see the screen. “It appears I’m receiving a call from my sister. You’ll have to excuse my cutting this short.” With a click, he accepts the call and shuts off the music, putting Cyrene on speaker.

“What convenient timing,” Mydei notes, “just as you turn on a song I like.”

Phainon can’t help but laugh. “Hi, Cyrene,” he says instead of responding.

“Hi,” she says. “I’m waiting to check out of the hospital now.”

“Shit, you’re unhooked and everything?”

“Unhooked and everything,” Cyrene confirms. A bit of shuffling on her end. “Stelle is here to take me home. We’re just waiting for the doctors to sign me out, which is taking forever, by the way. It’s already been forty minutes.”

“I wouldn’t be surprised if they leave you hanging for another hour,” Phainon laughs. “Prompt and timely healthcare in this day and age?”

“Ah, right, silly me,” she says, laughing too, and she might sound freer. Still tired, still sick, but a little better. Phainon can’t imagine spending a week cooped up in the hospital with nothing to do but sleep and feel sick. Going home is probably a light at the end of the tunnel. “Guess I’ll just wait another six hours.”

“You do that,” Phainon tells her. A glance at Mydei shows him listening with the edge of a smile on his face. He never has much to say, not on a call, not even when they’re visiting her in person, but it’s obvious that he cares. There’s something about that… having someone care about the things he does and act like it’s a given, as easy as breathing and as much of a no brainer as the sky and the sea being blue.

He’s lucky, isn’t he? Mydei is good at pretending he’s not, but he’s so *good.* Good to Phainon, good to everyone and everything he cares about. He’d probably hate it if Phainon called him out on that. It would probably piss him off if Phainon called himself lucky for having him, and Phainon loves him for that too.

He clears his throat, addressing Cyrene again. “How are you feeling?”

“Alright,” she answers. “Still pretty exhausted, and I’ve still got all the symptoms, but that’s normal. It’ll take a while for me to *really* feel better, and by then I’ll probably have to start treatment all over, but I’ll happily take fifty percent after a week of zero.”

“I hope you’ll feel better faster than that,” Phainon tells her, bouncing his leg and turning to look out the window in an attempt to not to get emotional again. He doesn’t need to cry twice in one day. He chews on the sores inside of his cheek, watches the sections of the traffic barrier blur together fast enough that his eyes struggle to focus.

“Me too,” Cyrene says. “Going home is enough for now, though. I can’t wait to sleep in my own bed and eat your leftovers and go *outside.”*

He exhales, and it’s like breathing out the weight of the world. “Oh, you’re in for a treat,” he says. “That cobbler Mydei made is amazing. Eat it fast before it goes bad, ‘cause my god…”

Mydei rolls his eyes. “It isn’t *that* special,” he says.

Phainon lets the corners of his mouth curl up. He feels good about this. Mydei by his side. Cyrene recovering, albeit slowly. He hadn’t been able to make sense of a lot of the doctor’s reports, but the count of abnormal cells in her blood is steadily coming down, and while the medication has been killing her healthy cells too, they’ve given her blood transfusions to make up the difference, and she should recover. Given time, her situation looks good, and that doesn’t make the *now* okay, but Phainon could swim in the relief.

Another exhale. Things are good, things are better. He gets to go home too. Sleep with his own blankets, eat Mydei’s cooking, not have to wake up just to drive for ten hours straight. Maybe that cry earlier was good for him.

He looks at Mydei, his profile, the cut of his jaw, his throat. His tattoos, the artful mess of his hair. What made him look at Phainon and decide he wants him? The more he thinks about it, the more absurd it gets. “We had the same cobbler, right?” he asks Mydei, who scoffs and presses his lips into a thin line. Pretending he doesn’t love the praise. God, if he knew how Phainon would drown him in it. “Don’t bother pretending to be humble.”

Cyrene’s laugh through the phone. “I can’t wait to try it,” she says. “I’ll fact check both of you, see who’s lying.”

“Mydei,” Phainon coughs, and reaches for his water. “Ah, excuse me, I think I got something caught in my throat there.”

Mydei offers his middle finger, and Phainon has to swallow quickly before he can risk spitting a mouthful of water as he laughs. “I hate you,” Mydei tells him, but he just laughs a little harder.

“Lying in front of my sister twice, Mydeimos?” he teasing. “You should be ashamed of yourself.”

This makes Cyrene laugh. Mydei told him once that she laughs the same as Phainon does. No matter how he was pressed, he wouldn’t explain what that meant. But her laugh is high and melodic and he misses her in a way that feels more sweet now than bitter. He takes another deep breath. Exhales it fully. “Are you gonna be okay, Cyrene?” he asks.

He can practically hear her smile. Imagines the way her eyes must soften. And then he remembers that his image of her isn’t quite correct anymore. She won’t have that pink hair. Her smile will be the same though, so it doesn’t make him sad to think about it.

“Yes,” she says. “I’m still sick, sure, but I’m getting better, and I’m not alone, remember?”

“Yeah,” he breathes.

“And I get to go home for the first time in a week! I get to go outside! Stelle and Dan Heng are going to be around, it’s fine, it’s good, so stop worrying.”

“It’s chronic,” Mydei and Phainon say at the same time, and Phainon laughs, laughs, laughs until he could cry again.

“But I’m glad,” he says when he’s gotten ahold of himself. “Remember the paperwork.”

“You’re worse than mom was,” Cyrene tells him. “I’m fresh off chemo and still half dead, let me breathe. It’s not like you’re even home yet to do anything with it.”

“But you will?” Phainon asks. She probably rolls her eyes, half a country away.

“Yes,” she says. “I will. And I’m gonna go since Stelle says the doctor is in the hallway. Bye, Phainon, Mydei.”

“Bye,” Phainon says back. “Keep us updated.”

“Bye,” Mydei echoes. He adds, a bit awkwardly, “Good luck with everything.”

“Thank you,” Cyrene says. “See you sometime.”

△

They switch once, Phainon driving after Mydei up until they decide to stop for lunch. They order sub sandwiches, wrapped in paper and easy enough to hold. When they sit down, Phainon bounces his leg and taps his fingernails so much on the table that Mydei asks if he

wants to take a walk as they eat instead of sitting. He's intimately familiar with every one of Phainon's restless tells, and he figures almost five hours in a car is enough to drive anyone crazy, let alone someone who needs to move as much as he does.

"Is that fine?" Phainon asks. "I mean, I guess these wouldn't be too hard to eat standing, but…"

Like walking around a bit is going to inconvenience Mydei in some way. He worries about the strangest things. Mydei was cooped up in that car too. He gets up instead of replying to that, just gathering his stuff and nodding his head. "Let's go."

Phainon bolts upright, grabbing his drink and his sandwich and tucking his chair in with his hip. Wordless, he follows as Mydei leads the way out.

It's still hot, but it's overcast and there are enough trees in the parkstrip to give them some shade as they head onto the sidewalk. Phainon sucks on his straw, fumbles with the paper on his sandwich before pausing. "What if we have a picnic," he says. "It's kind of nice out here, isn't it? Plenty of lawn space and trees…"

"A bit late to set that up," Mydei notes. "But if you want to get your ass wet sitting in the grass I won't stop you."

Phainon hums like he's contemplating this. Their strides are in sync on the sidewalk. Phainon's gray sneakers, Mydei's black boots. Their footsteps sound the same. Phainon falls out of sync to avoid the cracks. "But will you join me in getting my ass wet in the grass?" he asks, looking at Mydei with this dumb smile. His eyes are so stupid blue, and his inner child has always been more of an *outer* child. Mydei likes that, for the most part. Phainon is fun, for all his impulsivity, and nothing he does is ever really *bad.* Maybe Mydei will get his ass wet, but it'll dry, and Phainon will smile. He sighs, pretends to be tired of him. "Dead set on it, are you?"

"Would you rather sit on the sidewalk?" Phainon offers. Mydei laughs, shakes his head. It was one thing, stopping to pet a cat the day before. He can't imagine just sitting down right here to eat their sandwiches. At least in the grass they'll be out of the way.

"Yeah, fuck that," he says, and waves ahead of them, to where they're running out of trees. Six more, and then they'll have to cross the street and walk in the sun. "Pick a tree. We're sitting on dirty clothes if we get muddy."

"It's late enough that it'll have evaporated if they watered in the morning, right?" Phainon asks, guiding them under the next one. It's a slight incline, a dozen steps. They sit facing the street, businesses and parking lots behind them. Cars rush by, and admittedly, he's right. The grass is fairly dry, though it's prickly and Mydei has always had a very mild allergy. His pants will protect him, though, so he figures it's fine.

The crinkle of paper as Phainon unwraps his sandwich. His sits cross-legged, his drink cradled between his legs to keep it stable. It's funny how much calmer he seems, just sitting on the ground outside instead of at a table in the restaurant. He's like this at home too; put

him at a desk and he'll fidget like he'll die if he doesn't. Put him on the floor and he's as happy as can be. Until he starts complaining about back pain an hour later.

"See, this is pretty nice, isn't it?" Phainon asks. "It's cute out here." Suburbs instead of the city or the middle of nowhere. Plenty of trees and green space, not too many people. The breeze whistles through the leaves. Phainon's hair blows into his eyes.

"Sure," Mydei offers, making the mistake of looking at him as he says it. Phainon smiles a little, close-mouthed and soft. Mydei turns away and takes a bite of his sub, watching the cars as he chews.

A buzz. Phainon wrestles his phone out of his pocket and checks it, smiling a little as he reads the text he'd gotten. "Cyrene says you're a liar," he tells Mydei, turning the phone so he can see it. His hand shakes, so Mydei reaches out to steady it. *The cobbler is spectacular, and Mydei is a liar.* Another text sends when he finishes reading the first. Mydei reads it and frowns. *Also, he's so disgustingly in love with you it makes him look stupid.*

"Tell your sister she's a bitch," he says, and watches Phainon's mouth drop open in offense.

"She didn't even—" He pulls the phone back and reads the second text, which startles a laugh out of him and cuts off his words. "Oh," he says, typing something back that he doesn't let Mydei see. "She's a *delight."*

△

They get home late, as expected. The sky is already dark as they pull into Mydei's parking space and slip out of the car to get their things. Phainon yawns as he drags his suitcase out of the trunk, the wheels clacking as he sets it on the asphalt. They're lit with nothing but washed out streetlights. The sprinklers are on this late, watering the scant lawn around the apartment complex and puddling a bit on the sidewalk too. The soft hiss of them serves as their backdrop as Mydei grabs his duffle bag and the last of the snacks. Phainon gets the cooler, and then they're struggling up three flights of stairs, leaving wet footprints as they pass through a puddle.

Phainon yawns again behind him as he unlocks the door, and as they slip inside, he sighs like it's the greatest relief in the world. "Finally," he says, kicking the door shut behind them as Mydei turns on the light. He drops the cooler in the kitchen and pushes his suitcase on its wheels in the direction of his room. "I can still hear the road."

"Me too," Mydei says, breathing in. It's always strange coming back after a long time. It's the only time he ever knows what home smells like. Old paint and laundry, or something like it. He heads to his room to drop off his bag and has to fight the urge to collapse into bed in his sweaty clothes. He's so goddamn tired. It's barely ten at night but he's exhausted like it's three in the morning. He needs a shower. He needs to not go to work tomorrow or the week after, just to recover from this.

The pipes start to groan. That loose washer screams through the walls as Phainon beats him to it. "That bastard," he murmurs, squatting to unzip his bag and dump all his dirty laundry in

his hamper. Better he does this now, because he'll only procrastinate more and more if he waits. It only takes him a handful of minutes anyway.

He leaves his toiletries and something to change into on the bed to take to the bathroom when Phainon's done, and then he sighs and drags himself to the kitchen to deal with the cooler. There isn't much in there but a few leftover drinks, a single orange, and one last piece of the fruit cobbler he made wrapped in a plastic bag that must've gotten a hole in it, because there's water inside and it's all soggy from the melted ice in the cooler. He sighs and tosses it, then dumps the rest of the ice and water into the sink. He doesn't touch the bag of snacks; he'll leave that to Phainon when he comes out.

A handful of long minutes. The water finally stops running, the pipes stop groaning. Phainon comes out in his towel, probably having forgotten his clothes for the hundredth time. His bedroom door shuts behind him, and Mydei yawns into his hand before putting the last of his energy to this. A shower of his own before he takes a much needed rest.

The floor is wet. Phainon has dripped all over and didn't bother to clean it up. He never does, but Mydei is much too tired to care. He showers in water near scalding, using his own soaps for the first time in what feels like ages. He brushes his teeth when he gets out, and when he finally lays down, uncaring of his wet hair, dressed in a pair of plain black sweats, it's the best goddamn feeling in the world. He shuts his eyes and breathes just like that, then realizes he'll have to get back up to turn off the light.

And then there's Phainon in the doorway wearing green shorts and a loose, stained white shirt. He's rubbing one of his eyes, dead on his feet.

"Hey," he says.

"Turn off the light," Mydei tells him, and he laughs but does, and they're swathed in darkness. He can't see a thing with his eyes unadjusted, but he can finally relax, and *that* might be the best goddamn feeling. The mattress dips and the sheets rustle as Phainon climbs in beside him.

"Scoot," he says, bumping Mydei's leg, and Mydei scoots. Phainon settles in next to him, warm and smelling like himself. He sighs softly, pulling on one of Mydei's pillows. "Nice to be back, isn't it?" he asks.

There's nothing to see but dark, vague impressions here and there. Mydei closes his eyes, laying atop the covers, heavy with exhaustion. His breath is slow, even. "Mhm," he manages. Phainon lets out this tiny laugh that bleeds into a yawn. Just the sound of it is contagious, and Mydei yawns too. "Let me under the blanket," he grumbles, so together they shuffle around until they manage to wrestle it from underneath themselves. As it settles over his shoulders, Mydei changes his mind. *This* is the best goddamn feeling in the world.

Phainon's foot brushes his shin. The sheets whisper as he slides closer, the blanket over him too, now. "Hey," he whispers. His fingers curl lightly over Mydei's wrist. They're close enough to share air, face to face on their sides.

“Did you brush your teeth?” Mydei asks him, though his words kind of stumble and stick together.

“Yes,” Phainon answers, fingers tightening. “Would you…” A huff. He pulls on Mydei’s arm until he gets the memo, lifting it so Phainon can slide closer, his hand on Mydei’s bare back, head tucking under his chin. His hair tickles, cold and still damp from his shower, but the rest of him is so warm, and maybe it should be annoying that he’s here while Mydei is trying to fall asleep, but for some reason it’s nice instead.

“Better?” Mydei mumbles. He knows how awkward it is to have to ask someone to hold you. He sets his hand on Phainon’s hip, up his side until it finds a comfortable spot belted around his waist.

“Yeah,” Phainon tells him. His fingertips swirl and skim and trace patterns on his spine, and that tickles too. Mydei shifts until he stops, and then they settle again. Pressed close in the dark, neither with much left to say. They’ve already spent the last week breathing each other’s air. Maybe they could talk about Cyrene or Phainon’s hometown and his family and whatever else has been bothering him, but it isn’t the right time for it. Right now is just for this. They’re too tired to bother with much else until morning anyway.

His cheek against Phainon’s wet hair. Careful, not trying to poke his eyes out in the dark, Mydei brushes Phainon’s bangs back, feeling carefully over the shell of his ear down his face. His hand is cold, out of the covers. The line of Phainon’s jaw is surprisingly sharp. He’s probably so stupidly, unfairly pretty. Mydei is so tired. “Are your eyes closed?” he asks.

“No,” Phainon says. “Well… They are now.”

“Keep them that way,” Mydei tells him, filled with this dumb feeling. With gentle fingers, he finds the corner of Phainon’s eye. He can feel his own heartbeat, pounding in his chest.

“What’re you doing?” Phainon breathes.

It would be easier to just fall asleep like this. To ignore whatever this feeling is, but Phainon… Mydei’s already established that he would go to the end of the country and back for him. He’d do so many things at the cost of so much, if only Phainon wanted it. He sucks in a careful breath and holds Phainon still as he kisses his eyes, each one in turn, so lightly it can hardly be considered a kiss at all. His eyelids flutter, and his eyelashes tickle a bit. It feels like he’s holding his breath.

When he’s done, Mydei settles back into his pillows, his hand on the back of Phainon’s head, tangled in his wet hair and guiding him close. “That was on your list, wasn’t it?” he murmurs. Phainon lets out something that might be a laugh, but it’s all air.

“Yeah,” he says, his forehead pressing into Mydei’s shoulder. “Yeah. It was.” He’s soft all over. Mydei doesn’t want to give him up to the world tomorrow. He knows he’s fine, that he isn’t hurting as much as he was, that he’s happy, but he still carries so much, and always will. Mydei can only hope he won’t make himself carry it all alone.

“Hey,” Phainon whispers. He pokes at Mydei’s ribs, and that tickles too until his hand goes flat. “Can I stay here tonight?”

“You’ve already made yourself at home,” Mydei points out, stifling another yawn. He runs his fingers through Phainon’s damp hair, tugging lightly on the ends.

“Maybe you’re sick of me,” Phainon says. His foot is shaking. “Maybe you were looking forward to finally having the bed to yourself.”

He wraps his arm firm around Phainon’s shoulders. “Shouldn’t you have asked *before* you climbed in if you were worried about that?”

“You let me,” Phainon whispers.

A grunt. “Do you think I wouldn’t kick you out if I wanted to?”

“Yeah, actually,” Phainon admits. “I do think that.”

Mydei makes an unhappy sound. Holds tighter in case he decides he wants to leave now. “Don’t grow a fucking ego,” he grumbles. “I would, and I will if you don’t shut up. You’re the one that struggles to sleep; why aren’t *you* excited to have the bed to yourself?”

Phainon laughs a little, his breath on Mydei’s throat. He’s so warm, palms sticky with sweat on Mydei’s back. Always so goddamn sweaty. His foot is still bouncing. “I guess I got used to having you by my side,” he says.

Mydei’s mouth against his temple. He traps Phainon’s foot under his own until it stills, though he knows he’ll just start moving something else in a handful of seconds instead. “Clingy,” he murmurs.

“Oh you want to talk about clinginess now, do you?” Phainon asks, prodding him again. He’s caught on to the fact that between the two of them, Mydei is the one with doglike loyalty.

“Just shut up,” he says, half asleep already. “Goodnight, Phainon. We have work tomorrow.”

“Don’t remind me.”

Mydei grunts back, shifting a little until he’s comfortable with the way they fit. “At least we’re home,” he murmurs, his arm around Phainon’s shoulders, Phainon’s around his waist. Their legs tangle. Phainon turns his ear to his chest. Hums, softly.

“I can hear your heartbeat,” he breathes.

Mydei blows on his hair, eyes stubbornly shut. “What am I even supposed to reply to that?”

A weak laugh. “I don’t know. It sounded romantic in my head.”

“Just go to sleep,” Mydei grumbles. They’re quiet for a breath, two.

“I love you,” Phainon tells him. Mydei’s too tired for his heart to flutter.

“Yeah, yeah,” he says into the pillow. “I love you too. Now shut up.”

Chapter End Notes

we've reached the end!! I'm more of a one shot kind of guy so whenever I write something longer like this I end up very very attached... oh how I'm going to miss this universe :')

some notes: Cyrene was supposed to die in the initial plan for the fic, but the more I wrote the less it made sense... I wanted to do more with Phainon's grief, but oh well. (the scene I created this entire fic around never got written -_-) his voice lines were very much the basis of his characterization in the later chapters; bro has at least three about the wheat fields in Aedes Elysiae... what a dreadfully nostalgic creature... also tell me why I yawned writing about them yawning and again proofreading them yawning and again now writing this note about yawning

lastly, to everyone who's gotten this far, whether you've been reading since day one or just now, thank you for your time, attention, and comments and kudos if you've chosen to bless me with them. I appreciate all of it so so much and I hope you enjoyed at least a little <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!